

# **Lytton to Maulana Azad Library**

**Vision and Mission**

**By**

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## **Prayer**

اللهم انفعني بما علمتني وعلمني ما ينفعني وارزقني علما تنفعني به

**‘O Allaah benefit me with what You have taught me, and  
teach me that which will benefit me, and grant me knowledge  
which will benefit me.’**

*Dedicated to:*

*Sir Syed Ahmad Khan (1817- 1899)*

*The Founder of MAO College (1877),*

*Transformed into Aligarh Muslim University (1920): The Mecca of Aligs*

## About the Author



Prof. Shababat Husain is a distinguished scholar in Library and Information Science, with over four decades of service at Aligarh Muslim University (AMU). He earned his M.Sc., B.Lib.Sc., and M.Lib.Sc. with first-class distinction, followed by an M.Phil. in Information Technology from Loughborough University, England (under the Commonwealth Programme), and a Ph.D. from Lucknow University.

At AMU, he served as Chairman of the Department for 12 years, University Librarian for 4 years, and Dean of the Faculty of Social Sciences for one full term. He also held key administrative roles including Acting Vice-Chancellor, Provost, and Officer on Special Duty.

Beyond AMU, Prof. Husain was entrusted with several **prestigious national responsibilities:**

- Member of the **Search Committee for Director**, INFLIBNET (UGC)
- **UGC Expert Committee** Member for accreditation of C.U. Shah University
- **Govt of India nominee on the** Governing Body of **Khuda Baksh Oriental Public Library, Patna** (Ministry of Culture)
- **Govt of India nominee** on the Governing Body of **Allahabad Museum** (Ministry of Culture)
- Member of the **University Court, Allahabad University (MHRD nominee)**
- Governing Body Member of Raja Ram Mohan Roy Library Foundation, Kolkata
- Governor's nominee on selection committees of several state universities

Prof. Husain represented India in his subject internationally, presenting papers and chairing sessions at conferences held in **Canada, Spain, Sweden, Germany, Singapore**, and India. He also taught at the University of Maiduguri, Nigeria. Prof. Husain organised several National and International conferences and chaired scores of plenary sessions in India and abroad.

A **prolific author**, he has written **8 books and over 50 research articles**. Notable works include **Library Classification (Tata McGraw Hill)**, **Dewey Decimal**

**Classification (translated into Arabic at Al-Azhar University, Cairo), and two recent volumes on Knowledge Management Systems (Emerald, 2021; Routledge, 2025). He has supervised 12 M.Phil./Ph.D. scholars and is the Founding Editor of the Collnet Journal of Information Management and Scientometrics (Taylor & Francis, UK).**

**Under his leadership, the Dept. was awarded the prestigious Special Assistance Programme, SAP (DRS-I) by UGC for 5 years.**

**Awards and Honours:** Prof. Husain was elected unopposed as **President of the Indian Library Association (2016–19)**, where his recommendations on librarians' pay scales were incorporated into the 7th Pay Commission. His contributions have earned him multiple honours, including the **Prof. S.P. Narang Research Promotion Award (2014) and Lifetime Achievement Awards** from Satija Research Foundation (2017), Asian Library Association (2020), and Indian Library Association (2023).

Prof. Husain's most **pioneering projects** include the **Social Science Cyber Library (First in the world)** (inaugurated by the President of India in 2013, **ISO-certified, and listed in the LIMCA Book of Records**).

His other projects worth mentioning are: the **Knowledge Management System Portal** ([www.libraryknowledgemanagement.org](http://www.libraryknowledgemanagement.org)) and the **Indian Library Association website** ([www.ilaindia.net](http://www.ilaindia.net)).

## *Preface*

*Engr. Mujeeb Akhtar, originally from Aligarh and now settled in Kuwait, is a man of refined literary taste and deep admiration for those who have excelled in their fields. Through his YouTube program “Kehkashan ke Sitare”, he has provided a platform for such voices to share their journeys. It was through this initiative that he graciously invited me — a comparatively small figure in the vast galaxy of Aligs — to share my experiences. My interview was aired on 22 March 2025, where I spoke about the challenges and responsibilities I faced as Librarian-in-Charge of the Maulana Azad Library (2004–2008).*

*The response was overwhelming. Many of my students abroad approached me directly, while Aligs abroad — especially from the USA and Canada — conveyed their request through the program’s anchor, Engr. Mujeeb Akhtar. They urged me to write a book on the Maulana Azad Library, an institution regarded as one of the most iconic and largest libraries in the subcontinent. Their appeal made me reflect deeply. I realised that while the history of the Aligarh Movement and the AMU has been documented extensively, the library dimension of this history remains largely unexplored.*

*When I began delving into the subject, I found very little literature available. This absence convinced me to broaden the scope of my work — not only to trace the institutional journey of the library but also to highlight the individual contributions of unsung heroes who shaped it into its present form. These figures, often forgotten by successive generations of Aligs, deserve rightful recognition.*

*This book seeks to fill that void. It aims to restore dignity to those overlooked contributors, while also serving as a guide for students of the Aligarh Library School. By consolidating the past with the present, it hopes to provide direction for the future development of the Maulana Azad Library, while also addressing the long-pending issues that remain unresolved to this day.*

*Thanks to everyone who has been part of this journey.*

*October, 2026*

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## **Chapter 1**

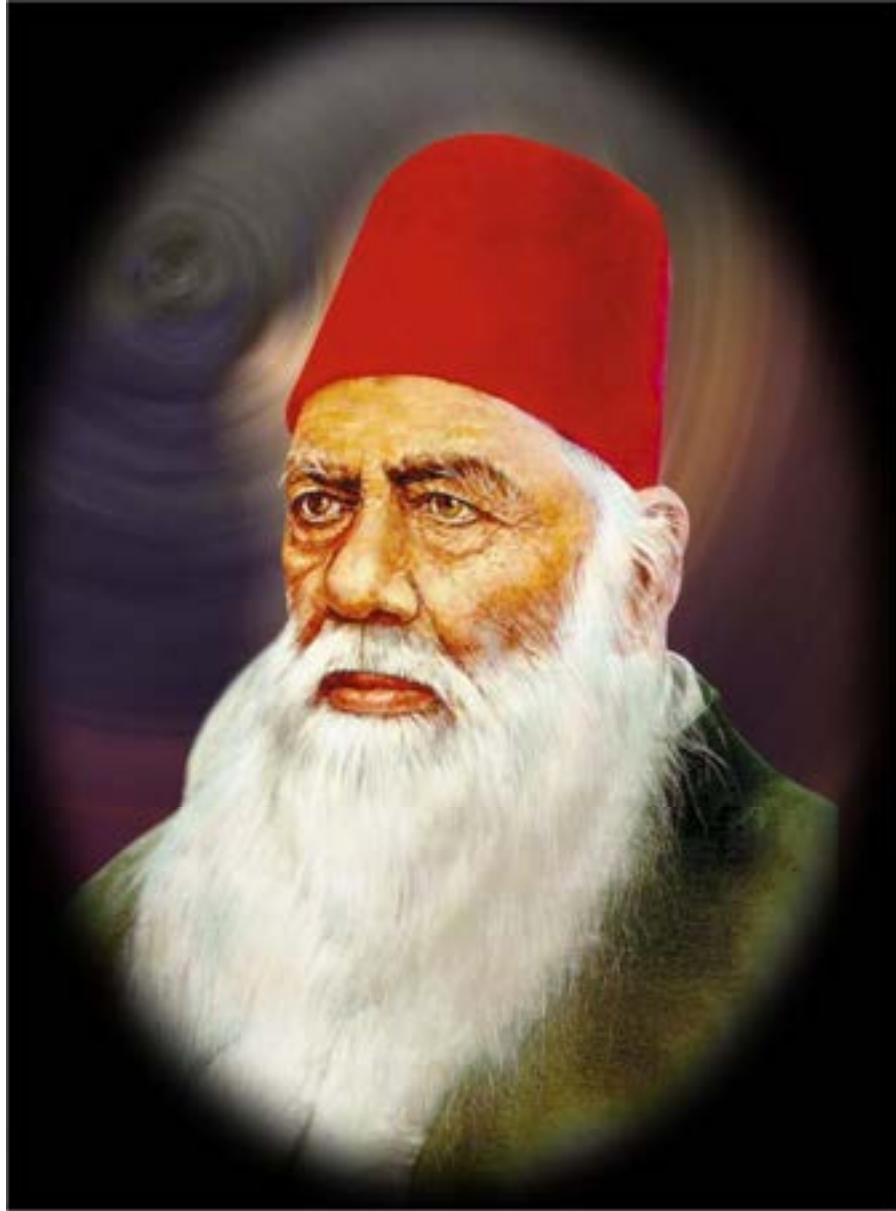
### **Lytton Library and Khalifa Mohammad Asadullah**

#### **1. Sir Syed Ahmad Khan: His Life and Mission**

Sir Syed Ahmad Khan (1817–1898) stands as one of the foremost reformers of modern India, remembered for his vision of education, rational thought, and social upliftment of Muslims. Born in Delhi into a cultured family connected with the Mughal court, he grew up in an atmosphere of refinement and learning. In 1838, he entered the service of the East India Company and rose to become a judge in the judicial department. Alongside his official duties, he wrote extensively, producing works such as *Asar-us-Sanadid*, a study of Delhi's monuments, and religious tracts in Urdu that reflected his deep interest in history and theology. The Revolt of 1857 proved to be a turning point in his life. Witnessing the devastation and the mistrust between the British and Indian Muslims, Sir Syed realised that the community's survival depended on embracing modern education and rational thought. His pamphlet *The Causes of the Indian Revolt* boldly criticised British policies, yet he remained convinced that cooperation with the colonial government was essential for Muslim progress.

Sir Syed's mission crystallised in the founding of the Scientific Society in 1863, which translated modern works into Urdu and promoted rational inquiry. But his greatest achievement came with the establishment of *Madarsatul Uloom Musammanan-e-Hind* at Aligarh on 24 May 1875. This modest school soon grew into the Muhammadan Anglo-Oriental (MAO) College in 1877, patterned after Oxford and Cambridge universities. Sir Syed's objective was clear: to build a college in line with the British education system, emphasising science and modern subjects, but without compromising Islamic values. He envisioned an institution where students could harmonise tradition with modernity, studying English and science alongside Islamic learning.

The MAO College became the nucleus of what came to be known as the Aligarh Movement, producing a new generation of Muslim leaders, scholars, and professionals who were equipped to engage with the challenges of colonial India. It embodied Sir Syed's conviction that education was the key to empowerment, and that Muslims could only regain their rightful place in society by embracing modern knowledge without abandoning their faith. His vision was to create an education system modelled after the British framework to enhance their proficiency in English and the sciences for Indians in general and Muslims in particular. This modern education system aimed to foster a political force capable of influencing Indian society.



**Sir Syed Ahmad Khan (1817-1898)**

Knighted in 1888 and honoured internationally, Sir Syed devoted his life to harmonising faith with reason. His life was thus a blend of scholarship, reform, and vision. His mission was not merely academic but civilizational—ensuring Muslims adapted to modernity while preserving their cultural and religious identity. His life was thus a blend of scholarship, reform, and vision. Sir Syed's mission was not merely academic but civilizational—ensuring Muslims adapted to modernity while preserving their cultural and religious identity.

He also worked to improve the status of women through enhanced education. Sir Syed Ahmad Khan believed in the fundamental unity of religions and preached the common interests of Hindus and Muslims. Sir Syed aimed to establish a distinct socio-cultural identity for Muslims along modern lines, by advocating a liberal interpretation of the Quran aimed at harmonising Islam with modern liberal culture. His progressive social ideas were disseminated through his magazine "Tahdhib-ul-Akhlaq" (Improvement of Manners and Morals).

His lifelong interest in religion manifested in several volumes of a modernist commentary on the Qur'an. In addition, he also began a sympathetic interpretation of the Bible and its teachings, intending to explain them in the context of Islam. This work was published in Urdu and English in three parts from 1862 to 1865 under the title \*Tabin al-al-kalam Fi tafsir altawrat Wa 'l-injil'ala millat al Islam\* (Elucidation of the World in Commentary of the Torah and Gospel According to the Religion of Islam).

Sir Syed was deeply distressed by Muir's portrayal of Islam and the character of the Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) in his four-part book, 'The Life of Mahomet', published in 1864. He was concerned that this book might create doubts among the younger generation of Muslims. To prepare for a response, he accompanied his son to England to gain firsthand insight into Western civilization.

In 1869, he wrote \*Al-Khutbat al-Ahmadiya fi'l Arab wa'l Sirat al-Muhammadiya\* (A Series of Essays on the Life of Prophet Muhammad and Other Subsidiary Subjects) as a counter to Muir's aforementioned work.

Ultimately, his dedication to the cause of education defined him as a person. Some of his important publications include:

1. Asbab Baghawat e Hind
2. Selected Essays by Sir Sayyid Ahmad Khan
3. Tareekh-e-Firoz Shahi
4. Asar-Us-Sanadid
5. Life of Muhammad
6. Mazameen e Sir Syed Ahmed Khan: Intikhab
7. A Voyage to Modernism

8. Musafir-e-London

9. History of Bijnor Rebellion

10. Review on Dr. Hunter's Indian Musalman's: Are They Bound in Conscience to Rebel Against the Queen?

11. Khutbat-e-Ahmadiya

Sir Syed Ahmad Khan was truly a transformative figure in Indian history, known for his pioneering efforts in modern education and social reform among Indian Muslims. His legacy, particularly through the establishment of the Muhammadan Anglo-Oriental College—later becoming Aligarh Muslim University—continues to inspire generations. Despite his struggles with health, his final years in Aligarh were marked by his relentless commitment to education and enlightenment. He breathed his last on 27 March 1898.

His burial within the premises of the university he founded signifies how deeply intertwined his life was with his mission. His influence shaped not just entrepreneurs but leaders, scholars, and visionaries who carried forward his ideals. His contributions remain monumental in the socio-educational landscape of India.

His legacy endures in the transformation of MAO College into Aligarh Muslim University (AMU) in 1920, ensuring that his mission continued to shape South Asian Muslim identity and education long after his lifetime. The Aligarh Movement successfully garnered support by collecting funds through generous donations from the Maharajas and Nawabs of the time, as well as from British governors. Having fulfilled a prerequisite of raising Rs 30 lakh, the Government of India officially established Aligarh Muslim University through an Act of Parliament in 1920.

Today, the university offers over 300 courses across various traditional and modern fields of study. It has more than 37,327 students, 1,686 teachers and some 5,610 non-teaching staff on its rolls. The University now has 13 faculties comprising 117 teaching departments, 3 academies and 21 centres and institutes. A special feature of the University is its residential character with most of the staff and students residing on the campus. There are 19 halls of residence for students with 80 hostels.<sup>1</sup>

The Aligarh Muslim University, along with Banaras Hindu University and Delhi University, was declared as an Institute of National Importance through Entry No. 63 in the Union List, Seventh Schedule to the Constitution of India.

## **2. Foundation of Lytton Library**

Aligarh Muslim University (AMU), established in 1920, traces its origins to the Madarsatul Uloom, founded in 1875, which in a short period of time grew into a MAO

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<sup>1</sup> [www.amu.ac.in](http://www.amu.ac.in) (Accessed on 28-4-2026)



**Edward Robert Bulwer-Lytton, Viceroy of India (1876-1880)**

College in 1877. Similarly, the present central library of the University has evolved from the MAO College Library, the foundation stone of which was laid on January 8, 1877, along with other adjacent buildings by Edward Robert Bulwer-Lytton, then Viceroy of India (1876-1880). The event took place in the presence of members of the MAO College Fund Committee, with Sir Syed Ahmad Khan serving as its Honorary Secretary.

During the foundation-laying ceremony, Sir Syed announced that the central college library would be named “the Lytton Library” in honour of Lord Lytton, who held the position of the Viceroy of India until 1880.

Lytton, a literary figure himself, appreciated the gesture of the founder and remarked:

“A library is the best society to which any man can be admitted, for it is an assemblage of the world’s greatest benefactors—the wise and the good of all ages. Here live those who are worthy to live. I esteem it a privilege to lay the foundation of a building under whose sheltering roof the number of such worthies is likely to increase.”

From the outset, Sir Syed envisioned the college as a stepping stone toward a future university. He eloquently remarked, “The College may expand into a University whose sons shall go forth throughout the length and breadth of the land to preach the gospel of free inquiry, largehearted tolerance, and pure morality.” Sir Syed developed the blueprint for the modern educational system he envisioned in London. He had a clear idea of the basic layout of the college—a self-contained quadrangle comprising classrooms, living accommodations, a dining room, a library, and a mosque.

In 1872, the British Principal of Roorkee College declined the invitation to serve as the architect for the college in Aligarh. Consequently, Sir Syed took direct responsibility for planning the buildings and supervising their construction. While the Public Works Department (PWD) reviewed plans for most structures built on government land, the college employed a full-time Supervisor for construction. Despite this, it was Sir Syed himself who conceptualized and finalized the Indo-British architectural designs of the college buildings, occasionally seeking assistance from Mr. Scotland, a lecturer at Thomson College of Civil Engineering (now IIT Roorkee).

Bhatnagar<sup>2</sup> notes “Sir Syed paid special attention to the program of construction of buildings. He would often stay on the site all day long in the extreme Summer heat, supervising stone machinery, sinking of wells, laying of foundations and raising of structures. He prepared plans for the expansion of the college building. The fund committee reviewed the construction program on July 29 1877. It was decided that the

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<sup>2</sup> Bhatnagar, S.K.. History of The M.A.O.College, Aligarh. Sir Syed Hall, Aligarh Muslim University, Asia Publishing House. 1969. P. 66

construction plans estimated at rupees 2,10,000, of which the government was expected to meet half."



**Lytton Library**

Despite the progress, an excerpt from Aligarh Monthly (July 1906) highlights construction delays: " There is slackness in building construction. The flooring of the Lytton Library is still incomplete, and nothing has been done to the Union Building."

Before departing Aligarh, Lord Lytton presented Sir Syed with a portrait of himself and several of his books as a token of appreciation. The construction of the Lytton library was completed in 1908.

### **3. Lytton Library Collection**

The library collection began with the personal library of Sir Syed Ahmad Khan himself, which served as an auspicious nucleus for the future growth and development of the library vis-à-vis the institution.

### 3.1 Beck's Collection

Bhatnagar<sup>3</sup> notes that Mr. H.G.I. Siddon, headmaster of the MAO School, became the first principal of the college in January 1877. However, he resigned on August 28, 1883, due to health reasons. Following his departure, Mr. Theodore Beck was appointed Principal of MAO College upon the recommendation of Syed Mahmood from England. Beck held the position from February 1, 1884, until his passing on September 2, 1899.

In 1888, Beck's parents, along with Mrs. Beck and Miss Beck, travelled to India and visited the college on November 30. A dinner was hosted in their honour, attended by students and staff. During the visit, Mr Beck's father pledged to send a collection of books and a clock from London as a gift to MAO College. While the books arrived promptly, the clock was delayed, reaching India in November 1893, after his passing in April 1892. As a token of appreciation, Sir Syed presented a silver flower vase to commemorate Mr. Beck's visit to the college.

### 3.2 Donations of books under Mr. J.H. Towle (1909-1919)

During the tenure of Mr. J.H. Towle, the last British Principal of MAO College, the library's collection grew significantly through various donations<sup>4</sup>:

1. **1910** – Syed Zainuddin, Deputy Collector, donated the entire library of his late father, Syed Zain-ul Abidin.
2. **1913** – H.E. Agha Khan gifted a set of 500 books, primarily in Persian and Arabic.
3. **1916** – Mirza Ashiq Husain, Assistant Manager at Rambagh Tea Estate, donated a collection of 214 books on History and Philosophy.
4. **1917** – The heirs of the late Mr. Aziz Mirza donated their father's entire library under the condition that the collection be preserved separately and labeled as Majmua-i-Kutub Maulvi Aziz Mirza Marhum.

By 1918, the library's holdings had reached 15,500 books, of which 9,500 were in English. That same year, Dr. Wali Muhammad oversaw the installation of electric lighting in the library.

### 4. Library Challenges and Reforms<sup>5</sup>

Despite the growing collection, the library fell into a state of disrepair by 1918, with many books missing. To address these concerns, **Mr K.M. Asadullah**, Librarian of Government College, Lahore, was invited to inspect the library and propose

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<sup>3</sup> Bhatnagar, S.K.. History of The M.A.O.College, Aligarh. Sir Syed Hall, Aligarh Muslim University, Asia Publishing House. 1969. P. 150

<sup>4</sup> Bhatnagar, S.K.. History of The M.A.O.College, Aligarh. Sir Syed Hall, Aligarh Muslim University, Asia Publishing House. 1969, P. 298

<sup>5</sup> Bhatnagar, S.K.. History of The M.A.O.College, Aligarh. Sir Syed Hall, Aligarh Muslim University, Asia Publishing House. 1969, P. 332



improvements. His key recommendation was the immediate adoption of the **Dewey Decimal Classification system** to organise the library efficiently.

### **K.M. Asadullah, First Librarian of Lytton Library <sup>6</sup>**

Following the inspection report, several administrative changes were made, including the removal of Maulvi Ihteshamuddin, Assistant Librarian. Eminent scholars like Gardner Brown, Arnold, Releigh, Horowitz, Storey and Auchtelphone functioned as honorary librarians in addition to their teaching responsibilities. Subsequently, the M.A.O. College, Aligarh, made a formal request to K.M. Asadullah in 1919 to offer his services for reorganising the growing library collection. Mr K.M. Asadullah was appointed Librarian of Lytton Library on July 25, 1919, marking the beginning of much-needed reforms.

Mr K.M. Asadullah was a pioneer of the library movement in the Indian subcontinent before 1947. After completing his graduation from Forman Christian College, Lahore, in 1913, he chose Library Science as his profession. In 1915, when Asa Don Dickinson, an American librarian, was invited to reorganise the Punjab University Library, he started the University Library Training Classes as well. Asadullah was among the students who attended the training course and obtained a certificate with distinction. He was the first Indian to receive the diploma of the Library Association from London. In 1916, he became the first qualified librarian of Government College, Lahore. He served as the librarian of MAO College until 1921, when he joined the Imperial Secretariat Library in New Delhi and Simla, a post he held for eight years.

In 1930, he was appointed as both the Librarian and Director of the Imperial Library (now the National Library of India) in Calcutta, a position he held for 17 years, from 1930 to 1947. He was the first and the only Muslim who had the honour of occupying that coveted position. During his tenure, he initiated the library training program as well. In 1933, he became one of the founding members of the Indian Library Association and served as its first secretary from 1933 to 1947. He was honoured with the title of Khan Bahadur in 1935. After migrating to Pakistan in 1947, he was appointed as an 'officer on special duty' in the Ministry of Education. On 23 November 1949, he passed away in Lahore, Pakistan, following a stroke.

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<sup>6</sup> Khalifa Mohammad Asadullah - Wikipedia Accessed on 27 April, 2025



**Khalifa Mohammad Asadullah (1890-1949)**

## 5. Celebrated Visitors

Inspired by the traditions of Oxford and Cambridge Universities, Sir Syed established an 'Institution of Visitors' at the school. As a result, several distinguished personalities of the time visited the MAO School and College. Below is a record of some of these notable visits.

### 5.1 Celebrated Visitors of the MAO School (1875-1877)

1. Sir William Muir (1819-1905), a Scottish Orientalist and Lieutenant Governor of the Northwestern Provinces of British India (1868-1874), visited the MAO School with Lady Muir on 12 November 1875. In his honour, a white stone memorial remains intact at the Faiz Gate of the University. He visited the school once again in October 1876.
2. Maharaja Rajinder Singh of Patiala (1872-1900), accompanied by his Chief Minister Khalifa Mohammad Hasan, paid a visit to the school on 6 December 1875. He announced a grant of Rs. 1,800/- per annum. He was appointed the first Visitor of the institution.

### 5.2 Celebrated Visitors of the MAO College (1877-1919)

1. **Syed Ahmed Khulusi Effendi**, the Ambassador of Turkey, visited the College on 8 November **1877**.
2. **Sir Richard Temple** (1826-1902), Governor of Bombay (1877-1880), paid a flying visit to the College on 12 January **1878**.
3. **Sir John Strachey** (1823-1907), the Lt. Governor of North West Provinces (1874-1876), paid a farewell visit on the eve of his retirement from ICS on 10 December **1880**.
4. **Sir Alfred Lyall** (1835-1911), Lt. Governor of North West Provinces, (1882-1887), visited the College on 5 February 1883 and declared open the newly constructed classrooms.
5. **Sir John Edge** (1841-1926), the first Vice-Chancellor of Allahabad University (1887-1893), visited the College after its affiliation on 1 January **1888**, on the occasion of the anniversary of the Siddons Union Club.
6. **Sir Asman Jah Bahadur** (1845-1922), Prime Minister of Hyderabad (1887-1894), visited the College on 24 July **1888**.
7. **Lord Curzon** (1859-1925), the Viceroy of India (1899-1905), visited MAO College on 23 April **1901**.
8. **Albert Edward, Prince of Wales** (1841-1910) and Emperor of India (1901-1910), visited MAO College along with the Princess on 8 March **1906**. The royal visit was a grand occasion for the college. Upon their arrival at Aligarh at 1:00 p.m., the distinguished guests were welcomed with a red carpet reception at the railway station,

led by H.H. Agha Khan and Sir James Latouche, Lieutenant Governor of the United Provinces.

Their journey continued straight to the college through Zahur Gate, where the pakka quadrangle had been transformed into a beautifully decorated garden. The Lytton Library, still under construction, was prepared as the banqueting hall, while the Nizam Museum was elegantly furnished as a retiring room for the royal visitors.

The royal guests enjoyed lunch at the Lytton Library, accompanied by H.H. Agha Khan and Lt. Governor Sir James Latouche. Later that evening, a grand dinner was hosted in their honour, attended by 200 distinguished guests.

The event was further marked by a brilliant speech delivered by Nawab Mohsin-ul-Mulk, who captivated the audience with his eloquence. He concluded his oration with a Persian couplet:

نمی گویم دریں گلشن گل و باغ و بهار از من  
بهار از یار و باغ از یار و گل از یار و یار از من م

(I do not say that the flowers and the bloom of this garden are due to me. The spring is due to my friend, the garden and the flowers are also due to him, and the friend is mine.)

## Chapter 2

### Maulana Azad Library and Padamshree Syed Bashiruddin Ahmad

#### 1. Introduction

The institution began modestly as a school in 1875, soon evolving into the **Mohammedan Anglo-Oriental (MAO) College in 1877**. Its transformation reached a historic milestone when, through an **Act of Parliament in 1920**, it was declared a full-fledged university called **Aligarh Muslim University** — the 10th University of India. This Act not only recognised its academic stature but also enshrined its unique mission: to blend modern scientific education with the preservation of Islamic values and cultural identity.

By the **1940s and 1950s**, the University's rapid growth in student enrolment, faculty strength, and academic disciplines placed **immense pressure on the Lytton Library**, which struggled to keep pace with the triangular increase in books, students, and staff. To address these spatial constraints, the Government of India sanctioned funds for expansion, marking a new chapter in AMU's academic infrastructure.

On 12 November 1955, Prime **Minister Jawaharlal Nehru laid the foundation stone** of the new library building, using a ceremonial silver trowel — a treasured artefact still preserved in the Manuscript Division of the Library, engraved with the date of its foundation. The completed building was **inaugurated by Pandit Nehru himself on 6 December 1960**. To the best of my knowledge, it was at his suggestion that the library was named the Maulana Azad Library, in tribute to Maulana Abul Kalam Azad (1888–1958) — a revered scholar, freedom fighter, India's first Education Minister, and a visionary who championed universal education.

Today, the Maulana Azad Library stands as a symbol of AMU's journey from a small school to a national university, embodying both its intellectual heritage and its commitment to modern scholarship.

#### 2. **Padamshree Syed Bashiruddin Ahmad (1902-1984):** A connecting link between Lytton and M.A. Library

Syed Bashiruddin Ahmed was a distinguished library professional and an outstanding administrator whose contribution to the development of libraries in India, particularly at Aligarh Muslim University (AMU), remains unforgettable.

Born in Cuttack (Orissa) in 1902, he passed his High School in First Division before joining the Mohammedan Anglo-Oriental College, Aligarh in 1919. Financial



**Maulana Abul Kalam Azad (1888-1958)**

constraints compelled him to work as a Laboratory Assistant in the Chemistry Department while continuing his studies privately, completing his Intermediate in 1921. He joined the **Lytton Library as Assistant Librarian in 1922**. His academic pursuit never waned: he earned his B.A. (1923) and M.A. in Philosophy (1926), and later, at the behest of the University, undertook a **Certificate Course in Library Science at the University of London (1932)**. On his return, he assumed the charge of the University Library, still the Lytton Library.

Photographs from the laying of the foundation stone of the Maulana Azad Library in 1955 and its inauguration by Pt. Jawaharlal Nehru in 1960 testify to his deep involvement in its planning and organisation. The infrastructure he established provided a strong foundation, much of which continues to guide the library's functioning, even as it has evolved from manual to automated systems in recent decades.

He retired from AMU on April 30, 1961, but returned in 1967 under a UGC scheme for three years. In the interim period, he served in many positions in India, such as **Director of Libraries, Jammu & Kashmir, Head of Department and University Librarian at Jaipur University, and subsequently as University Librarian and ex-officio Head of the Department at Delhi University** (May 1966-August 1967).

His vision extended beyond administration. In 1950–51, he introduced the **Certificate Course in Library Science at AMU**. He, along with the Senior staff of the MA Library, used to take classes in the library's cultural Hall, where it remained until 1995. The course proved so popular that after a few years, the University decided to run two courses a year. The course's popularity led to its expansion, and in 1958–59, he pioneered the **Bachelor of Library Science program** with full time lecturers, for the first time in India. The certificate course was eventually discontinued in 1968–69 as more advanced programs emerged to meet professional demand.

Syed Bashiruddin was actively engaged with both national and international professional associations and societies throughout his distinguished career. His most historic achievement came when he became the **first Muslim to be elected President of the Indian Library Association (Indian Library Association (ILA), Delhi** serving from 1972 to 1975. Decades later, this **humble self was elected unopposed** to the same office, serving from April 1, 2016, to March 31, 2019.

During his presidency, Prof. Bashiruddin worked tirelessly to raise professional standards, improve the status and salaries of librarians, and integrate modern educational practices into Library and Information Science across India. **His visionary leadership placed him alongside towering figures such as Dr. S.R. Ranganathan**, the Father of Library Science in India, and ensured that the pioneering practices of Aligarh Muslim University (AMU) gained national recognition.

Beyond his professional contributions, Syed Bashiruddin was a staunch advocate of women's right to work, championing progressive values at a time when such issues were still emerging in public discourse. His commitment to both institutional



**Padamshree Syed Bashiruddin (1902-1984)**



**Maulana Azad Library**



development and social reform reflected a vision that extended far beyond the library profession.

In recognition of his distinguished services, the **Government of India conferred upon him the Padma Shri in 1976**, one of the nation's highest civilian honours.

Syed Bashiruddin passed away on **October 22, 1984**, at his daughter's residence in Allahabad. He left behind a legacy of **scholarship, institution-building, and progressive vision** that continues to inspire generations of library professionals and educators across India.

### **3. Maulana Azad Library (1960)**

The **Lytton Library of the Mohammedan Anglo-Oriental (MAO) College**, established in **1877**, continued to serve the academic community until **1920**, when a historic milestone transformed the College into **Aligarh Muslim University (AMU)** through an Act of Parliament. Even after this transition, the Lytton Library remained the primary source of books and services for the rapidly growing student body.

By the 1940s and 1950s, however, the **reading space and shelving capacity** had become severely inadequate. It is assumed that the adjoining **Strachey Hall building** may have been used to accommodate the overflow. The tremendous rise in student enrolment during this period, coupled with the introduction of new courses, placed enormous pressure on the library to expand its collections, staff, and services.

Recognising these challenges, the **Government of India sanctioned approximately ₹2.3 crore** for the construction of a new, iconic library building. The **foundation stone was laid in 1955** by Prime Minister **Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru**, who also inaugurated the completed building on **6 December 1960**. This marked the birth of the **Maulana Azad Library**, destined to become one of the largest university libraries in Asia.

#### **3.1 Functional Structure of M.A. Library**

The contribution of Syed Bashiruddin Ahmed, who served first as University Librarian at the Lytton Library and later at the Maulana Azad Library, deserves special recognition. From 1955 to 1960, he worked closely with Mohammed Fayazuddin, the distinguished architect of the new library building, ensuring that the design would meet the academic and functional needs of a rapidly expanding university.

Following the inauguration of the Maulana Azad Library in 1960, Syed Bashiruddin meticulously oversaw the transfer of the entire Lytton Library collection into the new premises. He carefully organised diverse collections in multiple languages, assigning them appropriate locations to facilitate access and scholarly use. At the same time,

he safeguarded the continuity of essential library operations — acquisition, technical processing, cataloguing, and reader services — thereby laying the groundwork for the modern organisation and workflow of the Maulana Azad Library.

His vision and administrative acumen ensured that the library was not merely a new building but a well-structured academic institution capable of supporting AMU's intellectual growth for decades to come.

The intensive planning of the Maulana Azad Library during its construction — a process in which both the architect and the visionary University Librarian played pivotal roles — is clearly reflected in its infrastructure. The library's main gate opens into an outer hall, designed as a practical space where students can safely keep their bags and belongings before entering the reading areas. From here, one steps into the central hall, which originally housed the catalogue cabinets, enabling users to consult and locate books with ease. This arrangement continued until 16 March, 2009 when online catalogue was introduced by this author to make the online catalogue accessible within the library as well as via the campus network.

This central hall was strategically connected to two reading halls: one reserved for undergraduate and postgraduate students, and the other dedicated to reference and research work, thereby serving both general study and advanced scholarship. From the same central hall, a staircase leads to the first floor, where various language sections, comprising collections in Urdu, Arabic, Persian, Hindi, Sanskrit, Malayalam, Telugu, and Tamil, reflect the multilingual richness of the University, until it was reorganised during my tenure (2008-2012).

The central hall also links directly to the seven-storey stack building through the circulation section, which manages the issue and return of books. This arrangement ensured smooth access to both the English language collections housed across the seven floors on one side and the vernacular collections located on the first floor on the other.

Adjacent to the central hall is the Librarian's chamber, whose windows overlook the main road, symbolising both accessibility and oversight. On the other side of the chamber lay the processing area, comprising the acquisition, accession, and technical sections. Each of these was headed by a senior officer — either a Deputy Librarian or an Assistant Librarian — ensuring professional management and continuity of services.

This carefully planned infrastructure embodied the vision of creating a library that was not merely a repository of books but a well-organised academic institution, balancing functionality, inclusivity, and scholarly excellence.

### **3.2 Collections and services of M.A. Library (1960 to 2000)**

The importance of a library's book collection and reader services lies in their inseparable role in shaping the institution as a true centre of learning. A rich and diverse book collection serves as the reservoir of knowledge, preserving intellectual heritage, supporting academic research, and offering resources across disciplines. It provides credibility to the library and attracts scholars, students, and researchers

who rely on its depth and variety. Rare manuscripts, journals, and specialised works ensure that the library is not merely a storehouse but a guardian of cultural and scholarly traditions.

Equally vital are reader services, which transform this collection into a living resource. Through cataloguing, circulation, reference assistance, and digital access, libraries make knowledge usable and accessible. Reader services guide individuals in navigating complex collections, saving time and enhancing the quality of their study or research. They also foster inclusivity by extending support to diverse communities, offering literacy programs, and ensuring that learning continues seamlessly.

Together, the book collection and reader services form the twin pillars of a library. Without services, a collection remains locked and underutilised; without a strong collection, services lack depth and meaning. Their integration makes the library a dynamic institution — not just a repository of books, but a beacon of enlightenment, cultural preservation, and academic progress.

Quite mindful of the importance of the diverse collections inherited from the Lytton Library, Syed Bashiruddin Ahmed drew upon his vast experience in librarianship to reorganise and systematise the holdings of the newly established Maulana Azad Library. He carefully separated the English-language collection from those in other languages, ensuring both accessibility and scholarly utility.

***The seven-storey building was thus allocated in a structured manner:***

The ground floor housed textbooks across various subjects, meeting the bulk of demand from undergraduate and postgraduate students.

The remaining five floors (excluding the 7th-floor Junk Yard) were devoted to English-language books across different disciplines, meticulously arranged according to the Dewey Decimal Classification (DDC) scheme (000 Generalities to 999 Geography & History), 10 groups of knowledge, that primarily served the needs of the researchers. In 2016, the **4<sup>th</sup> floor (West) was assigned to the Hindi and Sanskrit Reading Room and stacks**, after being shifted from the 7th floor.

Meanwhile, the first floor of the main building was dedicated to collections in other languages, including the Manuscripts Division, reflecting the multilingual and multicultural character of the University. **Presently, a part of the Oriental Division has been shifted to the New Building of the M.A. Library.**

This thoughtful organisation not only streamlined access but also underscored the library's role as a comprehensive repository of knowledge, catering to students, researchers, and scholars across linguistic and disciplinary boundaries. By combining systematic classification with linguistic inclusivity, **Syed Bashiruddin laid the foundation for the modern organisation of the Maulana Azad Library, ensuring that it would serve as both an academic powerhouse and a cultural treasure house.**

### 3.3 Technical Processing of Reading Material

The organisation of technical processing in a library is of paramount importance. Every book or reading material undergoes a meticulous journey — from the bookseller's shop to its place on the library shelf. At each stage, careful handling and technical precision are required to ensure that the library maximises its resources and remains capable of meeting the present and future needs of students, researchers, and academic staff.

This process is not merely mechanical; it reflects the library's commitment to scholarly excellence, inclusivity, and resource optimisation. To achieve this, the work is divided into specialised divisions, each headed by an Assistant Librarian or Deputy Librarian, functioning under the overall supervision of the University Librarian.

**Acquisition Division** – Responsible for selecting, ordering, and procuring books and other materials, ensuring the collection remains current and relevant.

**Periodicals Division** – Manages journals, magazines, and newspapers, providing access to ongoing scholarly and general knowledge resources.

**Technical Division** – Handles cataloguing, classification, and bibliographic control, enabling systematic organisation and easy retrieval of materials.

**Circulation Division** – Oversees the issue, return, and renewal of books, ensuring smooth access for users.

**Services Division** – Provides reference assistance, user guidance, and specialised services to meet academic and research needs.

**Oriental Division** – Maintains collections in classical and regional languages such as Urdu, Arabic, Persian, Sanskrit, and others, preserving cultural and linguistic heritage.

**Manuscripts Division** – Safeguards rare manuscripts and archival treasures, ensuring their preservation and accessibility for scholarly study.

**Administrative Division** – Coordinates staff, finances, and policy implementation, ensuring efficient functioning of the entire library system.

In essence, technical processing transforms raw reading material into organised knowledge assets, making the library not just a repository of books but a living academic institution. Each division contributes to a seamless chain of operations, ensuring that resources are accessible, preserved, and optimally utilised for generations of learners and scholars.

A detailed discussion on each division follows:

#### ➤ Acquisition Division

The Acquisition Division plays a pivotal role in shaping the intellectual strength of the library. It is entrusted with the selection and ordering of books and other reading

materials, guided by the principles of collection development. This ensures that the library's holdings remain balanced, relevant, and responsive to the academic and research needs of the institution.

Its responsibilities extend beyond mere purchasing by following a laid down procedure. The division manages:

**Succession of books** – ensuring continuity and updating of editions.

**Gifts and exchanges** – incorporating valuable contributions from individuals, institutions, and societies.

**Procurement for departments of studies** – supplying resources not only for the central library but also for specialised departmental libraries.

A distinctive feature of this division is its outreach and collaboration. It actively contacts other institutions and learned societies in India and abroad to procure publications either gratis (free of cost) or through exchange programmes. Such initiatives enrich the library's collection with rare and diverse materials, fostering academic cooperation and cultural exchange.

In essence, the Acquisition Division is the gateway through which knowledge enters the library. By combining careful selection, strategic procurement, and scholarly collaboration, it ensures that the library remains a dynamic reservoir of learning — serving students, researchers, and faculty alike, while also strengthening ties with the wider academic world.

#### ➤ **Periodicals Division**

The Periodicals Division plays a vital role in sustaining the intellectual and research environment of the library. It is entrusted with the responsibility of acquiring academic and scientific periodicals based on recommendations received from the Heads of Departments.

A well-defined procedure for ordering and subscribing to periodicals is strictly followed, ensuring transparency and accountability in the selection process.

**Current Issues** – The latest issues of journals, magazines, and newspapers are displayed near the Periodicals Reading Room, providing immediate access to students, researchers, and faculty.

**Bound Volumes** – Once a volume is completed, the issues are carefully bound and transferred to the designated floors of the seven-storey stacks, where they are preserved for long-term consultation.

**Reading Environment** – The periodicals' reading area is designed to be quiet, interference-free, and generally open for extended hours, thereby encouraging uninterrupted study and research.

#### ➤ **Technical division**

The Technical Division forms the backbone of the library's organisational system. Its primary responsibilities include classification, cataloguing, and stock-taking of

reading materials, ensuring that every item is systematically arranged and easily retrievable.

**Classification & Cataloguing** – Books and other resources are classified according to recognised schemes (such as the Dewey Decimal Classification), and meticulously catalogued to provide accurate bibliographic records. This enables users to locate materials quickly and efficiently.

**Stock-Taking** – Regular stock verification is carried out both in the Central Library and in the Departmental Libraries, ensuring accountability and preventing loss or misplacement of resources.

**Support to Departmental Libraries** – The Central Library extends its technical expertise to departmental libraries where professional staff may be inadequate, thereby maintaining uniform standards of cataloguing and classification across the institution.

In essence, the Technical Division transforms newly acquired books into organised knowledge assets, while also safeguarding the integrity of the library's collections through systematic cataloguing and stock-taking. By supporting departmental libraries, it ensures that the entire academic community benefits from a cohesive and professionally managed system of information access.

#### ➤ **Circulation Division**

The Circulation Division occupies a central and highly visible position in the library, serving as the primary point of contact between the library's resources and its users. It is entrusted with the responsibility of managing membership services and the issue and return of books and other materials.

**Membership Management** – The division handles the registration of members, maintaining accurate records of students, faculty, and researchers entitled to borrow materials.

**Issue & Return System** – Members are provided with issue and return cards, which allow them to borrow from any part of the library's collection, except for materials specifically declared as reserved (such as rare manuscripts, reference works, or fragile items). The card system continued in MAL until the turn of the century and was later replaced by barcodes.

**User Access** – By regulating borrowing privileges, the division ensures equitable access to resources while maintaining accountability and proper circulation of materials.

**Central Role** – Positioned at the heart of the library, the circulation desk acts as a bridge between the collections and the community, guiding users in borrowing, returning, and renewing materials.

In short, the Circulation Division is the gateway through which knowledge flows outward to the readers. By combining efficient membership services with a structured borrowing system, it ensures that the library's vast resources remain accessible, organised, and responsibly managed for the benefit of all.

### ➤ **Services Division**

The Services Division is the intellectual hub of the library, designed to directly support the diverse needs of students, researchers, and general readers. It encompasses several specialised sections, each contributing to the library's mission of providing knowledge, guidance, and cultural enrichment.

**Reference & Research Section** – Offers expert assistance in locating information, guiding users through bibliographies, catalogues, and databases. It serves as the first point of scholarly support, helping researchers and students access authoritative sources for academic work.

**Textual Studies Section** – Dedicated to specialised study materials, critical editions, and subject-specific texts. This section strengthens the library's role in supporting in-depth academic inquiry and textual analysis.

**Popular Magazines & Newspapers Section** – Provides access to current affairs, general knowledge, and cultural trends through a wide range of magazines and daily newspapers. This section ensures that the library remains a living space for both scholarly and popular reading interests.

In essence, the Services Division bridges the gap between academic research and everyday reading, ensuring that the library caters not only to the serious scholar but also to the general reader. By combining reference guidance, textual study resources, and popular reading materials, it creates a balanced environment of knowledge and leisure.

### ➤ **Oriental Division**

The Oriental Division safeguards and promotes the rich heritage of classical and regional languages, serving as a cornerstone of cultural and scholarly preservation within the library.

**Collections** – It houses extensive holdings in Urdu, Hindi, Sanskrit, Persian, and Arabic, along with the distinguished Sir Syed Room, which preserves works related to Sir Syed Ahmad Khan and the Aligarh Movement.

**Selection & Acquisition** – The division is responsible for the careful selection of oriental works, ensuring that both classical texts and contemporary publications are represented.

**Technical Processing** – Books and manuscripts in oriental languages undergo specialised cataloguing and classification, tailored to the unique scripts and linguistic traditions of each language.

**Servicing & Access** – The division provides reading and reference services for scholars, students, and researchers engaged in oriental studies, ensuring that rare and valuable materials are accessible in a supportive environment.

**Cultural Preservation** – By maintaining and processing these collections, the division plays a vital role in preserving linguistic diversity and cultural heritage, while also supporting ongoing research in literature, history, philosophy, and religious studies.

In essence, the Oriental Division is not merely a repository of books; it is a living archive of South Asian and Middle Eastern intellectual traditions, ensuring that the voices of classical scholarship remain available to inspire future generations.

### ➤ **Manuscripts Division**

The Manuscripts Division represents the heart and soul of the Maulana Azad Library, safeguarding its most treasured and irreplaceable collections. In recognition of its profound importance, this book devotes a separate chapter 7 to the Manuscripts of the Maulana Azad Library.

**Foundation of the Collection** – The division houses manuscripts that have been gifted by eminent scholars, patrons, and institutions, as well as those carefully procured by the library over time.

**Sir Syed's Contribution** – True to his passion for knowledge and preservation, Sir Syed Ahmad Khan himself collected several rare manuscripts, many of which today form an integral part of this division. His vision ensured that future generations could access the intellectual heritage of past centuries.

**Range of Subjects** – The manuscripts span a remarkable diversity of disciplines, including Islamic theology, Sufism, medicine (Tibb), literature, mathematics, astronomy, history, and biographical works.

**Highlights of the division** are:

- A fragment of the **Holy Qur'an in Koofi** script, traditionally attributed to **Hazrat Ali (A.S.)**, the fourth Caliph of Islam (c.600-661CE).
- **Royal decrees of Mughal emperors** (1526-1857), reflecting the administrative and cultural ethos of medieval India.
- **Persian translations of Sanskrit classics** such as the **Bhagavad Gita, Mahabharata, and Leelawati** by Abul Faiz Faizi (1547-1595), the celebrated scholar of Emperor Akbar's court.
- A delicate **painting of a red tulip flower by Mansur Naqqash**, the renowned court painter of Emperor Jahangir (1605–1627). This masterpiece was displayed at the Festival of India in New York (1985).
- **Scholarly Importance** – With nearly 16,000 manuscripts, many of which belong to the “rarest of the rare” category, the division attracts researchers



from across the world in fields of Oriental Studies, Islamic Studies, and Medieval Indian history.

In essence, the Manuscripts Division is not merely a collection but a living archive of centuries-old wisdom, embodying Sir Syed's vision of preserving knowledge and making it accessible to scholars and seekers of truth. Its overwhelming importance justifies the inclusion of a dedicated chapter in this book.

#### ➤ **Administrative division**

The Administrative Division serves as the nerve centre of the Library, ensuring smooth governance, efficient resource management, and the preservation of collections. It is composed of several key sections, each with distinct responsibilities: Office of the Library – The central coordinating unit, headed by the University Librarian, is responsible for overall supervision, policy implementation, and communication with the University's academic and administrative authorities.

**Maintenance Section** – The Maintenance Section is entrusted with the upkeep of the library's infrastructure, ensuring that the building, reading halls, furniture, electrical systems, air-conditioning, and modern-day computer facilities remain in optimal condition. By maintaining these essential resources, the section creates a safe, academic, and comfortable environment that supports readers in their pursuit of knowledge.

**Bindery Section** – Dedicated to the repair, binding, and preservation of books, journals, and manuscripts. This section plays a crucial role in extending the life of rare and frequently used materials.

**Reprography Section** – Provides photocopying, microfilming, and digitisation services, enabling scholars to access fragile or rare materials without damaging the originals. It also supports archival preservation by creating durable copies.

**Accounts Section** – Manages the library's financial operations, including budgeting, procurement, passing of bills, and audit compliance. This section ensures transparency and accountability in the use of funds.

In essence, the Administrative Division is the backbone of the library's operations, harmonising infrastructure, preservation, and financial management to sustain the institution's mission of disseminating knowledge.

#### **4. MAL: One of the Largest University Libraries in the world?<sup>1</sup>**

With its extensive collection and state-of-the-art facilities, the Maulana Azad Library is often regarded as one of the largest university libraries. The library's official website even describes it as *"one of the largest university libraries in the world."*

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1. <https://www.amu.ac.in/libraries/maulana-azad-library/home-pa> (Accessed on 7May 2026)

while other sources have referred to it as the biggest university library in Asia and arguably the largest in India.

To substantiate this claim, an attempt was made to verify its status through online searches. However, because Google retrieves information from uploaded sources without independent authentication, reaching a definitive conclusion remains challenging. In the same vein, a Wikipedia search for the **"List of the world's largest libraries"**<sup>2</sup> provided a list of 35 libraries:

According to Wikipedia, **'This sortable list of the world's largest libraries includes libraries that (as of 2008) store 10 million or more items.'** Obviously, the M.A. Library nowhere appears in the said list.

| Name & Location | Catalogue size<br>(No.of items) | Visitors/Yr | Budget | Staff |
|-----------------|---------------------------------|-------------|--------|-------|
|-----------------|---------------------------------|-------------|--------|-------|

**First Library in the table**

|                 |             |             |               |       |
|-----------------|-------------|-------------|---------------|-------|
| British Library | 200million+ | 1.75million | £162.5million | 1,977 |
|-----------------|-------------|-------------|---------------|-------|

London&Boston Spa

**Last Library in the table**

|                  |                  |         |               |     |
|------------------|------------------|---------|---------------|-----|
| National Library | 21 billion items | 388,422 | \$102,515,000 | 428 |
|------------------|------------------|---------|---------------|-----|

of Australia, Canberra

## Conclusion

I sincerely hope that one of the library professionals in Aligarh will rise to the occasion and take up the challenge of conducting a comprehensive survey at the national—or even continental—level. Such an endeavour must be rooted in the collection of authentic, verifiable data rather than relying solely on information available on library websites, which is often incomplete or outdated. By engaging directly with institutions, gathering primary statistics on collections, budgets, staff strength, and user engagement, and cross-checking with official reports, this survey could provide a reliable benchmark for understanding the true state of libraries, including Maulana Azad Library. Undertaking this initiative from Aligarh, with its rich academic and library tradition, would not only strengthen professional credibility but also contribute significantly to the advancement of library science in India and beyond.

<sup>2</sup> [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List\\_of\\_the\\_world%27s\\_largest\\_libraries](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_the_world%27s_largest_libraries) (Accessed on 31.08.2026 )

## Chapter 3

### Maulana Azad Library and Mohammed Fayazuddin Nizami

#### 1. Introduction

The architecture of the Maulana Azad Library at Aligarh Muslim University reflects both grandeur and thoughtful functionality, embodying the vision of a modern academic institution rooted in tradition. Designed by a renowned architect, the seven-storied structure rises majestically amidst sprawling lawns and gardens, symbolising dignity and scholarship. Its layout was meticulously planned to balance accessibility with academic purpose: from the imposing main gate and outer hall that welcome students, to the central hall that once housed catalogue cabinets—serving as a gateway to knowledge. The building integrates spacious reading halls, multilingual sections, and a towering stack area, all interconnected to ensure smooth circulation of resources. With its blend of monumental scale, practical design, and cultural inclusivity, the Library's architecture stands as a testament to AMU's commitment to intellectual diversity and academic excellence.

#### 2. Mohammed Fayazuddin Nizami<sup>1</sup> (1903 - 1977)

It is indeed unfortunate that the name of the celebrated architect of the coveted Maulana Azad Library, **Mohammed Fayazuddin Nizami**, slipped into oblivion soon after its inauguration. Neither the staff of the library nor the officials of the building department were aware of the identity of the creative mind behind this monumental structure. **The present book aims to remind and revive the people like Fayazuddin, who remained associated with the MALibrary project in one way or the other, and ultimately contributed to making it what it is today.**

The architectural design was entrusted to Mr. Mohammed Fayazuddin Nizami, India's **first professional town planner and one of the nation's foremost architects**. Born in Hyderabad in 1903, Fayazuddin received his early education at City College, Hyderabad, before pursuing architectural studies at the prestigious Sir J. J. School of Art, Bombay (now Mumbai). He later advanced his training at the renowned Architectural Association School of Architecture, London, established in 1847, where he absorbed modernist ideas and international design trends.

This blend of Indian grounding and European exposure equipped him with a unique vision — one that combined functionality with aesthetic dignity. The Maulana Azad Library stands as a lasting testament to his genius, even if his name was unjustly forgotten by the very community that benefited from his work.

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<sup>1</sup> [https://en.m.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mohammed\\_Fayazuddin](https://en.m.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mohammed_Fayazuddin)(accessed on 12th April 2025)

Upon returning to India in 1934, he joined the Government of Hyderabad State as an architect and town planner. Over the next four decades, he played a pivotal role in shaping the civic and cultural landscape of Hyderabad and beyond. His work combined functionality with aesthetic dignity, reflecting both Indian traditions and modern architectural principles.

His contributions extended beyond individual buildings. Fayazuddin prepared the **master plan for Bahawalpur**, served as **Chief Town Planner of Hyderabad State**, and was the **first President of the Institute of Town Planners, India (1951)**. In recognition of his achievements, he was awarded the **Padma Shri in 1977**.

Through his vision and dedication, Fayazuddin Nizami helped define the architectural identity of modern Hyderabad and left an enduring mark on India's educational and cultural institutions.



**Padma Shri Mohammed Fayazuddin Nizami (1903 - 1977)**

It is rather unfortunate that the Aligarh community remains largely unaware of the name and fame of the distinguished architect who conceived the splendid Maulana Azad Library—a building so magnificent that many fondly describe it as the “**Taj Mahal of Aligarh.**” This lack of recognition makes it even more important to acknowledge the remarkable contributions of Mohammed Fayazuddin Nizami, India’s first professional town planner and one of the country’s foremost architects. A master craftsman in his field, Fayazuddin combined aesthetic vision with functional design, leaving behind a distinguished legacy of civic, cultural, and educational projects that continue to shape India’s architectural identity.

### **3.Celebrated works of Fayazuddin**

Among his most celebrated works are monumental landmarks such as the State Bank of Hyderabad, Gandhi Bhavan, Ravindra Bharathi, the Salar Jung Museum, and, of course, the Maulana Azad Library at Aligarh Muslim University—each a lasting testament to his genius and dedication to public life.

A glimpse of Fayazuddin’s most celebrated works has been provided hereunder along with their URLs (**worth seeing**):

#### **3.1 Alhambra, Hyderabad (1938–1996)**

Residence of architect Mohammed Fayazuddin, built in 1938 at the famous Banjara Hills, Hyderabad, and demolished in 1996–97. The mansion reflected Fayazuddin’s personal vision, blending modernist design with Hyderabad’s aristocratic elegance. It stood as one of the earliest landmark residences in Banjara Hills, later a hub of elite Hyderabad society. Alhambra symbolised the architect’s stature, serving as both his home and a showcase of his creative style.

Though demolished, its memory endures as part of Hyderabad’s architectural heritage and Fayazuddin’s personal legacy.

URL:

[https://en.m.wikipedia.org/wiki/File:Alhambra1\\_Hyderabad.jpg](https://en.m.wikipedia.org/wiki/File:Alhambra1_Hyderabad.jpg)

#### **3.2 Nawab Ali Yavar Jung Mansion, Hyderabad (1930s)**

Constructed in the 1930s, this elegant residence belonged to Nawab Ali Yavar Jung, distinguished diplomat and former Vice Chancellor of Aligarh Muslim University (1965–1968).

Designed by architect Mohammed Fayazuddin, the mansion reflected the refined tastes and cosmopolitan outlook of its owner. Its architecture combined classical grace with modern sensibilities, making it one of Hyderabad’s notable residences of the era. The mansion often served as a venue for intellectual and diplomatic gatherings, reinforcing Jung’s stature in public life.

Today, it is remembered as part of Hyderabad's architectural and cultural heritage, linked to one of India's most respected statesmen.

URL:

[https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/6/65/Ali\\_Yawar\\_Jung\\_Mansion%2C\\_Banjara\\_Hills.png](https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/6/65/Ali_Yawar_Jung_Mansion%2C_Banjara_Hills.png)

### 3.3 Sayyid Naqi Bilgrami Mansion, Hyderabad (1946)

Private residence of Sayyid Naqi Bilgrami, a distinguished scion of the **Royal Bilgrami family**. Designed by architect Mohammed Fayazuddin, the mansion reflected the refined tastes and aristocratic lifestyle of its owner. Its architecture blended traditional elegance with modern influences of the mid-20th century. The mansion became a social hub for Hyderabad's elite, hosting cultural and intellectual gatherings.

Though primarily a private residence, it remains remembered as part of the city's architectural heritage.

URL:

[https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/6/65/Sayyid\\_Naqi\\_Bilgrami\\_Mansion%2C\\_Banjara\\_Hills.png](https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/6/65/Sayyid_Naqi_Bilgrami_Mansion%2C_Banjara_Hills.png)

### 3.4 Sarathi Studios building (1936)

Designed by architect Mohammed Fayazuddin, the residence of Maharaja Kishen Pershad was originally built in 1936. Kishen Pershad served twice as **Prime Minister of Hyderabad** and was once designated as **Yamin-us-Sultanat**. The building was later closely linked to the city's emerging film industry. Its elegant design reflected the Maharaja's refined taste and cosmopolitan outlook. Over time, the mansion became a **cultural landmark**, remembered for its blend of political history and artistic legacy. The building was later linked to the film industry.

URL:

<https://kishenpershad.com/wp-content/uploads/2020/05/hym02sarathi1.jpg>

### 3.5 State Bank of Hyderabad building (1952)

Formerly named Hyderabad State Bank, it was the central bank of the erstwhile Nizam. It was established on 8 August 1941 under the Hyderabad State Bank Act, during the reign of the **last Nizam of Hyderabad, Mir Osman Ali Khan**. While working for the government of Hyderabad State, Mohammed Fayazuddin's major projects in Hyderabad include the State Bank of Hyderabad building (1952). The grand building was **inaugurated by President Rajendra Prasad**.

URL:

[https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/State\\_Bank\\_of\\_Hyderabad#/media/File%3ASBH\\_main\\_building\\_at\\_Gunfoundry\\_full.JPG](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/State_Bank_of_Hyderabad#/media/File%3ASBH_main_building_at_Gunfoundry_full.JPG)

### 3.6 Gandhi Bhavan, Hyderabad

Gandhi Bhavan serves as the **headquarters of the Indian National Congress Party** in Nampally, Hyderabad, and is widely recognized as a prominent city landmark. The building was constructed by Khan Bahadur Abdul Karim Babukhan, father of Bashiruddin Babukhan and Narala Saikiran Mudiraj, and generously donated to the Congress Party.

On 7 October 1950, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel laid the foundation stone of the Bhavan. The structure was designed by the eminent architect Mohammed Fayazuddin, and was formally **inaugurated by President Rajendra Prasad** on 8 July 1956. Today, Gandhi Bhavan stands not only as a political headquarters but also as a symbol of Hyderabad's role in India's democratic journey.

URL:

[https://media.andhrajyothy.com/media/2022/20221214/GANDHI\\_BHAVAN\\_d963b7443b.jpg](https://media.andhrajyothy.com/media/2022/20221214/GANDHI_BHAVAN_d963b7443b.jpg)

### 3.7 Maulana Azad Library

The Maulana Azad Library serves as the central library of Aligarh Muslim University. Its seven-storied structure rises amidst 4.75 acres (1.92 ha) of lawns and gardens, offering a serene academic environment. Designed by the renowned architect Mohammed Fayazuddin, the foundation stone was laid in 1955 by **Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru**, who returned in 1960 **to inaugurate** the completed building. Today, the Library stands not only as a **hub of scholarship but also as a symbol of AMU's rich intellectual and cultural heritage**.

URL:

[https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/thumb/7/70/Maulana\\_Azad\\_Library\\_%2C\\_AMU.jpg/1920px-](https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/thumb/7/70/Maulana_Azad_Library_%2C_AMU.jpg/1920px-)

### 3.8 Ravindra Bharathi, Hyderabad

An iconic cultural centre and auditorium, named after Rabindranath Tagore, was inaugurated on 11 May 1961 by the former President of India, Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan.

Designed by architect Mohammed Fayazuddin, it quickly became the heart of Hyderabad's performing arts. Its architecture blends modern functionality with dignified simplicity, **symbolising the spirit of Tagore's humanism**. Even today, Ravindra

Bharathi remains a premier venue for national and international cultural events, carrying forward its rich legacy.

URL:

<https://media-cdn.tripadvisor.com/media/photo-o/17/2b/d4/ba/ravindrabharati.jpg>

### 3.9 Salar Jung Museum, Hyderabad

A premier national museum, it began as the private art collection of the Salar Jung family and was gifted to the nation after the death of Salar Jung III. Following a design competition, architect Mohammed **Fayazuddin was chosen to create the new building**. The foundation stone was laid by Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru in 1963, and by 1968 the museum had shifted to its present location at Dar-ul-Shifa. Today, it houses one of India's finest and **most extensive art collections**, making it a cultural treasure of global significance.

URL:

[https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/a/ac/Salar\\_Jung\\_Museum%2C\\_Hyderabad%2C\\_India.jpg](https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/a/ac/Salar_Jung_Museum%2C_Hyderabad%2C_India.jpg)

## 4. Architectural Highlights of Maulana Azad Library

Mr. Mohammed Fayazuddin Nizami masterfully blended traditional Muslim architectural elements with modern design to create the magnificent seven-story library, set amidst 4.75 acres of landscaped lawns and gardens. Situated at the heart of the university, it serves as a vital knowledge hub for students and faculty, providing ample reading spaces for various types of study materials within the library as well as online resources via the campus network, laid out in 2009 during the tenure of this author.

### ➤ *The Library's Main Gate*

The main gate of the Maulana Azad library, which serves as the nerve centre for the University community, is an ingenious architectural marvel, comprising a hemispherical upper structure that strikingly mirrors the human brain, the natural reservoir of knowledge. The periphery of the hemisphere is distinctly marked with nerve fascicles extending from one end to the other. A nerve fascicle is a bundle of nerve fibres found in the peripheral nervous system<sup>2</sup>.

### ➤ *Treasure Trove of Knowledge*

*Within* the hemisphere rests a striking replica of bookshelves — a symbolic treasure trove of Knowledge. These shelves embody the timeless pursuit of learning, reminding every visitor that Knowledge, though vast and infinite, can be preserved, shared, and revered within the walls of a library.

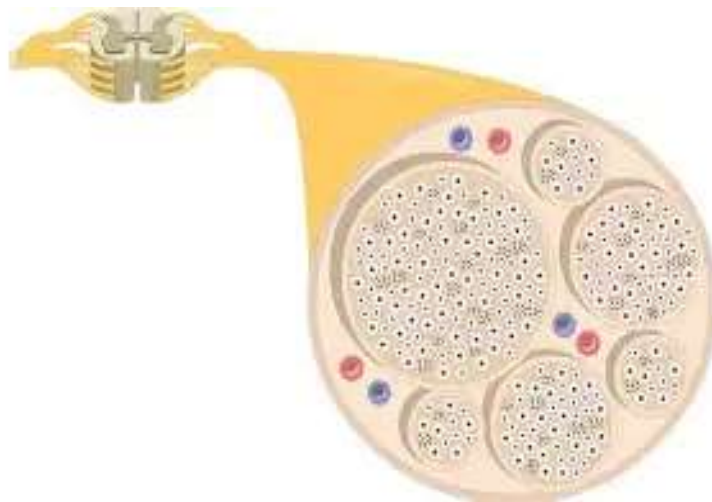
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<sup>2</sup> Nerve fascicle - Wikipedia





**Library's Main Gate**



**Nerve Fascicle: Anatomy and Diagram**

### ➤ ***Lantern of Knowledge***

From the ceiling of the great hemisphere hangs a lantern — **a luminous emblem of Knowledge**, the very foundation of a library's purpose. Across cultures and traditions, light has long stood as a profound metaphor for enlightenment, understanding, and the triumph over ignorance.

Just as light dispels darkness, **Knowledge illuminates the mind**, unveiling truth and guiding the seeker toward wisdom. This radiant symbol reminds every visitor that a library is not merely a repository of books, but a beacon that nurtures the eternal quest for learning.

### ➤ ***Four Pillars of Knowledge***

The great hemisphere of Knowledge rests upon four pillars, each symbolically representing the vast Universe of learning:

- ***Vedic tradition***

As envisioned in the Vedic tradition, these pillars embody the four cardinal paths of understanding:<sup>3</sup>

- **Dharma** — Subjects guiding individual conduct and the maintenance of society, such as Law, Theology, Ethics, and Sociology.
- **Artha** — Disciplines devoted to social well-being, including History, Political Science, Economics, and Applied Sciences.
- **Kama** — Fields born of human creativity, encompassing Fine Arts and the Humanities.
- **Moksha** — Philosophical and spiritual knowledge leading to inner peace, such as Philosophy and Spiritual Experience.

Together, these pillars uphold the hemisphere as a living symbol of the completeness of Knowledge — practical, creative, social, and spiritual — reminding every seeker that true learning embraces all dimensions of life.

- ***DIKW framework***

In Library and Information Science, the four pillars of knowledge are often interpreted through the **DIKW framework** — Data, Information, Knowledge, and Wisdom. <sup>4</sup>

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<sup>3</sup> Shabahat Husain. *Library Classification: Facets and Analyses*. Ed. 1. New York: McGraw-Hill Publishing Company, 1993. P.10

<sup>4</sup> Shabahat Husain. *Knowledge Management Systems Design: Innovation and Strategy*. Ed.1. New York, London, Routledge, 2025. P. 2.



**DIKW Pyramid**

- **Data** – The foundation of information consists of raw, unorganised symbol or facts in isolation. Though trivial on their own, these symbols gain significance when systematically organised.
- **Information** – When structured data is interpreted to answer specific questions, it becomes information.
- **Knowledge** – Knowledge emerges from the application of information derived from data. It represents the purposeful use of information to achieve defined objectives.
- **Wisdom** – It is the ability to make informed judgments based on the application of knowledge.

This progression from raw data to wisdom reflects the deepening of understanding and insight. In the same spirit, the poet **T.S. Eliot** poignantly captured the fragile balance between these stages in his famous lines:<sup>5</sup>

“Where is the wisdom we have lost in knowledge?

Where is the knowledge we have lost in information?”

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<sup>5</sup>Eliot, T.S. (1934). Choruses from the Rock. Quote by T.S. Eliot: “Where is the wisdom we have lost in knowledge? Accessed on 21 April 2025



## Chapter 4

### Maulana Azad Library and Syed Sadequain Ahmed

#### 1. Introduction

Institutions are never built overnight; they emerge through the sustained dedication of individuals whose names often fade into obscurity, leaving behind only the grandeur of the structures they helped shape. The saga of the **Maulana Azad Library** is no different. Many assume that what stands today has remained unchanged since its inauguration in 1960 by Prime Minister Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, yet few realize the painstaking effort that went into making the library both functional and reader-friendly.

As discussed in the preceding chapter, the celebrated architect **Mohammed Fayazuddin Nizami**, working in close collaboration with the professional librarian **Syed Bashiruddin Ahmed**, ensured that the building's design harmonised with academic workflows and user services. **Ironically, both men were forgotten by the AMU community, even though each was honoured nationally with the Padma Shri for his distinguished contributions.** Equally overlooked are the artistic treasures within the library — most notably the magnificent painting inscribed with the Qur'anic verse “عَلَّمَ الْإِنْسَانَ مَا لَمْ يَعْلَمْ” (“He taught man that which he knew not”), symbolically placed at the entrance of the library to reflect the University's higher purpose.

These unsung heroes — architects, librarians, poets, and artists — laid the foundations of an institution whose legacy continues to inspire generations. Their stories remind us that the true strength of the Maulana Azad Library lies not only in its collections and architecture, but also in the vision and devotion of those who shaped it.

#### 2. Syed Sadequain Ahmed Naqvi <sup>1</sup>(30 June 1930 – 10 February 1987)

The **main gate of the Maulana Azad Library opens** into the outer hall, where visitors are greeted by a remarkable painting — an exquisite masterpiece of Islamic calligraphy. When I assumed charge of the library, I sought to uncover the identity of the artist behind this work, for no name was inscribed upon it. To my astonishment, neither the library staff nor even the faculty of Fine Arts and Museology — where a mural by **M.F. Husain** adorns the front gate — could identify its creator. Many assumed it to be yet another work of Husain, overlooking the fact that his artistic specialization was altogether different from the style and spirit embodied in this painting.

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<sup>1</sup> Sadequain - Wikipedia (Accessed on 25 May 2025)

It was only later revealed, with immense surprise and admiration, that this **exquisite masterpiece of Islamic calligraphy** was in fact the creation of the **world-renowned Pakistani painter Sadequain**, whose genius in calligraphy and art continues to enrich the cultural and spiritual aura of institutions across the world. In India, his masterpieces adorn places such as Aligarh Muslim University (AMU), Banaras Hindu University (BHU), the India Islamic Cultural Centre (IICC), New Delhi, the National Geophysical Research Institute (NGRI), Hyderabad, etc. The invaluable painting at the Maulana Azad Library was not commissioned but born of Sadequain's own wish, a gesture of generosity and devotion. He **gifted this treasure to Mr Saiyid Hamid**, IAS, the then Vice-Chancellor of AMU, thereby weaving his art into the intellectual and cultural fabric of the university. This act of selfless artistry stands as a reminder that institutions are built not only by architects and administrators but also by visionary artists whose contributions often remain unsung.

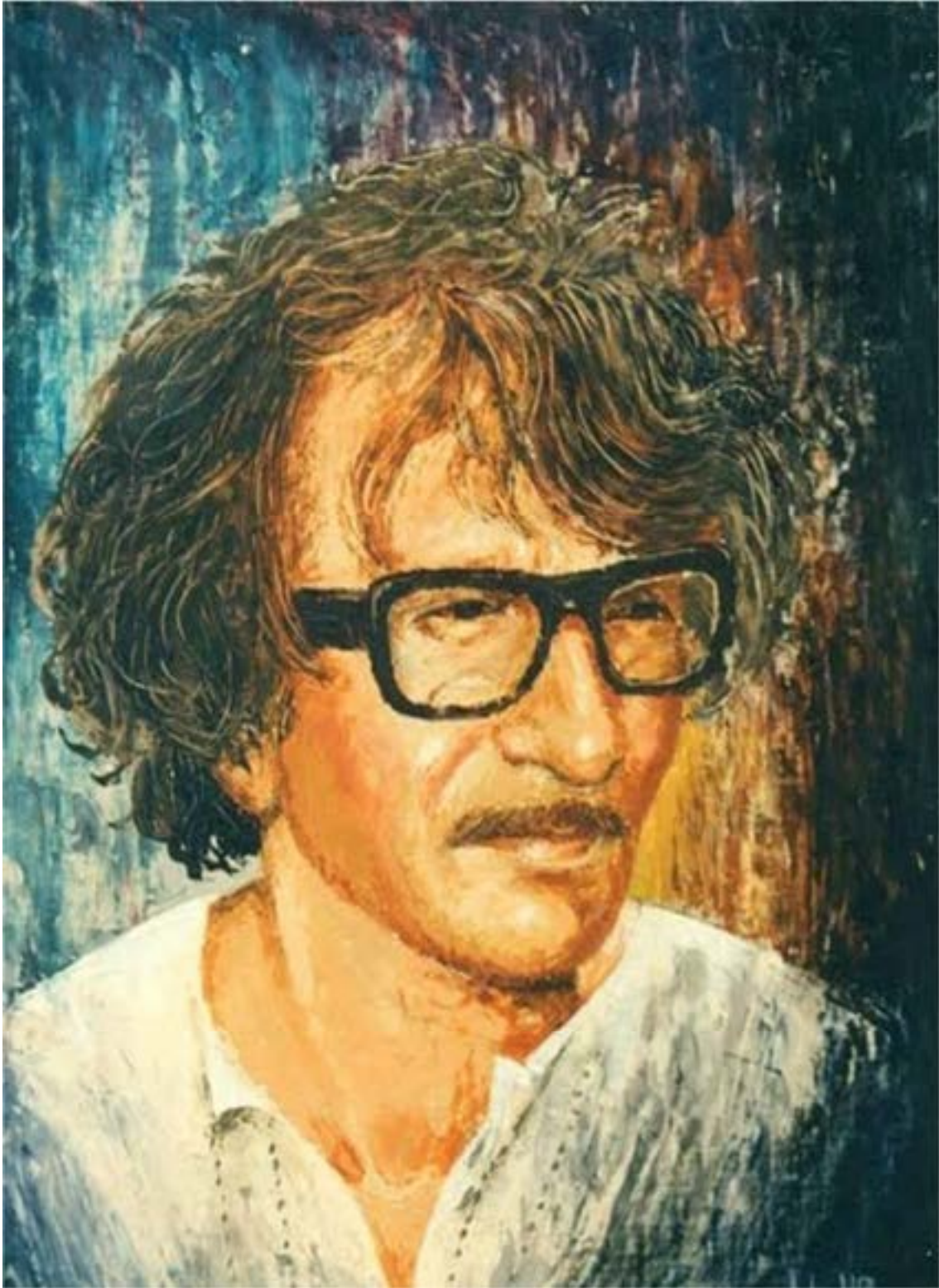
### 3. Life History

Syed Sadequain Ahmed Naqvi (30 June 1930 – 10 February 1987), widely known as **Sadequain Naqqash**, is celebrated as one of Pakistan's greatest painters and calligraphers. Over the course of his prolific career, he produced an estimated 15,000 works of art, ranging from murals and paintings to drawings and calligraphy. He remains the only artist in Pakistan to have been **honoured with all four of the nation's highest civilian awards**: Nishan-i-Imtiaz, Sitara-i-Imtiaz, Tamgha-i-Imtiaz, and Pride of Performance.

Beyond his visual artistry, **Sadequain was also a gifted poet**, composing hundreds of rubā'iyāt in the tradition of Omar Khayyam and Sarmad Kashani, blending mysticism with philosophical reflection.

Born in Amroha, Uttar Pradesh, into a family of calligraphers, he migrated to Pakistan during the partition of 1947. He settled in Nazimabad, Karachi, where he lived until his passing at the age of 56. His vast body of work not only preserves his artistic legacy but also cements his status as an immortal figure in the world of art.

Sadequain played a pivotal role in the **renaissance of Islamic calligraphy**, reviving an art form that had reached its zenith during the Mughal Empire but later fell into neglect. His bold, modernist interpretations infused calligraphy with fresh energy, making it accessible to contemporary audiences. Recognising his invaluable contribution, the Khaleej Times (UAE) published an article on 20 June 1980 titled "Renaissance of Islamic Calligraphy – A Mystic Artist from Pakistan Who Has Become a Legend in His Own Time."



**Syed Sadequain Ahmed Naqvi (30 June 1930 – 10 February 1987)**

Sadequain often remarked that if all the calligraphies he had painted were placed end-to-end, they would span several miles—a testament to both his productivity and devotion. His monumental murals adorn institutions across Pakistan and India, including the State Bank of Pakistan, Frere Hall Karachi, Aligarh Muslim University, and the Indian Islamic Cultural Centre, New Delhi, ensuring his art continues to inspire generations.

Even decades after his death, Sadequain's work remains a bridge between tradition and modernity, a symbol of cultural pride, and a reminder of the transformative power of art in shaping collective identity.

#### **4. Sadequain's illustrious contributions**

Between late 1981 and March 1983, Sadequain spent nearly two years in India, where he created several monumental calligraphic paintings and murals. Among his most significant achievements from this period is the breathtaking rendition of the ninety-nine panels of Asma-e-Husna (The Beautiful Names of God), inscribed on the towering five-story circular rotunda wall of the India Islamic Research Centre (IIRC), New Delhi.

In addition to his work at the IIRC, Sadequain also created calligraphic pieces at Aligarh Muslim University, Ghalib Academy, Jamia Millia Islamia, and the Tomb of Tipu Sultan. True to his generous nature, he gifted all these works to the Indian authorities, reflecting his belief that art was a sacred trust meant to enrich society rather than personal wealth.

Beyond these murals and calligraphies, he held exhibitions in multiple cities, including Delhi, Lucknow, Hyderabad, Aligarh, and Banaras, where his art was received with admiration and reverence.

##### **➤ Sadequain's Work in A.M.U.**

##### **• Maulana Azad Library**

One of his most notable paintings, by the renowned painter of Islamic calligraphy, is displayed at the entrance of the central hall of the Library at Aligarh Muslim University. Measuring 116 × 68 inches (9.67 × 5.66 feet), it features the Quranic verse:

عَلَّمَ الْإِنْسَانَ مَا لَمْ يَعْلَمْ

Aallama al-insana ma lam yalam

(Surah Al-'Alaq, 5)

**English translation: *Taught man that which he knew not***





#### **Notable painting by Sadequain in M.A. Library**

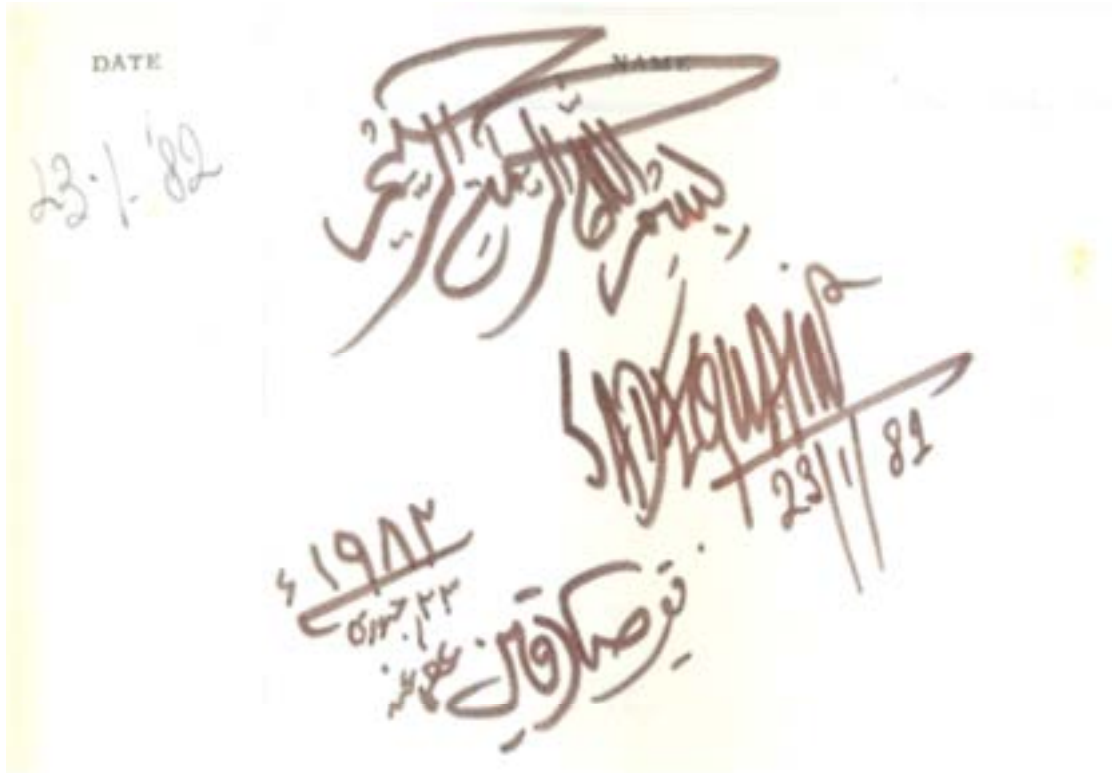
This Quranic verse is also enshrined within the monogram of Aligarh Muslim University, symbolizing its deep connection to the institution's academic mission.

***In his calligraphy, Sadequain masterfully integrated the verse with a thematic representation of knowledge, depicting books as the backdrop to the sacred words. This artistic choice reinforced the timeless idea that divine wisdom is the fountainhead of human learning.***

The masterpiece was **presented as a gift to the university**, commemorating its intellectual journey and elevating its library into a space where faith and scholarship converge. Eyewitnesses among the university staff recall that during the creation of this sacred calligraphy, **Sadequain refrained from drinking**, a gesture that underscored the spiritual devotion and reverence with which he approached the work. His art thus became not only a visual treasure but also a testament to the sanctity of knowledge and the sincerity of the artist's soul.

**The official *Visitors' Diary* of the Maulana Azad Library, Aligarh Muslim University, bears a rare and treasured entry on page no. 95:**

**"Sadequain's signature, dated 23 January 1981, is recorded in the Visitors' Diary as follows."**



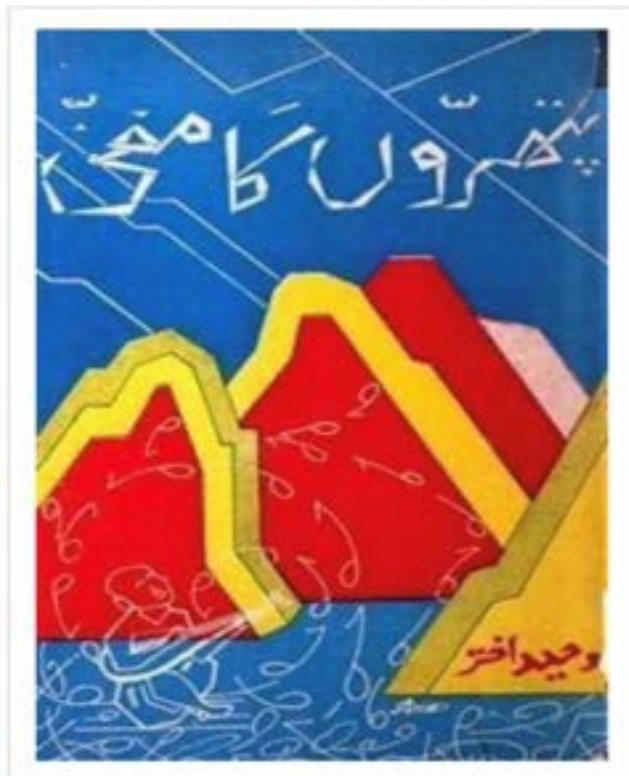
This inscription is not merely a routine record but a mark of distinction, for it belongs to Syed Sadequain Ahmed Naqvi (1930–1987)—the coveted painter, calligrapher, and poet whose genius illuminated the cultural landscape of South Asia.

Sadequain's visit to the Maulana Azad Library was part of his extended stay in Aligarh during the early 1980s, when he created monumental works of art for the university. His calligraphy at the entrance of the library, inscribing a Quranic verse that resonates with the institution's academic mission, remains a living testament to his spiritual devotion and artistic mastery.

The signature in the Visitors' Diary thus stands as a historical witness—a simple yet profound reminder of the day when one of the greatest artistic minds of the 20th century graced the library with his presence. For scholars, students, and admirers, it is more than ink on paper; it is a symbol of heritage, creativity, and intellectual generosity.

- **Book cover designing**

During his stay in India in the early 1980s, Sadequain spent considerable time in Aligarh, where he **collaborated closely with AMU professors**. Notably, he extended his artistic generosity to **Prof. Waheed Akhtar** of the Philosophy Department—an eminent author of Urdu literature—by **designing covers for at least two of his books**. These acts of friendship highlight Sadequain's deep respect for scholarship and his enduring bond with the intellectual community of Aligarh. His book cover designs were not mere embellishments but visual interpretations of the author's intellectual themes, reflecting his rare ability to merge literature and art.



Book cover design



**Mural at the Geography Department with painter's signature (left corner) \***

(\*Taken from: <https://blog.saffronart.com/2012/11/02/sadequain-a-muralist-par-excellence/?shem=rimsouwouoe>, accessed on 13-06-2026)

➤ **Sadequain's Other Major Works in India**

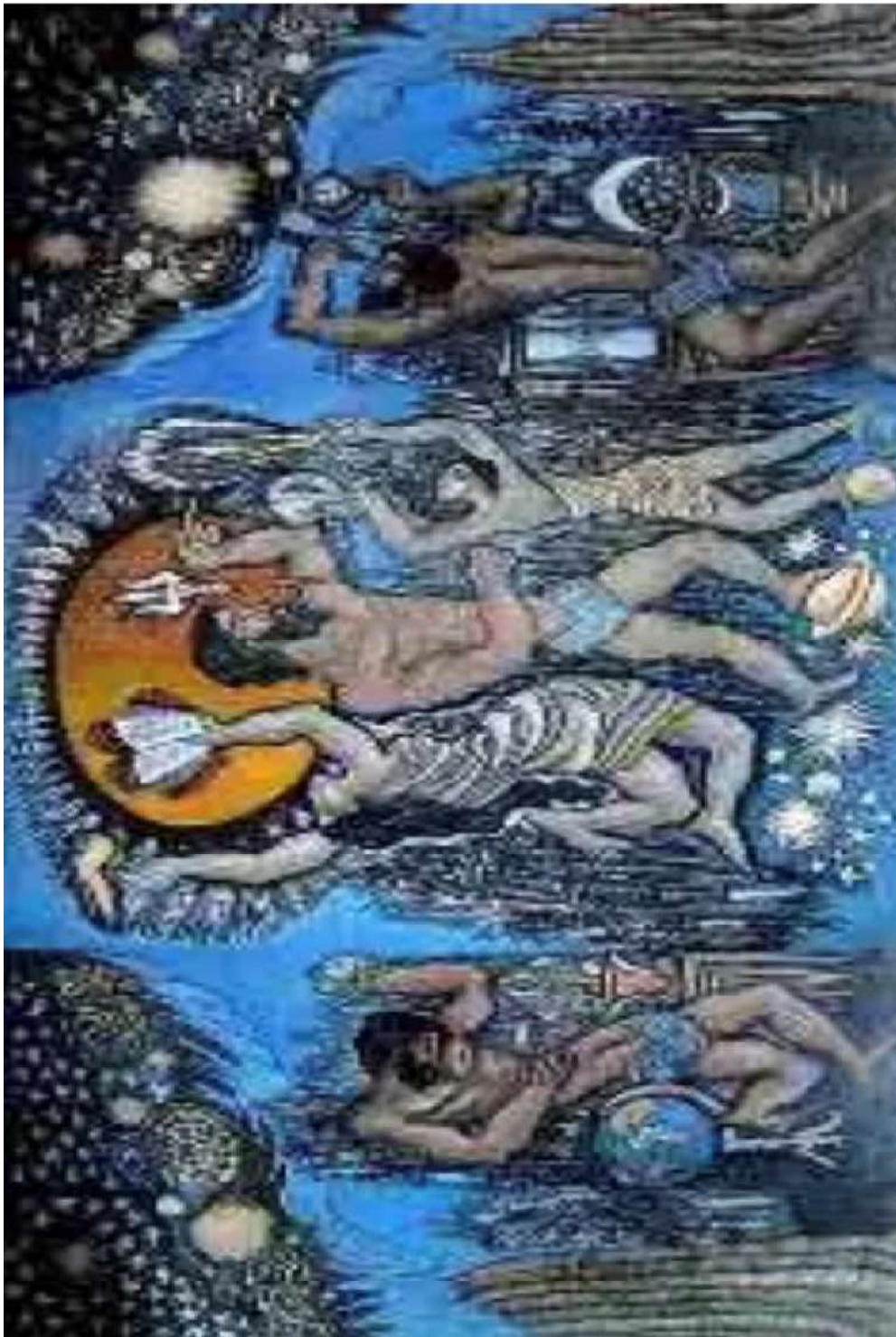
Beyond his contributions at the India Islamic Research Centre (IIRC), New Delhi, Aligarh Muslim University, Ghalib Academy, Jamia Millia, and the Tomb of Tipu Sultan, Sadequain also produced monumental murals at two prestigious institutions:

- ***Banaras Hindu University (BHU):***

Here, Sadequain created a grand mural measuring 20x10 feet, affixed on the wall of Swatantrata Bhawan (Grand Auditorium). The mural symbolises the continuity of knowledge and cultural heritage. By contributing to BHU—one of India's foremost centres of learning—he underscored his belief that art must serve as a bridge between tradition and modernity, and between faith and reason.

The mural embodies a **humanistic vision of learning**. Its sweeping forms and layered imagery highlight the **continuity of intellectual pursuit across ages**, portraying knowledge as a river that flows unbroken through history. Rather than relying on religious motifs, Sadequain chose a **universal language of abstraction and symbolism** to stress that education transcends boundaries of faith and culture. In doing so, he affirmed that true heritage lies in the **shared quest for wisdom**, where tradition and modernity converge to illuminate the path of progress.





**Mural at Swatantrata Bhawan, BHU\***

(\*Taken from: <https://blog.saffronart.com/2012/11/02/sadequain-a-muralist-par-excellence/?shem=rimsouwouoe>, accessed on 13-06-2026)

- **Monumental work at the India Islamic Research Centre (IIRC), New Delhi.**

Among his most significant achievements during his two-year stay in India is the breathtaking rendition of the ninety-nine panels of Asma-e-Husna (The Beautiful Names of God), inscribed on the towering five-story circular rotunda wall of the India Islamic Research Centre (IIRC), New Delhi. Extending approximately 700 feet in length and covering nearly 3,000 square feet, this masterpiece stands as one of only three complete sets of Asma-e-Husna he produced during his lifetime and remains a landmark of Islamic art in India.



**Asma-e-Husna**

- **National Geophysical Research Institute (NGRI), Hyderabad (GII)**

At GII, he painted an even larger **mural, measuring 70 × 25 feet**, capturing the forces of nature, geological formations, and the mysteries of the earth. This work reflected his fascination with science and his ability to translate complex natural phenomena into visual poetry. The mural remains a testament to his vision of art as a universal language that connects human inquiry with divine creation.

The mural at the National Geophysical Research Institute (NGRI), Hyderabad, painted by Sadequain, is a striking blend of science, art, and national identity.

- **Globes and Geometric Shapes** → Symbolise geophysical research, mapping, and humanity's effort to decode Earth's mysteries.
- **Hourglasses** → Represent geological time, the slow passage of ages, and the vast history embedded in Earth's strata.
- **Lamps & Instruments** → Suggest enlightenment, discovery, and the role of science in illuminating hidden truths.
- **Abstract Human Figures** → Stylised forms reaching upward, holding symbols, embodying mankind's quest for knowledge and progress.
- **Unity & Collaboration** → Figures working together reflect collective effort in science and nation-building.
- At the centre, two figures hold up a map of India inscribed with the famous patriotic verse:  
“सारे जहाँ से अच्छा हिन्दोस्ताँ हमारा” (Better than the entire world, is our Hindustan).
- This anchors the mural in national pride, linking scientific pursuit with cultural heritage and unity.

Overall, the mural is a **visual manifesto of geoscience and patriotism**. It dramatises the forces of nature and time through symbols of globes, hourglasses, and instruments. It celebrates human endeavour and scientific curiosity, showing people striving to understand Earth. It ties this pursuit to India's identity and pride, making science not just a technical mission but a cultural one.





Mural at the Geological Institute of India, Hyderabad



## **Chapter 5**

### **Maulana Azad Library and Moazzam Ali Khan**

#### **1.Introduction**

Yet another notable feature of the outer hall is a long Nazm on MAL, elegantly displayed in a well-decorated frame. To the best of my limited knowledge of Urdu literature, composing a Nazm on a subject like a library is a rare endeavour that could only be undertaken by a true admirer of the university and, more specifically, its library. With this deep sentiment, the renowned Urdu poet Dr Moazzam Ali Khan penned the Nazm at my request in 2010.

#### **2. Dr. Moazzam Ali Khan (1943 to 2021)**

Dr. Moazzam Ali Khan stands among the most distinguished Urdu poets (Shayars) to emerge from Aligarh, India. Born on September 3, 1943, in Rampur, Uttar Pradesh, he pursued his education at Aligarh Muslim University before joining S.T. High School, where he served with dedication until his retirement.

A deeply respected literary figure, Dr Khan devoted his life to composing Ghazals and Nazms, with his poetic works appearing in various acclaimed books and prominent literary magazines of India and Pakistan. His voice, enriched with sensitivity and depth, continued to inspire until he departed on his final journey during the COVID-19 pandemic in 2021.

#### **3. Tarana-e- Maulana Azad Library**

Fortunately, the coveted Maulana Azad Library of AMU completed 50 glorious years in 2010. I, thus, had the privilege of organising the Golden Jubilee celebrations during 2010–11. As part of these festivities, I requested Dr Moazzam Ali Khan to compose a Nazm dedicated to the library. He graciously obliged me, crafting a beautiful composition on what might seem an unpoetic theme—the library itself. This unique work was printed and elegantly framed by Dr. Khan himself. It was later placed on one of the walls of the Outer Hall of the Library by the then Vice Chancellor, Prof. P.K. Abdul Azis, thereby adding to the grandeur of both the occasion and the library.



**Dr Moazzam Ali Khan (1943-2021)**



علی گڑھ مسلم یونیورسٹی، علی گڑھ

میں نے یہ سب کچھ دیکھا ہے۔ میں نے یہ سب کچھ سنا ہے۔ میں نے یہ سب کچھ محسوس کیا ہے۔

اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
کائنات کے گھر ہے وہ اقلید کے کی جان ہے  
اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
تیرے آگے دیکھو کچھ دھڑکا حیران ہے  
اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
میر تقی میر غرور کا پر سکون ساحل ہے تو  
میکر انسانیت کا خوبصورت دل ہے تو  
تیرے دامن میں علی گڑھ کا ہر چھکڑا ہے  
اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
عظیم شاہان فکر و فن کا تو دربار ہے  
نورِ اطالک ماضی سے بھی تو سرشار ہے  
مہر و ماہ و علم کی دنیا تری مہمان ہے  
اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
کیوں نگزریں ملکِ مہربان میں تیرے در و شب  
ایٹیا کیا ساری دنیا میں ہے تیری تاب و جب  
سکین شاہ و علم کا اعیان ہے  
اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
پیش تری جوہل میں مفلوک کی تحریریں بہت  
مختلف افکار کی پر نور نگہیں بہت  
تو ہی تاریخ جہاں کا معتبر اعلان ہے  
اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
نشانِ عہدِ ماضی و مرکز فکر و نظر  
تیرا رشتہ ہے فنِ تحیر سے بھی خوب تر  
آکر وہ کائنات ہے تو غرورِ ہندوستان ہے  
اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
تیرے ہی دم سے نورِ علم کے کون رات ہیں  
وہ جو پہلوئیں ترے اصولِ مشروطات ہیں  
ابتدا سے آفرینش کا تجھے عرفان ہے  
اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
رنگ و نور آگہی ہے علم کی تاشیر ہے  
علمِ انسان مانتے پر ترے تحریر ہے  
تو محمد مصطفیٰ کا حکم ہے فرمان ہے  
اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
اجتہادِ باہمی کی تو کمل داستان  
شاملِ فطرت تری، آزاد کا زورِ بیان  
وقت کا دنیا سے فکر و فن پہ ترا حسان ہے  
اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
اب ہر علم کی تجھ میں شایہت جلو و گر  
نکسیرت ہے تری صورتِ معظمِ مستبر  
تو کتابِ اجتہادِ علم کا عنوان ہے  
اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے

تفکر: ڈاکٹر معظم علی خاں معظم 4/8 زہرہ باغ علی گڑھ

تحریر: شرف حسین مختار

نوٹ: اس قسم کا میوزک جانی فاسٹر نے میوزک کیا ہے۔

## مولانا ابوالکلام آزاد لائبریری

### علی گڑھ مسلم یونیورسٹی، علی گڑھ

بموقعہ گولڈن جوبلی تقریبات (2010-1960)، پروفیسر شہابت حسین کی آرمائش پر  
یہ نظم ۲۱ دسمبر ۲۰۱۱ء کو کھڑت تاب وائس چانسلر پروفیسر بی۔ کے۔ عبدالعزیز، مسلم یونیورسٹی، علی گڑھ کی خدمت میں پیش کی گئی

اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے      تو کتب خانہ نہیں ہے علم کی پہچان ہے  
کانکرت گھر ہے، داخلہ سے کی جان ہے      تو کتب علم جہاں کا حسین جزاں ہے  
تیرے آگے دجہ کا فہم و ذکا حیران ہے      اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
طالبان علم کے افکار کی منزل ہے تو      بحرِ تقدیرِ خرو کا یہ سکون حاصل ہے تو  
دیکر انسانیت کا خوبصورت دل ہے تو      سردارِ کوئٹہ کے اصحاب کی محفل ہے تو  
تیرے دامن میں علیؑ کے ہاتھ کا قرآن ہے      اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
معتزلیہ شاہانِ فکر و فن کا تو دربار ہے      تیرے پہلو میں نکتا دولتِ آثار ہے  
نشدِ ملاکِ باطنی سے بھی تو سرشار ہے      عیدِ حاضر کے تینوں کا بھی تو اہار ہے  
مہر و باغِ علم کی دنیا تری مہمان ہے      اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
کیوں جگڑیں علم کی راہوں میں تیرے درویش      سید احمد خاں سے ملتا ہے ترا نام و نسب  
اٹھایا کیا ساری دنیا میں تیری تاب و جنب      جھک کے کرتے ہیں تری تعلیم شاہکار ادب  
مسکینِ شاہو ہنر ہے، علم کا ایمان ہے      اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
جس تری جھل میں مغلوں کی قبریں بہت      غلامِ صورت، غرضِ نظر شاہوں کی تصویریں بہت  
تلفک افکار کی یہ نورِ تعمیریں بہت      تجھ سے واسطہ ہیں علم و فن کی تعمیریں بہت  
تو ہی تاریخِ جہاں کا معتبر اعلان ہے      اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
اے نشانِ عیدِ باطنی، مرکزِ فکر و فکر      یوں تو کہنے کو تو غزن ہے کتابوں کا مگر  
تجرا رشتہ ہے فہمِ حقیر سے بھی خوب تر      زورِ ترقیٰ سے آہستہ ہیں ہام و در  
آگرہ کا تاج ہے تو فجرِ ہندوستان ہے      اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
تیرے ہی دم سے منور علم کے دن رات ہیں      حیرتی ملکیتِ فردِ مندی کے احساسات ہیں  
دو جو پہلو میں ترے اصولِ مخلوقات ہیں      وادائی تہذیبِ گنگھ کے انعامات ہیں  
ابتدائے آفرینش کا تجھے عرفان ہے      اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
ریگ و نور آگہی ہے علم کی تاثیر ہے      اطلبِ اعلم کی تو اک یہ اثرِ تعمیر ہے  
علمِ انسان مانجھے کا ترے قریب ہے      تو جہالت کے مرض کے واسطے اکسیر ہے  
تو محمد مصطفیٰؐ کا حکم ہے فرمان ہے      اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
اتحادِ باہمی کی تو کھل داستان      تجھ میں خوشبوئے کتاب سرخ ہے اب بھی کہاں  
شاملِ فطرت تری، آزاد کا نورِ جان      انقرضِ چھٹی صدی ہے تیرے جلوں سے کہاں  
وقت کا دنیائے فکر و فن پہ تو احسان ہے      اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے  
بابِ ہر علم کی تجھ میں شہادتِ جلوہ گر      تو منبرِ ملک و ملت کی ہے علمِ روزگار  
مکمل سیرت ہے تری صورتِ معجزِ معجز      اب کھل ہی نہیں اکمل ہے تو انھن  
تو کتابِ اچھائے علم کا عنوان ہے      اے کتب گاہ علی گڑھ تو ہماری شان ہے

بیچہ منکر: ڈاکٹر معتمد علی خاں معتمد ۸/۸ ذی قعدہ ۱۴۳۱ھ علی گڑھ

ترجمین: کلہ بشارت حسین محسن

Some of the other notable works of Dr Moazzam Ali Khan are given hereunder:

### **1. Famous ghazals**

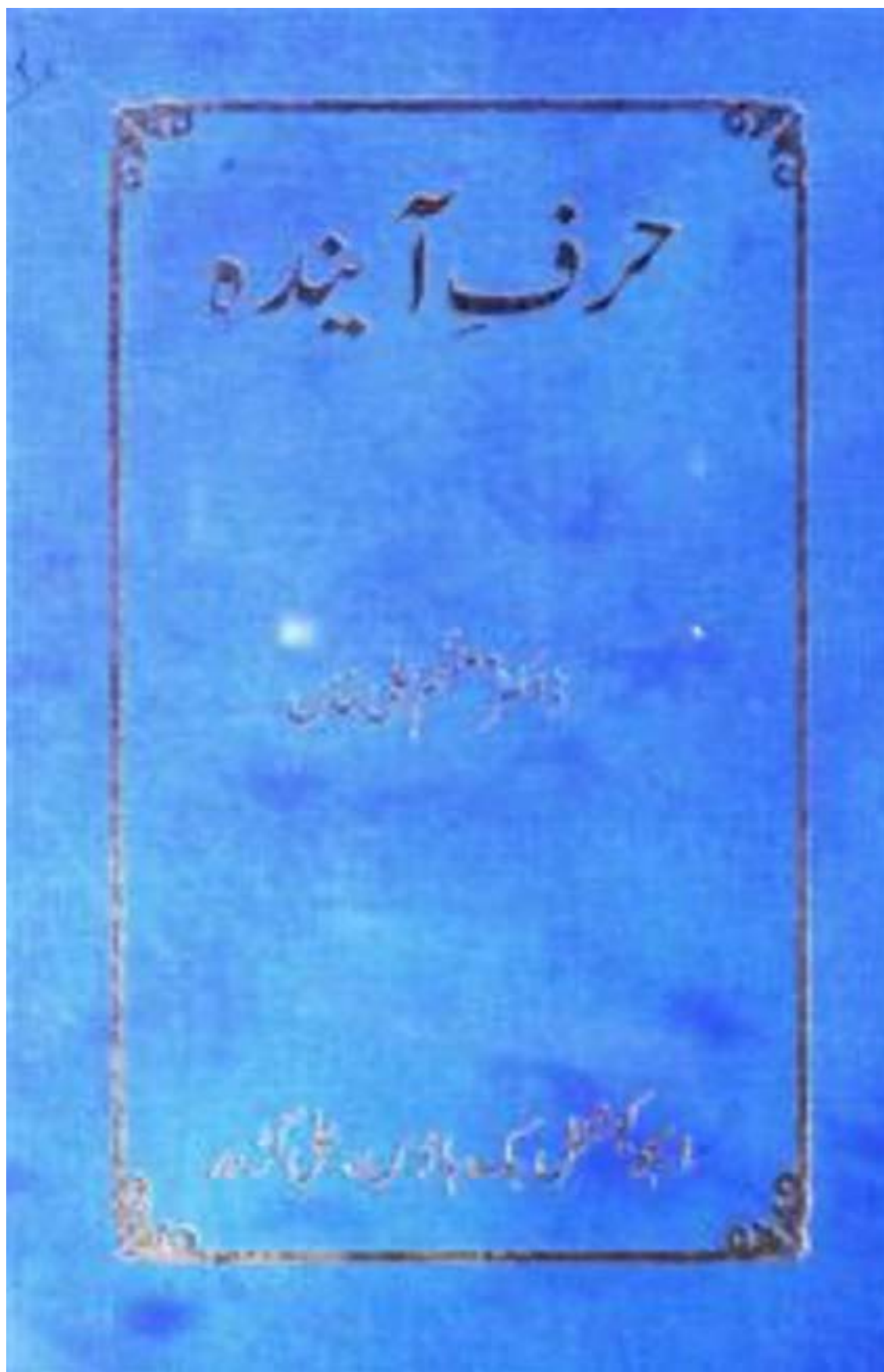
- ajnabi shahr mein ghar yaad aaya
- pattharon ke darmiyan bahti nadi achchhi lagi
- bahut qarib hai wo husn-e-aftab-numa
- sipurd-e-ah na karte to aur kya karte
- riwaj-e-qatl-e-insani bahut hai
- rang-e-shafaq bas husn-e-nazar ho ye bhi to ho sakta hai
- tark-e-ulfat mein hai aaram bahut

### **2. NAZMs**

- ai Aligarh
- man ki mamta bap ki shafqat tera aaghosh hai
- eid ka chand dekh kar
- subh KHairaat ke aangan mein gharibi hogi
- holi
- muKHtalif rang bikharte hain tere aangan mein
- nazr-e-nanak
- hind mein saikDon paida hue yun

### **3. Books**

- Harf-e-Aainda, 2005
- Rakhse sada
- naKHlistaan jild 18 sh. 2000, 1999







سہ ماہی  
تخلصات  
جے پور



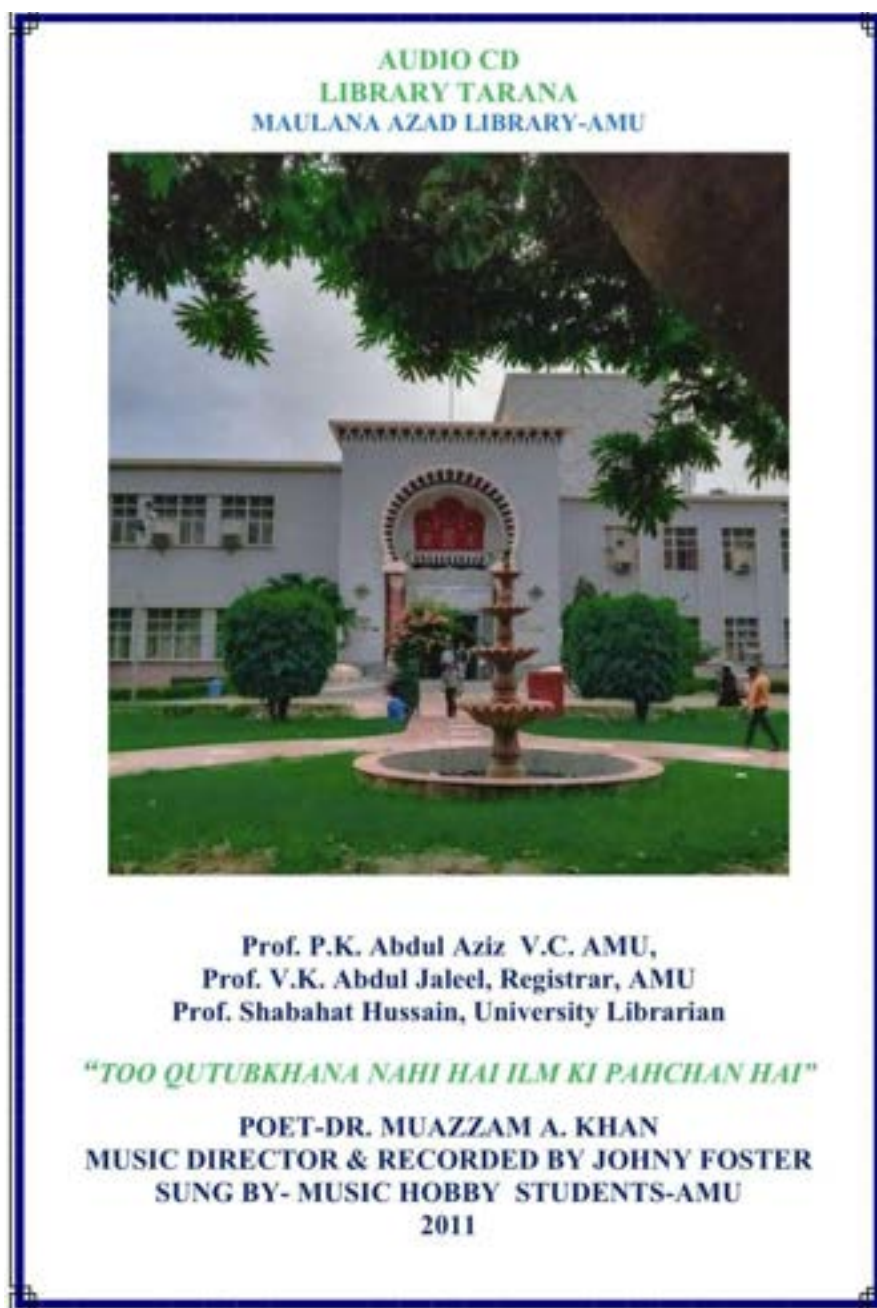
راجستھان اُردو اکادمی  
ڈی. سی. سہاسی بزرگ، سی ایٹیم، جے پور (راجستھان)

Rs. 15/-

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570  
1728 51-20  
1979

#### **4. Music composer of Tarana-e-Maulana Azad Library: Mr Jhony Foster**

Further enriching the celebration, Mr Jhony Foster—an alumnus, renowned poet, musician, and singer—composed the music for the library tarana and rendered it in his own voice. An audio CD of the same was also released during the Golden Jubilee celebrations in 2011. A photograph of the CD cover is reproduced below:





**MAJAZ LUCKNOWI**

**Majaz Lucknowi**  
(19.10.1911 - 05.12.1955)

Asrarul Haq 'Majaz Lucknowi' the composer of Tarana-i-Aligarh "Yeh Mera Chaman hai mera chaman, mein apne chaman ka bulbul hoon" was born in Barabanki (U.P.). After completing his education from Lucknow, he moved to Aligarh where from he graduated in 1936 and later joined All India Radio. He was one of the founders of Progressive Writers Movement. He started an Urdu journal titled 'Naya Adab', the progressive mouthpiece of the era. He did believe in revolution but was by temperament a romantic Poet. Therefore, he has been termed as Keats of India. He breathed his last in Lucknow.

#### 4. Asrarul Haq Majaz

When we speak of the aforesaid composition of Library Tarana, how can one forget the composer of **University Tarana, by the son of the soil, Asrarul Haq Majaz**. His contribution to Aligarh Muslim University is truly immortal. Like countless generations of Aligarhians across the world, I too remain a devoted admirer of this poet, who in his brief yet brilliant life left an indelible mark not only on the history of Urdu poetry but also on the cultural heritage of AMU. As will be detailed in Chapter 10, during a cleaning drive of the library's seventh-floor stacks, several **portraits of Sir Syed's comrades were recovered in a depleted state**. Among them was the **portrait of the great Majaz**. After refurbishment, while the **other portraits found their rightful place** alongside the founder's image in the central Hall of the library, **Majaz's portrait** did not fit into that sequence. I therefore made the conscious decision to place it in the left corner of the central hall, just above the showcase of "Must Read Books," ensuring that his presence would inspire every visitor. Wanting to include something worthy about this legendary poet, I felt like a layman before his towering stature, and thus requested Prof. Imtiaz Ahmad, Department of Urdu, to kindly contribute a write-up. His gracious acceptance and thoughtful words about the great poet will surely offer readers a glimpse into the life and legacy of one of AMU's most cherished sons.

#### Asrarul Haq Majaz (1911-1955)

مجاز لکھنوی (1911-1955) کا شمار اردو کے ممتاز رومانی شاعروں ۛ

- شاعروں میں ہوتا ہے

ان کا پورا نام اسرار الحق تھا - چنانچہ انہوں نے خود بھی لکھا ہے

خوب پہچان لو اسرار ہوں میں

جنس الفت کا خریدار ہوں میں

ان کے گھر کا نام جگن بھیا تھا۔ وہ لکھنؤ کے مضافات میں واقع مشہور علاقہ ردولی کے رہنے والے تھے - بہ علاقہ اپنے شاعروں اور ادیبوں کے لیے مشہور ہے - مجاز نے ابتدائی تعلیم اپنے وطن میں حاصل کی۔ 1929ء میں سینٹ جانس کالج آگرہ میں داخلہ لیا۔ وہیں فانی بدایونی اور معین احسن جذبی سے ملاقات ہوئی۔ 1930ء میں وہ علی گڑھ آ گئے - یہاں بی۔ اے میں داخلہ لیا اور فلسفہ، معاشیات اور اردو اختیاری مضامین لیے - یہاں ہوسٹل



کی زندگی نے ان میں آزادی اور کھلنڈرا پن پیدا کیا - نتیجہ کے طور پر کئی بار فیل ہونے کے بعد 1935ء میں بی - اے کا امتحان پاس کیا - یہیں ایم - اے - اردو

میں داخلہ لیا۔ اسی زمانے میں آل انڈیا ریڈیو، دہلی کے رسالے آواز کی ایڈیٹری کا اشتہار شائع ہوا۔ اس کے لیے درخواست دے دی۔ اور منتخب کر لیے گئے - چنانچہ لگ بھگ ایک سال وہاں ملازمت کی۔ اور پھر واپس علی گڑھ آ گئے - بعد ازاں لکھنؤ سے شایع ہونے والے رسالوں نیا ادب اور پرچم کی ادارت میں شامل رہے - اس زمانے کی جدو جہد کی داستان سردار جعفری نے لکھنؤ کی پانچ راتیں میں بہت خوبصورتی سے جمع کر دی ہیں بعد میں مجاز ہارڈنگ لائبریری دہلی میں اسسٹنٹ لائبریرین ہو گئے لیکن اپنے رومانی اور انقلابی نظریات کی - وجہ سے وہ کہیں ایک جگہ جم نہیں سکے - وہ اپنی نسل کے ذہین ترین لوگوں میں تھے - فیض احمد فیض، - سردار جعفر، سبط، معین احسن جذبی، وغیرہ کا ایک پورا گروپ تھا

مجاز ایک ایسے خاندان سے تعلق رکھتے تھے جس کا ہر ذرہ آفتاب تھا۔ ان کے بھائی انصار ہاروانی ممتاز جان نثار اختر کی بیگم اور جاوید اختر کی والدہ تھیں - جان نثار اختر کے نام ان ' صحافی تھے - ایک بہن صفیہ کے خطوط کے مجموعے " زیر لب" اور "حرف آشنا" کے نام سے شایع ہو چکے ہیں اور ان کے مضامین کا مجموعہ "انداز نظر" بھی اردو ادب میں اضافے کی حیثیت رکھتا ہے - ان کی دوسری بہن حمیدہ سالم بھی اپنی خودنوشت سوانح عمری "شورشِ دوراں" اور اپنی یادوں پر مشتمل کتاب "ہم ساتھ تھے" "پرچہانیوں کے اجالے" اور ناول "بردم رواں ہے زندگی" کے لیے یاد رکھی جائیں گی۔ یہ کتابیں مجاز اور ان کے بھائیوں اور بہنوں کے - ذکر سے بھری پڑی ہیں

- مجاز نے اپنی شاعری اور شخصیت کا تعارف کراتے ہوئے خود ہی لکھا ہے

عشق ہی عشق ہے دنیا میری

فتنہ عقل سے بیزار ہوں میں

عیب جو حافظ و خیام میں تھا

ہاں کچھ اس کا بھی گنہ ر ہوں میں

زندگی کیا ہے گناہ ہے آدم

زندگی ہے تو گنہگار ہوں میں

اک چمکتا ہوا شعلہ ہوں میں

ایک چلتی ہوئی تلوار ہوں میں

فیض احمد فیض نے مجاز کو ایک غنائی شاعر قرار دیتے ہوئے بجا طور پر ان کی شاعری کے تین بنیادی - عناصر قرار دیئے ہیں - ان عناصر کی طرف خود انہوں نے اپنے اس شعر میں اشارہ کیا ہے

دیکھ شمشیر ہے یہ، ساز ہے یہ، جام ہے یہ

تو جو شمشیر اٹھا لے تو بڑا کام ہے یہ

عشق، انقلاب، اور نغمگی سے ان کی شاعری کی عمارت تعمیر ہوئی ہے - یہ تینوں چیزیں اس زمانے کی سب سے اہم ادبی تحریک کا حصہ تھیں - اس تحریک کے شاعر اور ادیب انجمن ترقی پسند مصنفین کے علم بردار تھے جو بائیں بازو کی سیاست سے نظر یاتی ہم آہنگی رکھتی تھی - اس لئے وہ لوگ ظلم و جبر کی ہر صورت کے خلاف تھے - ملک کی آزادی، خواتین کی آزادی، غریب اور مزدور طبقہ کی آزادی محنت کش طبقہ کا ساتھ اور سرمایہ داری کی مخالفت ان کے خاص موضوعات تھے - ان کی نظمیں ”سرمایہ داری“، ”مزدوروں کا گیت“، اور نوجوان خاتون سے ”اس سلسلے کی نمائندہ مثالیں ہیں - نظم ”نوجوان خاتون سے“ کے یہ اشعار خاص طور سے ہمیشہ یاد رکھے جائیں گے

خود اپنے حسن کو پردہ بنا لیتی تو اچھا تھا حجاب فتنہ پرور تو اٹھا لیتی تو اچھا تھا

تو اس نشتر کی تیزی آزما لیتی تو اچھا تھا تیری نیچی نظر خود تیری عصمت کی محافظ ہے

تو اس آنچل سے اک پرچم بنا لیتی تو اچھا تھا ترے ماتھے پہ یہ آنچل بہت ہی خوب ہے لیکن

اسی طرح اپنی نظم ”انقلاب“ میں وہ براہ راست نوجوانوں کو خطاب کر کے کہتے ہیں

جو ہو سکے تو ابھی انقلاب پیدا کر تو انقلاب کی آمد کا انتظار نہ کر

- مجاز نے ترقی پسند تحریک کے دوسرے نوجوان لکھنے والوں کے ساتھ اپنا شعری سفر شروع کیا

ان کا بہترین زمانہ ان کی علی گڑھ کی طالب علمی کا زمانہ تھا - یہیں انہوں نے اپنی بہترین نظمیں لکھیں - یہیں ان کی بے پناہ مقبولیت کا آغاز ہوا - کچھ روایتوں کے مطابق انہیں اتنی مقبولیت حاصل ہوئی کہ عبداللہ گریس کالج کی لڑکیاں اپنے تکیہ کے نیچے ان کا مجموعہ رکھ کر سوتی تھیں - مجاز نے اردو کی دو مقبول ترین شعری اصناف غزل اور نظم نے شاعری کی - ان کی نظموں میں ”آوارہ“ ”نذر علی گڑھ“ اور ”نورا“ ”ننھی پجارن“ خاص طور سے بہت مشہور ہوئیں - ملک کی آزادی کے بعد مجاز کی نظم ”نذر علی گڑھ“ علی گڑھ مسلم - یونیورسٹی کا ترانہ قرار دی گئی

- ان کی نظریاتی شاعری سے قطع نظر ان کے یہ مصرعے بھی مقبول خاص و عام ہیں

چہلکے تیری آنکھوں سے شراب اور زیادہ

مہکیں ترے عارض کے گلاب اور زیادہ

اللہ کرے زور و شباب اور زیادہ

ان تمام خوبیوں کے باوجود ان کی ذاتی ناکامیوں کی وجہ سے 1940ء سے 1953ء تک ان پر تین بار دیوانگی کا حملہ ہوا – مجبوراً ان کو رانچی کے ذہنی مریضوں کے اسپتال میں داخل کرنا پڑا – چہ مہینے میں وہ ٹھیک ہو کر گھر واپس آ گئے لیکن یہ واپسی ہمیشہ ہمیشہ کی رخصتی کے لئے تھی

تمام دوسرے رومانی شعرا کی طرح انہوں نے اپنی مختصر عمر میں بہت سے قابل ذکر کام کئے اور بالآخر ایک یادگار شاعری چھوڑ کر ہم سب سے رخصت ہو گئے

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### AMU Tarana

سرشار نگاہ نرگس ہوں پا بستہ گیسوئے سنبل ہوں

یہ میرا چمن ہے میرا چمن میں اپنے چمن کا بلبل ہوں

ہر آن یہاں صہبائے کہن اک ساغر نو میں ڈھلتی ہے

کلیوں سے حسن ٹپکتا ہے پھولوں سے جوانی ابلتی ہے

جو طاق حرم میں روشن ہے وہ شمع یہاں بھی جلتی ہے

اس دشت کے گوشے گوشے سے اک جوئے حیات ابلتی ہے

اسلام کے اس بت خانے میں اصنام بھی ہیں اور آذر بھی

تہذیب کے اس مے خانے میں شمشیر بھی ہے اور ساغر بھی

یاں حسن کی برق چمکتی ہے یاں نور کی بارش ہوتی ہے

ہر آہ یہاں اک نغمہ ہے ہر اشک یہاں اک موتی ہے



ہر شام ہے شام مصر یہاں ہر شب ہے شب شیراز یہاں  
بے سارے جہاں کا سوز یہاں اور سارے جہاں کا ساز یہاں

یہ دشت جنوں دیوانوں کا یہ بزم وفا پروانوں کی  
یہ شہر طرب رومانوں کا یہ خلد بریں ارمانوں کی

فطرت نے سکھائی ہے ہم کو افتاد یہاں پرواز یہاں  
گائے ہیں وفا کے گیت یہاں چھیڑا ہے جنوں کا ساز یہاں

اس فرش سے ہم نے اڑا کر افلاک کے تارے توڑے ہیں  
نابید سے کی ہے سرگوشی پروین سے رشتے جوڑے ہیں

اس بزم میں تیغیں کھینچی ہیں اس بزم میں ساغر توڑے ہیں  
اس بزم میں آنکھ بچھائی ہے اس بزم میں دل تک جوڑے ہیں

اس بزم میں نیزے پھینکے ہیں اس بزم میں خنجر چومے ہیں  
اس بزم میں گر کر تڑپے ہیں اس بزم میں پی کر جھومے ہیں

آ آ کے ہزاروں بار یہاں خود آگ بھی ہم نے لگائی ہے  
پھر سارے جہاں نے دیکھا ہے یہ آگ ہمیں نے بچھائی ہے

یاں ہم نے کمندیں ڈالی ہیں یاں ہم نے شب خوں مارے ہیں

یاں ہم نے قبائیں نوچی ہیں یاں ہم نے تاج اتارے ہیں

ہر آہ ہے خود تاثیر یہاں ہر خواب ہے خود تعبیر یہاں

تدبیر کے پائے سنگیں پر جھک جاتی ہے تقدیر یہاں

ذرات کا بوسہ لینے کو سو بار جھکا آکاش یہاں

خود آنکھ سے ہم نے دیکھی ہے باطل کی شکست فاش یہاں

اس گل کدہ پارینہ میں پھر آگ بھڑکنے والی ہے

پھر ابر گرجنے والے ہیں پھر برق کڑکنے والی ہے

جو ابر یہاں سے اٹھے گا وہ سارے جہاں پر برسے گا

ہر جوئے رواں پر برسے گا ہر کوہ گراں پر برسے گا

ہر سرو و سمن پر برسے گا ہر دشت و دمن پر برسے گا

خود اپنے چمن پر برسے گا غیروں کے چمن پر برسے گا

ہر شہر طرب پر گرجے گا ہر قصر طرب پر کڑکے گا

یہ ابر ہمیشہ برسا ہے یہ ابر ہمیشہ برسے گا

## Chapter 6

### Shifting Lytton Library to Maulana Azad Library (1960):

#### Syed Bashiruddin's Role

##### 1. Introduction

The Lytton Library, established in 1877, served as the college library of the Mohammedan Anglo-Oriental (MAO) College until the institution was transformed into a full-fledged university by an Act of Parliament in 1920. With this transition, the Lytton Library itself became the University Library, meeting the growing demands of the AMU community until its relocation to the new seven-storied building inaugurated by Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru in 1960.

##### 2. fundamental contribution: From Vision to Institution

At the helm since 1922, Syed Bashiruddin Ahmed began his career as Assistant Librarian and, after completing a Certificate Course in Library Science at the University of London in 1932, rose to the position of University Librarian.

It must be clearly understood that an architect alone cannot plan a library unless guided by a senior library professional. Just as a developer cannot design a website without the vision of a designer, so too the planning of the Maulana Azad Library required the insight of a librarian. From the laying of the foundation stone in 1955 to its inauguration in 1960, **Bashiruddin worked in close coordination with Mohammed Fayazuddin**, the celebrated architect from Hyderabad, ensuring that the building was not merely an architectural marvel but a functional academic institution.

##### 3. Emphasising the Librarian's Role in Planning

To reinforce the aforementioned point, I recall an episode from my professional life. In 2010, I was invited as one of three experts to conduct the **selection for the post of University Librarian at the Central University of Rajasthan**. After the committee proceedings, the Vice Chancellor, Prof. (Dr) Manikrao M. Salunkhe, requested us to visit both the makeshift University Library and the permanent site where a new library

was to be planned with the assistance of a **renowned architect based in Green Park, New Delhi.**

Upon reviewing the initial drawings, we found several **fundamental lacunae** and conveyed our concerns. The Vice Chancellor then asked another expert from Delhi and me to hold detailed discussions with the architect and his team of engineers. Over the course of **four meetings in Delhi**, we had to educate them about the intricacies of library planning—from functional workflows to reader services and collection management. Only after these consultations were **new drawings finalised.**

Apart from the above-mentioned experience as well as a few others, underline a broader truth that **library buildings designed without consultation of librarians often suffer from inherent defects.** Such flaws may be managed but can never be fully removed.

It is precisely this professional insight that made **Syed Bashiruddin Ahmed's contribution to the Maulana Azad Library so fundamental**—his vision ensured that the institution was not merely an architectural structure, but a living academic space, where collections, readers, and scholarship could thrive in harmony.

#### **4. Bashiruddin's guiding principle for M.A. library planning was language-based allocation of collections.**

*The following points explain the basis of Bashiruddin's guiding principle:*

- **Language-based allocation**

The **Central Library of AMU** is renowned for its Urdu, Persian, and Arabic collections, and most importantly, its treasure of over **16,000 manuscripts and artefacts.** Yet the **majority of holdings comprise books in English**, covering all disciplines including Science and Technology.

- **English collections**

The **growth rate of English collections** far outpaced that of Oriental languages, leading to the allocation of the seven-storied stacks for English-language books.

- **Oriental and Manuscripts Divisions**

Meanwhile, the **Urdu, Persian, Arabic, and Hindi collections** were separately housed — along with **dedicated reading facilities — on the first floor** of the main building. The Manuscripts Division was kept close to the Oriental Division, keeping in view the linguistic closeness of the disciplines covered, as well as security purposes.

➤ **Textbooks Section**

Given the consistently high demand, the **Textbooks Section** was strategically located on the **ground floor of the stack building**, adjacent to the issue and return desks. This placement ensured quick accessibility and facilitated efficient circulation for the largest group of users.

➤ **Reading Halls**

Of the two reading halls, one was **exclusively allocated to undergraduate students**, providing them with a focused environment for textbook study. The other was reserved for **postgraduates and research scholars**, equipped with reference and research materials to support advanced academic work. This thoughtful division reflected the library's commitment to **serving both general study needs and specialised scholarly pursuits**.

## **5. Preserving Sir Syed's Vision**

The above-mentioned arrangement preserved the **legacy of Sir Syed Ahmad Khan's vision of modern education** — a vision deeply rooted in cultural and religious traditions, yet firmly oriented toward scientific progress. By harmonising these dimensions, the library ensured its **relevance and scientific ethos for generations to come**.

The credit for this rare blend of **architectural collaboration and professional librarianship** belongs to one man: **Syed Bashiruddin Ahmed**. His foresight transformed the Maulana Azad Library from a mere architectural structure into a living academic institution, embodying both tradition and modernity.

***Regrettably, the institutional culture of the University has often been characterized by a short memory. Contributions that shaped its foundations are too easily forgotten, with little or no effort made to investigate how systems were initiated or sustained. The present is enjoyed without acknowledgement of the***

*past — a past painstakingly built by individuals like Bashiruddin, whose vision transformed a building into an enduring institution.*

## **6. Transferring the Lytton Library Collections into the new Maulana Azad Library building**

At this pivotal moment, **Syed Bashiruddin Ahmed undertook the monumental responsibility of transferring the Lytton Library's multilingual collections** into the newly built Maulana Azad Library. Volumes in **English, Urdu, Arabic, Persian, Hindi, Sanskrit, and other languages** were not merely shifted but **carefully relocated to their designated sections and meticulously integrated into the accession registers**. Only after this painstaking process did the library begin recording new acquisitions, ensuring continuity, order, and scholarly integrity in its expanding collections.

His **meticulous planning of merging the collections of the Lytton Library with the newly developing holdings of the Maulana Azad Library** in the accession registers remains a professional lesson — especially for budding librarians. Unfortunately, the original accession registers of the Lytton Library, **preserved in the Accession Section and the Oriental Division**, are today in a dilapidated condition. Despite the presence of a full-fledged Bindery section with qualified staff, these invaluable records are on the verge of extinction, though they could and should have been safeguarded for future generations of librarians.

Bashiruddin's achievement was extraordinary: he ensured that the legacy of the Lytton Library was seamlessly integrated into the new Maulana Azad Library — a rare blend of architectural collaboration and professional librarianship. Yet this feat of vision and precision has faded from collective memory, even within AMU's own library school.

One purpose of this book is to restore recognition to his overlooked contribution, affirming his role in shaping the foundations of the Maulana Azad Library with the dignity it deserves. The infrastructure he established continues to guide the library's functioning, even as it has evolved from manual to automated systems.

Tellingly, **Bashiruddin's name survives only in the Librarians' Gallery**, with no Division or Reading Room dedicated to him. For a figure whose vision laid the very foundations of the Maulana Azad Library, this silence is striking. A dedicated space in

his honour would have been not merely symbolic, but **a rightful tribute to his enduring contribution** — ensuring that generations of scholars remember the man who transformed a building into an institution.

## **7. Library Collection and its Services**

A university library's strength lies in the balance between its **collection and its services**. The collection — books, journals, theses, manuscripts, and digital resources — forms the intellectual backbone, preserving knowledge across disciplines and generations. Yet, without effective services, even the richest collection remains underutilised. Reader services such as cataloguing, circulation, reference guidance, and digital access transform stored knowledge into living resources. Together, they ensure continuity of learning, inclusivity, and academic excellence. A vast collection provides depth, while strong services provide accessibility; only in their integration does a university library truly become a beacon of scholarship and cultural preservation.

### **➤ Print Collection**

As per the information provided on the official website,<sup>1</sup> *“Maulana Azad Library is one of the largest university libraries in the world, with more than 117 sister libraries (college/departmental libraries). In all, it possesses more than 14 lakh volumes of documents.”*

However, this figure of “more than 14 lakhs” appears inconsistent with the detailed statistics given in the accompanying table, which records a total of **16,57,705 volumes** (excluding 142 subscribed journals). It is important to note that current journal titles are not counted in the collection until their issues are bound into volumes, at which point each bound volume is accessioned as a book.

Furthermore, the bound volumes of periodicals already held in the library have not been included in the total collection figure. The most recent collection details, as published on the library's website, are reproduced below for reference:

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<sup>1</sup> <https://www.amu.ac.in/libraries/maulana-azad-library/library-collection> Accessed on 07-09-1926

| Collection (Print)                                                           | Quantity       |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| <b>Books (Text, Reference, Gifted)</b><br>(including Departmental Libraries) | <b>1409715</b> |
| <b>Oriental Collection (Hindi, Sanskrit, Persian, Urdu, Arabic)</b>          | <b>187705</b>  |
| <b>Theses &amp; Dissertations</b>                                            | <b>20968</b>   |
| <b>Books (in Braille Script)</b>                                             | <b>3200*</b>   |
| <b>Manuscripts</b>                                                           | <b>16117</b>   |
| <b>Rare Books</b>                                                            | <b>20000</b>   |
| <b>Journals (subscribed)</b>                                                 | <b>142</b>     |

A much better description of Library Collections was first provided by Dr Ishrat Ali Qureshi (1989)<sup>2</sup> with a language-wise breakup as under, followed by this author (as on 31-03-2026):

| Language                         | Volumes (as on 31-03-1988) | Volumes (as on 31-03-2026) |
|----------------------------------|----------------------------|----------------------------|
| English                          | 5,59,003                   | 10, 45000                  |
| (including occidental languages) |                            |                            |
| Urdu                             | 95,402                     | <b>1,98,963</b>            |
| Arabic                           | 24,871                     | <b>43, 485</b>             |
| Persian                          | 14,996                     | <b>22,889</b>              |
| Hindi                            | 30,353                     | <b>47,604</b>              |
| Sanskrit                         | 6,136                      | <b>9317</b>                |
| Malayalam                        | 3,298                      | 6562                       |

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<sup>2</sup> Qureshi, Ishrat Ali. The Maulana Azad Library: A major Library of the world, 1877-1988. Aligarh, Anwar Publishing House, 1989



|              |                 |                  |
|--------------|-----------------|------------------|
| Telugu       | 1,945           | 2934             |
| Tamil        | 1,110           | 3200             |
| Braille      | 1,033           | 3200             |
| <b>Total</b> | <b>7,38,147</b> | <b>13,83,154</b> |

Here also, the figures provided are self-contradictory, as mentioned on the MAL website:

**Oriental Collection (Hindi, Sanskrit, Persian, Urdu, Arabic) =1,87,705<sup>3</sup>**

Whereas the current:

**Oriental Collection (Hindi, Sanskrit, Persian, Urdu, Arabic) =3,22,258<sup>4</sup>**

➤ **Gifted Urdu collections**

The library has been receiving collections from scholars and prominent personalities in their own field, as given hereunder:

| <b>S.No.</b> | <b>Name of Collection</b>           | <b>No. of Volumes</b> | <b>Remarks</b>       |
|--------------|-------------------------------------|-----------------------|----------------------|
| <b>1</b>     | <b>Aftab collection</b>             | <b>1795</b>           |                      |
| <b>2</b>     | <b>Ansarullah collection</b>        | <b>468</b>            | <b>(Unprocessed)</b> |
| <b>3</b>     | <b>Asghar Abbas collection</b>      | <b>1347</b>           |                      |
| <b>4</b>     | <b>Chighani collection</b>          | <b>259</b>            |                      |
| <b>5</b>     | <b>Faruqi collection</b>            | <b>892</b>            |                      |
| <b>6</b>     | <b>Haneef Naqvi collection</b>      | <b>1019</b>           |                      |
| <b>7</b>     | <b>Kaifi Azmi collection</b>        | <b>3210</b>           |                      |
| <b>8</b>     | <b>Kewal Dheer collection</b>       | <b>1240</b>           |                      |
| <b>9</b>     | <b>Khursheedul Islam collection</b> | <b>642</b>            |                      |

<sup>3</sup> <https://www.amu.ac.in/libraries/maulana-azad-library/library-collection>

<sup>4</sup> As per record on 31-03-2026

|           |                                      |             |
|-----------|--------------------------------------|-------------|
| <b>10</b> | <b>Masood Husain collection</b>      | <b>1452</b> |
| <b>11</b> | <b>Naaz Ansari collection</b>        | <b>1450</b> |
| <b>12</b> | <b>Nazeer Ahmad collection</b>       | <b>664</b>  |
| <b>13</b> | <b>Pakistani Collection</b>          | <b>3113</b> |
| <b>14</b> | <b>Rahat Abrar collection</b>        | <b>270</b>  |
| <b>15</b> | <b>Syed Hamid collection</b>         | <b>1678</b> |
| <b>16</b> | <b>Saxena collection</b>             | <b>1257</b> |
| <b>17</b> | <b>Subhan Allah collection</b>       | <b>736</b>  |
| <b>18</b> | <b>Usmania collection</b>            | <b>506</b>  |
| <b>19</b> | <b>Zahida Zaidi collection</b>       | <b>668</b>  |
| <b>20</b> | <b>Zia Ahmad collection</b>          | <b>1680</b> |
| <b>21</b> | <b>Zoe Ansari collection</b>         | <b>426</b>  |
| <b>22</b> | <b>Mukhtaruddin Arzoo collection</b> | <b>1537</b> |

#### ➤ **Manuscripts Collection**

The Manuscripts Section forms the intellectual nucleus of a great library, safeguarding rare and irreplaceable treasures of human thought. Mostly acquired through gifts, patronage, and careful procurement, these manuscripts embody centuries of scholarship across diverse disciplines. They not only preserve the cultural and spiritual heritage of past civilisations but also serve as invaluable sources for researchers in fields such as theology, literature, science, and history.

Though the Maulana Azad Library has embraced modernisation in recent years, it remains especially renowned for its priceless holdings in Orientalia and its treasure trove of nearly 16,117 Islamic manuscripts, originating from the personal collection of the founder, Sir Syed Ahmad Khan, an ardent lover of manuscripts. Many manuscripts in the library's collection fall into the “rarest of the rare” category. Among these is a

revered fragment of the Holy Qur'an, inscribed on parchment in Kufi script, traditionally attributed to Hazrat Ali (A.S.), the fourth Caliph of Islam. The collection also preserves several royal decrees of Mughal emperors, alongside remarkable Persian translations of ancient Sanskrit classics such as the Bhagavad Gita, Mahabharata, and Leelawati, rendered by Abul Faiz Faizi, an eminent scholar at Emperor Akbar's court. These treasures, spanning subjects from Hadith, Tasawwuf (Sufism), Tibb (Medicine), Literature, Tarikh-e-Islam (Islamic History), Mathematics, Astronomy, Jawahirat (Gemmology), Biographical works, and more, make the library a magnet for scholars worldwide.

The collection also includes two copies of Sahih al-Bukhari:

- (Juz 13, 14, 15) — the only copy in the world transcribed by Allama Ibn-e-Hajar Asqalani in 843 H./1439 A.D.
- A golden, beautifully illuminated khatt-i-naskh calligraphy, reported to have been in the personal use of Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb Alamgir (noted by the Tahwildar of the emperor's library in 1094 H.)

A few manuscripts highlighted in this chapter are remarkable for their richness and representativeness, offering profound insight into the literary and cultural traditions they embody. A vivid and detailed account of some of the invaluable manuscripts has been presented in Chapter 7 of the book, where their historical and scholarly significance is comprehensively described.

### ➤ **The Gifted collections**

Of the many collections preserved in the Maulana Azad Library, the Manuscripts Division is regarded as one of the most prestigious, for it houses invaluable manuscripts, some of which belong to the rarest of the rare category, with only a single copy available in the entire world. The present description traces its origin to the nucleus formed by the manuscripts donated by Sir Syed Ahmad Khan, the founder of the Muhammadan Anglo-Oriental College, who had a deep passion for collecting and preserving such treasures. Among the manuscripts from his personal collection is the celebrated Tarikh-e-Gazida, enriched with marginal notes by Abul Faiz Faizi, the renowned scholar and courtier of Emperor Akbar. From this modest beginning, the collection steadily grew, and while in 1924 the number of manuscripts stood at only

628, by 1989 it had expanded to an impressive 14,500. The strength of the division lies in its diverse collections, as documented by Qureshi<sup>5</sup>. Together, these holdings form a living archive of centuries of intellectual, cultural, and spiritual heritage, offering scholars of Islamic studies, oriental learning, medieval Indian history, literature, medicine, astronomy, and philosophy an unparalleled resource. The Manuscripts Division thus stands not merely as a repository but as a custodian of civilisation's memory, embodying Sir Syed's vision of preserving knowledge for posterity and making it accessible to seekers of true knowledge.

The Manuscripts of the Maulana Azad Library, comprising a total of thirteen distinct collections, may broadly be classified into two categories:

1. Collections received as gifts from eminent scholars and bibliophiles.
2. Collections acquired by the University Library, either through purchase or as occasional donations from individuals.

The larger collections have been preserved separately, retaining their individuality, and are traditionally identified by the names of their original owners — a practice that honours their legacy and ensures scholarly recognition.

In the following paragraphs, an analysis of the growth of these collections has been undertaken. For this purpose, data has been compiled from the following four different authoritative sources, allowing us to trace how the division expanded over time and how its holdings evolved into one of the richest repositories of manuscripts in the country.

1. Qureshi, Ishrat Ali. The Maulana Azad Library: A major Library of the world, 1877-1988. Aligarh, Anwar Publishing House, 1989. P. 29.
2. The Descriptive catalogue of Arabic manuscripts of the Habib Ganj collection, Maulana Azad Library. Vol. 2, compiled by M.H. Qaiser under the guidance of M.H. Razvi. Aligarh: Maulana Azad Library, 1993.
3. Catalogue of manuscripts in Maulana Azad Library: Compiled and edited by Amjad Ali. Aligarh; Publication Division, AMU. 2019.
4. Library website: Current Hand List of Manuscripts

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<sup>5</sup> Qureshi, Ishrat Ali. The Maulana Azad Library: A major Library of the world, 1877-1988. Aligarh, Anwar Publishing House, 1989. P. 29.

This classification and historical analysis not only reveal the organic growth of the division but also underscore the role of scholars, benefactors, and the University itself in shaping a treasure house of knowledge that continues to serve generations of researchers.

| S. No. | Name of Collection                 | Manuscripts Number<br>Reference 1<br>1989 | Manuscripts Number<br>Reference 2<br>1993 | Manuscripts Number<br>Reference 3<br>2019 | Current Hand List of Manuscripts<br><a href="https://webopac.amu.ac.in/mal/manu.php">https://webopac.amu.ac.in/mal/manu.php</a> |
|--------|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1.     | Abdul Hai collection               | 1,552                                     | 1500                                      | 1500                                      | Records 1 to 1889 = 1889                                                                                                        |
| 2.     | Abdul Salam collection             | 575                                       | 563                                       | 569                                       | Records 1890 to 2538 = 649                                                                                                      |
| 3.     | Aftab collection                   | 115                                       | 131                                       | 131                                       | Records 10689 to 10819 = 131                                                                                                    |
| 4.     | Ahsan collection                   | 353                                       | 447                                       | 447                                       | Records 10253 to 10688 = 436                                                                                                    |
| 5.     | Habeeb Ganj collection             | 1,616                                     | 2000                                      | 2000                                      | Records<br>11045 to 12103 = 1059<br>12626 to 12919 = 294<br>13130 to 13423 = 294<br>Total 1647                                  |
| 6      | Jawahar Museum (Etawah) collection | 1,643                                     | 1243                                      | 1800                                      | Records 3020 to 4774 = 1755                                                                                                     |
| 7.     | Munir Alam collection              | 117                                       | 189                                       | 189                                       | Records 2539 to 2729 = 191                                                                                                      |
| 8.     | Qutbuddin collection               | 235                                       | 290                                       | 290                                       | Records 2730 to 3019 = 290                                                                                                      |
| 9.     | Shaifta collection                 | 209                                       | 224                                       | 224                                       | Records 10820 to 11044 = 225                                                                                                    |

|     |                            |       |       |              |                                                                                                                        |
|-----|----------------------------|-------|-------|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 10. | Subhan Allah collection    | 2399  | 2200  | 2,200        | Records<br>12104 to 12625= <b>522</b><br>12920 to 13129= <b>210</b><br>13424 to 13914= <b>491</b><br>Total <b>1223</b> |
| 11. | Sulaiman collection        | 1,412 | 1,384 | 1,384        | Records<br>4775 to 6213=<br>1438                                                                                       |
| 12. | University collection      | 4,330 | -     | 4,500        | Records<br>6630 to 10252<br>= <b>3623</b><br>13915 to 15147<br>= <b>1233</b><br>Total <b>4856</b>                      |
| 13. | Tibbiya College collection | -     | -     | 300          | Records<br>6214 to 6629<br>=416                                                                                        |
| 14  | Unnamed manuscripts        |       |       |              | Records<br>15148 to 15500<br>= 354                                                                                     |
|     |                            |       |       | <b>Total</b> | <b>15,534</b>                                                                                                          |
|     |                            |       |       |              | <b>15,500</b>                                                                                                          |

## Discrepancies

An analysis of the collections reveals several discrepancies in the recorded figures relating to the number of volumes in each collection:

1. In some cases, the number of manuscripts has increased (e.g., Collections 2–9, 11, 12, and 13).
2. In other cases, the number of manuscripts has significantly decreased (e.g., Collections 5 and 10).
3. The last 354 entries in the Hand List of Manuscripts available on the library's website remain uncategorised, with no indication of their placement in any collection.
4. Certain collections appear scattered across multiple locations, raising questions about consistency and preservation:

- Habeeb Ganj Collection at three different locations
  - Subhan Allah Collection at three different locations
  - University Collection at two different locations
5. To uphold scholarly accuracy and institutional credibility, the actual number of manuscripts in each collection must be verified and the corrected figures displayed on the library's official website.
  6. Equally important, the total number of manuscripts requires re-confirmation. The website continues to cite 16,117 manuscripts, whereas the Hand List shows only 15,000 manuscripts.

### ➤ **E-Resources: An Introduction**

Libraries today rely heavily on electronic resources (e-resources) such as e-books, e-journals, databases, digital archives, multimedia content, and open-access repositories. These resources provide 24/7 access, remote availability, and advanced search features, making them indispensable for students, researchers, and professionals.

Major types of E-Resources used in the libraries are listed here in tabular form:

| S.N | Type of E-Resources  | Description                                             | Examples/Uses                                 |
|-----|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| 1   | E-Books              | Digital versions of printed books.                      | Textbooks, reference works.                   |
| 2   | E-Journals           | Scholarly journals published online.                    | Science, medicine, humanities.                |
| 3   | Databases            | Searchable collections of information.                  | Scopus, JSTOR, ProQuest.                      |
| 4   | Digital Archives     | Digitized historical documents and manuscripts.         | National Digital Library, university archives |
| 5   | Multimedia Resources | Audio, video, images, podcasts, instructional materials | Recorded lectures, documentaries, apps.       |

|    |                          |                                                        |                                       |
|----|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| 6  | Open-Access Repositories | Free scholarly content available without subscription. | DOAJ, Project MUSE, arXiv.            |
| 7. | Datasets & Statistics    | Raw data for research and analysis                     | Indiastat, census data, survey files. |
| 8  | Reference Sources        | Online encyclopaedias, dictionaries,                   | Britannica, Oxford Reference          |

○ **Benefits of E-Resources**

- 24/7 Access – Users can consult materials anytime, anywhere.
- Remote Availability – Off-campus access supports distance learning.
- Enhanced Searchability – Quick keyword searches save time compared to manual browsing.
- Cost Efficiency – Reduces physical storage and printing costs.
- Inclusivity – Multiple users can access the same resource simultaneously.

○ **Challenges in Using E-Resources**

- Digital Literacy – Users must be trained to navigate platforms effectively.
- Licensing & Access Restrictions – Subscription models can limit availability.
- Technical Compatibility – Formats and platforms may not work across all devices.
- Digital Preservation – Ensuring long-term access to electronic content is complex.

○ **Why They Matter**

E-resources have transformed libraries into hybrid information centres, combining traditional print with digital access. For universities, they are vital in supporting research, teaching, and lifelong learning. They also democratize knowledge by allowing students in smaller towns to access the same scholarly content as those in major institutions.



### ➤ Digital Collection in M.A. Library<sup>6</sup>

The library website lists the following 23 Databases under the caption Databases:

BIS Complete

BMJ Case Reports

Britannica Library (Britannica Academic Guided Tour)

Cengage Gale Research Complete (How to access)

EBC Reader-Campus edition (How to access)

EBSCO Art & Architecture Complete (How to access)

EBSCO Business Source Elite (How to access)

EBSCO Dentistry & Oral Science (How to access)

EBSCO LISS (How to access)

Edzter (How to access)

HeinOnline

Indiastat (How to access)

J-Gate Complete (How to access)

JSTOR

Manupatra (How to access)

NotNul (How to access)

Project MUSE eBooks

ProQuest Dissertations & Theses

Prowess (How to access)

SCC Online (How to access)

SciFinder

Scopus (How to access)

UpToDate

**An analysis of the above list shows that Free / Open Access databases are included in the list without segregation from subscribed resources, as explained hereunder:**

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<sup>6</sup> <https://webopac.amu.ac.in/mal/webpage/> Accessed on 14-07-2026)

- **Free / Open Access**
  - Hein Online → While primarily subscription, it provides some open access collections (e.g., U.S. Presidential Library, COVID-19 resources, Law Journal Library sample content).
  - JSTOR → Offers a limited set of open access journals, books, and primary sources freely available without subscription
  - Project MUSE eBooks → Provides selected open access books and journals.
  - BMJ Case Reports → Individual articles may be open if authors paid for open access, but generally subscription.
  - Britannica Library (Academic Guided Tour) → The guided tour is open, but full content is subscription.
  - SciFinder → Subscription only, but some chemistry resources (like PubChem) are open elsewhere.
  - UpToDate → Subscription only, though patient education articles are sometimes freely accessible.
- **Truly open access portions:** JSTOR, Project MUSE, HeinOnline (selected collections).
- **Conditional open access:** BMJ Case Reports (if author paid), Britannica guided tour (demo only).
- **All others: Subscription-only.**
- **M.A.L.'s web page for Digital collection<sup>7</sup>** provides the following information:

| <b>Collection (Digital)</b>    | <b>Quantity</b> |
|--------------------------------|-----------------|
| e-Books (purchased)            | 2300 (approx.)  |
| e-Journals (subscribed)        | 8               |
| e-Journals (consortia)         | 13806           |
| Online Databases (subscribed)  | 13              |
| Online Databases (consortia) - |                 |
| Manuscripts (digitised)        | 16117           |

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<sup>7</sup> <https://www.amu.ac.in/libraries/maulana-azad-library/library-collection> (Accessed on 15-07-2026)

|                                         |        |
|-----------------------------------------|--------|
| Rare Books (digitized)                  | 13500  |
| Books in Oriental Languages (digitised) | 10424  |
| e-Theses & Dissertations                | 12325* |
| Others (miscellaneous languages)        |        |

➤ **Other digital resources of M.A.Library**

**The following link provides digital resources not available on the library's website<sup>8</sup>:**

<https://sites.google.com/view/malibrary/drc>

This link provides access to the freely available resources on the Digital Resource Centre (DRC), inaugurated by Prof. P. K. Abdul Azis, the then Vice Chancellor, on 16 March 2009. The Digital Resource Centre was one of the earliest initiatives to democratize access to global scholarly content at AMU.

Among its many digital resources, the DRC proudly comprises approximately 1.75 lakh e-books, downloaded free of cost from the First World e-Book Fair (sponsored by Project Gutenberg and the World Public Library), held from July 4 to August 4, 2009. The Fair offered free access to over 2.5 million e-books, enabling readers worldwide to download titles without restriction — a landmark initiative in democratizing knowledge. DRC's collection of 1.75 lakh e-books represents a treasure trove that could have significantly boosted MAL's profile in the age of digital transformation.

Unfortunately, the link for the downloaded e-books is no longer functional — much like nearly 50% of the other links on the same page. Even more regrettably, the DRC page has no connection with the main library website, leaving it isolated from the institutional framework. This disconnect has prevented the vast collection from being formally recognised as part of the Maulana Azad Library's e-book holdings, thereby diminishing the comparative size and prestige of MAL's digital collection when measured against other university libraries. As a result, the true size of MAL's digital collection remains understated when compared with the collections of other university libraries, despite

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<sup>8</sup> <https://sites.google.com/view/malibrary/drc> (Accessed on 15-07-2026)

the pioneering effort that went into establishing the DRC. More details of DRC will be provided in chapter 9.

In fact, towards the end of my tenure as Librarian-in-Charge of the Maulana Azad Library in 2012, I was considering a proposal to rename the library as “***Maulana Azad Library and Sir Syed’s Digital Resource Centre***.” This idea reflected my conviction that the DRC was not merely an adjunct but a pioneering extension of the library’s mission — a bridge between Sir Syed’s vision of modern knowledge and the digital age.

Keeping in view the vast number of digital resources available in the public domain, this dream found fuller realisation during my tenure as Dean, Faculty of Social Sciences (2012 to 2014), when the ***Social Science Cyber Library (socscocybraryamu.ac.in) — the first of its kind in the world*** — was inaugurated by Shri Pranab Mukherjee, Ex-President of India. Today, the Cybrary is being accessed in 176 countries, standing as a testament to the global reach of knowledge when vision and technology converge. **The Social Science Cyber Library has been dealt with separately because of its unique character.**

The DRC and the Cyber Library together remain pioneering efforts in digital resource creation, but their current isolation underscores the urgent need for integration, preservation, and modernisation so that the vision behind their establishment — and the spirit of the proposed renaming — can be fully realised.

The lack of integration with the main library website and cataloguing system reflects a missed opportunity in library modernisation and visibility.

Proper recognition and inclusion of the DRC collection would not only enhance MAL’s statistics but also honour the vision behind its creation.

The library plays a crucial role in enabling the university to achieve excellence in teaching, learning, and research. A well-qualified and dedicated library staff ensures high-quality services by optimising both library and web resources.

## Chapter 7

### Manuscripts Collection of the Maulana Azad Library<sup>1</sup> and Publication of *Nehjul Blagha*

#### Introduction

Though the Maulana Azad Library has embraced modernisation in recent years, it remains especially renowned for its priceless holdings in Orientalia and its treasure trove of nearly 16,117<sup>2</sup> Islamic manuscripts, many of which fall into the “*rarest of the rare*” category. Among these is a revered fragment of the Holy Qur’an, inscribed on parchment in Kufi script, traditionally attributed to Hazrat Ali (A.S.), the fourth Caliph of Islam.

The collection also preserves several royal decrees of Mughal emperors, alongside remarkable Persian translations of ancient Sanskrit classics such as the *Bhagavad Gita*, *Mahabharata*, and *Leelawati*, rendered by Abul Faiz Faizi, the eminent scholar at Emperor Akbar’s court. These treasures make the library a magnet for scholars of Islamic Studies, Oriental research, and Medieval Indian history from across the globe.

The manuscripts span an extraordinary range of subjects — Hadith, Tasawwuf (Sufism), Tibb (Medicine), Literature, Tarikh-e-Islam (Islamic History), Mathematics, Astronomy, Jawahirat (Gemology), Biographical works, and more. Below are some unique features of representative manuscripts preserved in this distinguished collection.

#### Representative Highlights

- **Two copies of Sahih al-Bukhari:**
  - (Juz 13, 14, 15) — the only copy in the world transcribed by Allama Ibn-e-Hajar Asqalani in 843 H./1439 A.D.
  - A golden, beautifully illuminated khatt-i-naskh calligraphy, reported to have been in the personal use of Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb Alamgir, as noted by the Tahwildar of the emperor’s library in 1094 H.
- **Manuscripts on Tasawwuf (Sufism):**
  - Uyoonul Ajwiba fi Funoon al-As’ila — penned by Abul Qasim Abdul Karim al-Qushairi (d. 465 H./1072 A.D.) himself.

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<sup>1</sup>This chapter is based on a Preface authored by Shababat Husain (then Librarian-in-Charge) for the work *Nahjul-Balagha*, jointly published in 2011 by the Maulana Azad Library, Aligarh Muslim University, Aligarh, and the Office of the Cultural Counsellor, Embassy of the Islamic Republic of Iran, New Delhi.

<sup>2</sup> <https://www.amu.ac.in/libraries/maulana-azad-library/library-collection> Accessed on 07-07-2026

- Fathul Muta'al fi Madeh Ne'al — written and transcribed by Ahmad bin Muhammad al-Maghribi (d. 1041 H.) in 1033 H.

Some noteworthy possessions of **Persian manuscripts on Sufism** include:

- (i) **Tarjuma Awariful-Ma'arif** by Shaikh Shihabuddin Umar bin Md. Suhrawardi (d. 632 H./1234 A.D.). It was translated from Arabic to Persian by Qasim Da'ud Khateeb, a disciple of Baha'uddin Zakariya Multani (d.663H/1264 A.D.). A transcription of the manuscript by Dilshaad bin Iqbal in 758H. /1357 A.D. is regarded as one of the oldest specimens of the Persian language extant today. Probably the only available copy of the same is possessed by our library;
- (ii) **Surur us Sudoor** by Sheikh Hamiduddin Nagauri (d. 673 H./1274 A.D.) and his son Fariduddin Mahmood (d.752 H/1351A.D.). A copy of the manuscript by Md. Anwarul Haq Dehlavi (d.1301 H./1883 A.D.) is a part of the library's manuscript division;
- (iii) **Malfoozat-i-Akhi Jamshed Rajgiri** compiled by Yahya bin Ali Asghar bin Usman al Husaini consists of discourses of Akhi Jamshed Rajgiri, one of the well-known Sufis of his time (d. 842 H./1438 A.D.). It was transcribed in 1179 H./1765 A.D. in 114 folios.;
- (iv) **Anisul Ashiqin** composed by Mujtaba bin Mustafa Laharpuri (d.1084H/1673A.D.) in 1049H/1639A.D., is an exposition of various orders of Sufi's invocations and thoughts. The only copy known to exist in the world is possessed by the library.

Another invaluable manuscript related to **Tibb (Medicine)** entitled **Al Mua'lajaat al Buqratiya** by Abul Hasan Ahmad bin Mohammad Al Tabari (d. 320 H./932 A.D.), the teacher of Ibn Sina, was copied in 360 folios in 1090 H. M.A.library is in possession of the same.

**The manuscripts on Arabic and Persian Literature include:**

- (i) **Jam'harah Ash'aar al 'Arab** compiled by Abu Zaid Md. Bin Abil Khattab al Qarashi (d. 170 H./ 786 A.D.), is one of the oldest work of Arabic Literature. A copy transcribed in 986 H. of the same is a part of our collection.
- (ii) **Diwan-i Arzu** A rare copy of Lyrical poems of Siraj-ud-din 'Ali Khan "Arzu" (d.1169H/1755 A.D.);
- (iii) **Masnavi Sarapa-i-Ma'shooq** written and transcribed by Ghulam Ali Azad Bilgrami (d. 1206 H./ 1785 A.D.);
- (iv) **Kulliyat-i-Faizi** by Abul Faiz Faizi (d.1004 H/1595 A.D.) is the oldest copy transcribed only nine years before the death of the poet;

- (v) **Diwani-i-Hafiz Shirazi** transcribed by the famous scribe, **Sultan Ali Mash'hadi**. The same available in our library has earlier been part of the libraries of Sultan Husain Mirza and his Wazir Meer Ali Sher Nawai;
- (vi) **Diwani-i-Hafiz Shirazi** transcribed by Abdur Rahman al-Katib in 971 H., has remained the part of personal collections of many Mughal emperors and now forms the part of our library;
- (vii) **Masnavi Gu'i wa chaugan An** allegorical poetry also known as **Haal Namah**, was composed by Maulana Mahmud al 'Arifi (853H/1449 A.D.) of Herat under Sultan Shahrukh. It was copied by Mir 'Ali al Husayni, the famous scribe of his time, in 926H/1519 A.D. at Herat. The copy remained part of the Qutb Shahi library until the annexation of Golkunda, when it was included in the royal library of Emperor Aurangzeb;
- (viii) **Masnawi-i-Ma'nawi** by **Jalaluddin Rumi** (604-672H/1207-1273A.D.). The oldest known copy available in our library was written by Abdul Qadir Qadiri al-Rafa'i in 712H/1312 A.D. The title page consists of notes dated 853H in addition to a royal seal of Emperor Aurangzeb;
- (ix) **Kulliyat-i-Talib Amuli** The library possesses a copy of the complete poetical works of **Talib Amuli**, who was honored by the Emperor Jahangir (1014-37H/1605-27 A.D.);
- (x) **Qasa'id-i-Shamsuddin Tibsi** is the oldest manuscript of Shamsuddin Tibsi (d. 626H./1228 A.D.) transcribed in naskh in 721H. The latter remained an invaluable part of libraries of the Deccan rulers, whose official seals' impressions on the title page tell the history of its own.

Some rare manuscripts on the **History of Islam (Tarikh-e-Islam)** include:

- (i) **Tasliyat-ul-Ikhwan** authored by 'Alauddin Ata Malik bin Baha'uddin Muhammad al-Juwaini (d. 681H/1283A.D.) in 680A.H./1281-82 A.D. and copied in 998 H/1589 A.D. One of the two copies of the manuscript known to exist in the world is available in the M.A. Library;
- (ii) **Tarikh-i Guzidah** by Hamdullah b. Abi Bakr b. Ahmad b. Nasr Mustaufi Qazwini was authored in 730 H/1329 A.D. The title page of the available copy bears five different seals and one autograph of Abul Faiz Faizi, the famous poet of Mughal Emperor Akbar's court;
- (iii) **Khulasat-ul-Akhbar** compiled in 905H. and copied in 920 H. is regarded as one of the most important books on the history of Islam, beginning with Adam to Amir Nizamuddin Ali Sher of Herat.

A few manuscripts on the subject of **mathematics** are:

- (i) **Leelavati** by Bhaskar Acharya was translated at the instance of Akbar, by Shaikh Abul Faiz Faizi (d.1004H./1595A.D.) under the title *Tarjama Leelavati*;
- (ii) *Risala* by **Ahmad Mi'mar**, the famous architect of Taj Mahal was transcribed by Kalka Parshad in 1836 A.D.

Similarly, one of the most important and oldest discourses on Astronomy in possession of M.A. Library is titled ***Muqaddimatut-taqwim dar Ilm-i-Tanjim*** written by Muhammad Ali al-Riyazi, the grandson of Lutfullah Muhandis and son of Khairullah Khan, the author of *Tarjama-i-Tahrir-i-Uqlidas*. It was copied by the author's son named Zaynul-Abidin, in 1179H/1782A.D.

Yet another manuscript dealing with Precious Stones, titled as ***JawahirNama*** also called ***Ahwaal-i-Jawahir*** was authored and transcribed by Muhammad bin Mansoor in 1031H. The same was dedicated to Sultan Abunnasar Hasan Bahadur Khan of Multan.

Maulana Azad Library is in possession of some note worthy **Biographies** that include:

- (i) ***Muzzakkir-i-Ahbab*** was compiled by Baha'udin Hasan Khwaja Naqibul Ashraf Bukhari with the Poetic name 'Nisari' in 974 H. /1566 A.D. and copied by Mirak in 980H/1572A.D. at Samarqand. The available copy covers biographical sketches of poets, emirs, officials, divines and others, who lived in Bukhara or its dependencies after Mir 'Ali Shir Nawa'i, towards the middle of the second half of the 10<sup>th</sup> century H. / 16<sup>th</sup> century A.D.;
- (ii) ***Moonisul Ahrar fi daqa'iq-il-ash'Ar*** compiled by Ahmad bin Mohd Kalati in 702H. is one of the most valuable anthologies which, incidentally, includes the oldest version of the select verses of Hafiz Shirazi;
- (iii) ***Nafa'isul-Ma'asir*** by Mir 'Ala ud-Daulah Kami Qazwini is a biographical and anthological dictionary of Persian poets, mostly of the 10<sup>th</sup> century hijra. The compilation was completed from 973H. /1565 A.D. to 982H. /1574-5A.D. with subsequent additions. The same was copied in 1085H. /1674 A.D. The earliest known copy of the manuscript available in our library gives an account of the history of the early Mughals at its end. It is also known as ***Tazkira-i-Ala'uddaulah*** ;
- (iv) ***Nafahat-ul-uns*** by Nuruddin Abdur Rahman Jami (d.898H/1492A.D.) was penned in 883H. and copied in 911H. This rare copy of a manuscript dealing with the Biographies of noted Muslim saints, transcribed in beautiful Nasta'liq and illuminated



throughout with gold, bears on its title page a royal gold seal of **Sultan Mohammad Safawi Khuda Banda** (938 H./ 1531-1004H./1595 A.D.), the king of Iran. The last page of the book depicts an autograph (dated 1050 H.) of **Princess Jahan Ara**, the daughter of the Mughal Emperor Shahjahan.

- (v) **Anisul Muhaqqiqin** is a description of biographical sketches of Indian Sufis and Saints, composed by the well-known scholar Ghulam 'Ali Azad Bilgrami (d. 1200H/1785 A.D.) and copied by Ahmad 'Ali in 1290H/1873 A.D. No other copy of this work is reported to be available elsewhere.

### **The idea of Publication of Rare manuscripts:**

The Maulana Azad Library houses a remarkable collection of nearly 16,000 manuscripts, many of which belong to the "rarest of the rare" category. Yet, paradoxically, this treasure of knowledge had long remained steeped in neglect, with emphasis placed merely on guarding the manuscripts rather than on their preservation, conservation, and scholarly dissemination. Recognising this gap, I felt it imperative to select at least a few of the rarest manuscripts and publish them for distribution to relevant libraries across the world at a fixed price, thereby, not only generating a corpus fund to ensure the continuity of such publications, but also bringing out the steeped knowledge for scholarly dissemination.

### **Importance of Nahjul Balagha**

Amongst the rare manuscript treasures of the Maulana Azad Library, Nahjul Balagha stands as the second-oldest and most significant manuscript, surpassed only by the fragment of the Holy Qur'an in Kufi script on parchment, attributed to Hazrat Ali (A.S.), the fourth Caliph of Islam.

Seizing the opportunity of the Golden Jubilee celebrations (2010–11), this highly revered manuscript was selected for publication, marking a milestone in the Library's mission to disseminate its rarest holdings for further research and scholarship.

Compiled by Al-Razi Hasan Muhammad ibn Al-Husain ibn Musa (359–406 H./970–1015 A.D.), Nahjul Balagha is an embodiment of the letters, speeches, and aphorisms of Hazrat Ali (A.S.). The Library's copy, regarded as the oldest in the Sub-Continent, comprises two volumes in 173 folios, transcribed by Ali ibn Abi-al-Qasim in 538 H., just 132 years after the death of its compiler.

The manuscript's title page bears notes, signatures, and seals of eminent scholars and nobles across centuries, attesting to its rich journey of custodianship. Among them are:

- طيفور بن سلطان محمد البسطامي (1061 H.), a distinguished scholar of Shia theology.
- محمد كاظم بن حبيب الله (1024 H.).
- رمضان بن علي الجزائري, resident of Bahrain.
- الحاج اسمعيل بن الحاج ابراهيم بن لامق.
- Araz Deeda (1184 H.), dated 27th Dhul-Hijjah 1184.
- Notes with the signature of سيد ابو جعفر (22 Ramadan 1254 H.).
- Seals of سيد ابو جعفر باسطي and الواثق بالملك المتعالي العالي الاوالي عبده مبارك بن عبدالله (1252 H.).

Further annotations appear across folios (1, 6, 7, 8, 14, 17, 22, 26, 27, 49, 66, 75, 76, 89, 101, 106, 114, 118, 119, 120, 141, 160, 162 & 165), each awaiting deeper scholarly research. Collectively, this manuscript not only embodies the intellectual legacy of Hazrat Ali (A.S.) but also underscores the library's larger vision — to publish and preserve the rarest manuscripts for global scholarship.

## **Nahjul Balagha Publication – Golden Jubilee of Maulana Azad Library**

At the **culmination of the Golden Jubilee celebrations of the Maulana Azad Library**, the revered work Nahjul Balagha was published in **2011**, following a **historic Memorandum of Understanding (MoU)** signed between the Library and the Office of the Cultural Counsellor, Embassy of the Islamic Republic of Iran.

In a **gala inauguration ceremony** held at the **Kennedy Hall Auditorium on 21 December 2011**, the manuscript was formally released by **Honourable Dr. Ali Akbar Velayati**, former Minister of Foreign Affairs of Iran and head of the distinguished Iranian delegation. The event was graced by eminent scholars, dignitaries, and members of the academic community, marking a significant milestone in the Library's cultural and scholarly journey.

This publication not only symbolized **the deep cultural and academic ties between India and Iran**, but also reaffirmed the Library's role as a custodian of

Islamic intellectual heritage. The collaboration brought **global attention** to the Library's manuscript treasures, strengthening **its reputation as a center for Islamic Studies and Oriental scholarship**.

As part of the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU), the Iran Cultural House undertook the publication of 2000 copies of the revered manuscript Nahjul Balagha, to be equally divided between the two signatories. On the day of the inauguration ceremony, they brought about 25 copies for the release function and for the Maulana Azad Library, with the remaining copies supplied only after I was relieved of my charge as Librarian on 20 June, 2012.

**Regrettably, the larger aim of publication has not been realised to this day. Despite the noble vision of disseminating this rare and precious work, nearly 1000 copies of the publication remain stored in the Manuscript Division, thereby undermining the very purpose for which the manuscript was published. This unfulfilled outcome highlights the gap between scholarly intent and practical execution in preserving and disseminating rare knowledge.**

# سبح السبأ

مجموعة المحاضرات والخطب والأقوال الماثورة للإمام علي بن أبي طالب عليه السلام  
سورة مخطوطة سنة ١٢٣٨ / ١٨٢٢ م، مطروقة في مكتبة مولانا آزاد، جامعة عليكرة الإسلامية، عليكرة (الهند)

الناشران

مكتبة مولانا آزاد

جامعة عليكرة الإسلامية

عليكرة (الهند)

المركز الثقافي

لسفارة الجمهورية الإسلامية الإيرانية

دلهي الجديدة (الهند)





إحتفال المهرجان الذهبي لمكتبة مولانا آزاد

# سبح السبحة

مجموعة المحاضرات والخطب والأقوال الماثورة للإمام علي بن أبي طالب عليه السلام

صورة مخطوطة سنة ١٥٢٨ / ١٧٤٣ مخروطة في مكتبة مولانا آزاد - جامعة عليكرة الإسلامية، عليكرة (الهند)

الناشر

مكتبة مولانا آزاد

جامعة عليكرة الإسلامية

عليكرة (الهند)

المركز الثقافي

لسفارة الجمهورية الإسلامية الإيرانية

دلهي الجديدة (الهند)

١٤٣٣ / ٢٠١١ م





Back Cover of the manuscript with royal seals and signatures



<https://www.islamicinvitationturkey.com/seminar-on-nahjul-balagha-and-human-rights-held-in-india/>



## Chapter 8

### Department of Library & Information Science (1995 to 2017)

#### History

The history of automation in the Maulana Azad Library (M.A. Library) is inseparably linked to the modernisation of the **Department of Library and Information Science** (DLIS), which has long served as the “**feeding department**” to the University's vast library system.

By the time I returned from England after completing my M.Phil. in Information Technology (1992), the Department had managed to acquire a PC XT. Yet, this machine mostly remained covered in the Head of Department's chamber, rarely used. The reason was twofold: there were hardly any faculty or students trained to operate it, and the syllabi of the courses taught contained little or no input of Information Technology as applicable to libraries.

When I assumed the charge of the Department in 1995, I was deeply conscious of the growing importance of computer technology in libraries worldwide. To meet the evolving demands of the profession, the Department required nothing short of a total metamorphosis—to evolve into a modern, dynamic centre capable of supporting the University's vast library system, comprising the Maulana Azad Library at the centre, five faculty libraries, and nearly 100 departmental libraries. At the same time, graduates of the Department were expected to serve premier institutions across India and abroad.

مرے جنوں کا نتیجہ ضرور نکلے گا

اسی سیاہ سمندر سے نور نکلے گا

True to my ingrained habit of working with relentless junoon, I devoted my first two tenures as Head of the Department (1995–2000 and 2003–2006) to rebuilding and modernising DLIS. This passion was not mere ambition, but a mission—to lay strong foundations that elevated the Department toward national recognition and prepared it for international distinction. Under this vision, DLIS began its transformation during the

said period into a beacon of excellence, shining at both national and international levels.

### ***Key Steps Undertaken***

During my first term as Chairman (19 September 1995 – 8 June 2000), I undertook a series of transformative initiatives that reshaped the Department. The syllabi were thoroughly revised to meet emerging professional demands, sufficient faculty were appointed to strengthen the academic base, and the first fully automated library was established. Alongside, modern computer facilities were developed, bringing the Department to the forefront of the library profession in India. The aforesaid steps are detailed as under:

#### **1. Revision of Syllabi:**

- As I took over charge as Chairperson of the Department, the entire curriculum underwent a rigorous and comprehensive revision to align with the rapidly emerging professional requirements of the field. This painstaking exercise took several months of deliberation, consultation, and drafting. In the process, the courses were redesigned to integrate Information Technology, library automation, and digital resource management, ensuring students were prepared for the challenges of modern librarianship.
- Ultimately, a robust and forward-looking syllabus emerged—one that not only transformed teaching and training within the Department but also became a benchmark for Library and Information Science education across India.
- In fact, the revised syllabus was so well received that it later served as a model for several other DLIS departments nationwide, with some state universities adopting it wholesale—some even replicating it verbatim. This achievement underscored the Department's pioneering role in setting academic standards and reaffirmed its position as a leader in modern library education.

#### **2. Appointment of Qualified Manpower**

At that time, the Department had only three faculty members, while several teaching posts lay vacant for years. With the wholehearted cooperation of the Vice Chancellors — (Late) Mehmoodur Rehman Sahib and Mr Naseem Ahmad Sahib — I

was able to convene selection committees in 1997 and 2005. Most importantly, these appointments allowed me to resist the entrenched practice of “inbreeding” that had long plagued the University, thereby opening the doors to fresh talent and diverse academic perspectives.

As a result, appointments were made from a wide range of institutions — including Calicut University (Kerala), Bundelkhand University (Jhansi), Punjab University (Chandigarh), AMU itself, and even the private IT sector — and later from Banaras Hindu University (Varanasi) and Kashmir University (Srinagar) in 2015. This diversity brought fresh perspectives and specialized expertise into the Department, breaking away from the narrow confines of inbreeding that had long hindered growth.

It is true that, regrettably, some appointees later lost sight of the mission for which they were selected. Yet, the overall impact of these appointments was transformative: they enriched the Department’s intellectual base, strengthened its credibility, and laid the foundations for DLIS to emerge as a modern, nationally recognised center of excellence, prepared for international distinction. However, this decision to bring in fresh talent from outside AMU earned me many adversaries, whose resentment I had to endure until my retirement. Still, it was essential for the Department’s growth.

### **3. Development of Modern Facilities in DLIS**

- **Information Technology Laboratory**

A sophisticated **I.T. Laboratory** was established in the DLIS with about 10 computer systems, enabling hands-on training in multiple library automation packages, including Libsys, Alice for Windows, VTLS, and SOUL (Software for University Libraries) and a few open-source software used to develop Digital Libraries.

- **First Fully Automated Seminar Library and National Workshop**

Alongside these reforms, the first fully automated Seminar Library of the University was established to serve as a model for the Department’s students. It featured barcode-based issue and return of books, an online catalogue, Access to web-based information and a CD-ROM workstation, thereby introducing learners to the practical dimensions of library automation.

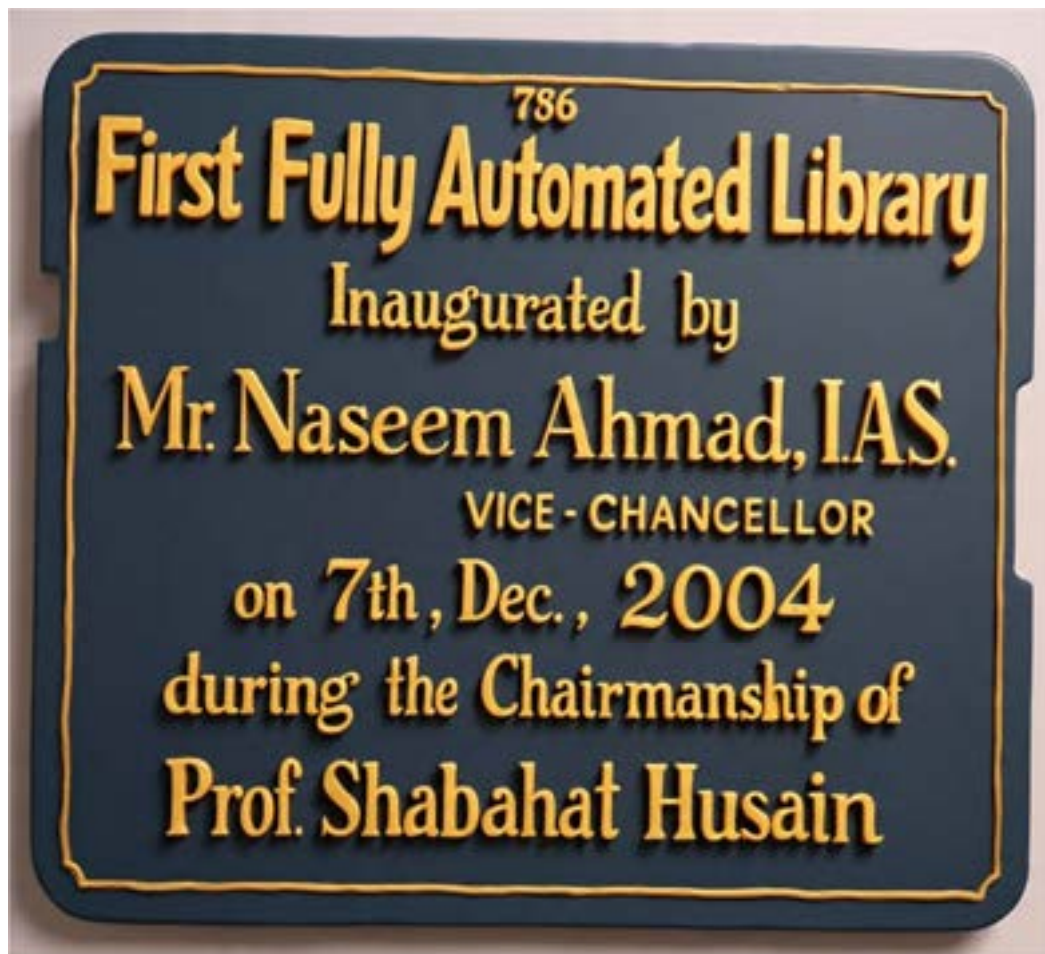
Both the Information Technology Laboratory and the Seminar Library were formally inaugurated on 7th December 2004 by the then Vice-Chancellor, Mr. Naseem Ahmad, IAS, in the presence of Prof. Waseem Akhtar, Vice-Chancellor of Integral University, Lucknow. On the same day, the Honourable Vice-Chancellor also inaugurated a **National Workshop on Developing Digital Libraries using DSpace**, organised by the Department in collaboration with the INFLIBNET Centre, Ahmedabad and the Documentation Research and Training Centre (DRTC), Bangalore. Prof. Waseem Akhtar graciously consented to be the Guest of Honour at this landmark event.

- **Departmental Website ([www.dlisamu.org](http://www.dlisamu.org))**

While rebuilding the Department, another significant milestone directly or indirectly contributed to the modernisation of the Maulana Azad Library was the launch of the **Departmental Website —[www.dlisamu.org](http://www.dlisamu.org)**- inaugurated by the Honourable Vice Chancellor, Mr. Naseem Ahmad on 1st May 2006.

The occasion was further graced by the presence of Syed Mohd Ashraf sb (IRS), a distinguished alumnus and the first Income Tax Commissioner of Aligarh (2001–2007), who attended the function as Guest of Honour. These milestones not only strengthened the Department's academic and technological foundation but also symbolised its growing role in shaping the digital transformation of the University's central library system.

On that occasion, the Vice-Chancellor was pleased to describe the Department as a **“Flagship Department”** of the University, acknowledging its pioneering role in modernising library science education and practice. •





Inauguration of First Fully Automated Seminar Library and I.T.Laboratory



Inauguration of National Workshop on Developing Digital Libraries using DSpace

#### 4. Launching of ‘Journal of Information Management and Scientometrics’

It is well known that an academic peer-reviewed journal published by a department is a hallmark of scholarly credibility. It not only provides a platform for faculty, Researchers, and other subject experts at national and international levels to publish original research but also ensures that the work is rigorously evaluated by experts, thereby maintaining high academic standards. Such a journal enhances the department's reputation by showcasing its intellectual contributions. It strengthens the image of the parent institution as a center of knowledge creation and dissemination by encouraging innovation and collaboration, attracting scholars, researchers, and funding opportunities. A peer-reviewed journal thus serves as a record of excellence, reflecting the department's commitment to advancing new knowledge and keeping students updated with emerging trends.

In essence, a peer-reviewed departmental journal becomes both a mirror and a beacon — reflecting the scholarly strength of the department while guiding the institution toward greater academic distinction

In my second term (9 June 2003 – 8 June 2006), the next milestone was the **launch of a scholarly journal from the Department**. The idea germinated in 2004, when I was invited to chair a session at the International Conference at Roorkee University. There, I met **Prof. Hildrun Kretschmer of Germany**, a scholar of international repute engaged in pioneering research in Scientometrics, while my own focus was on Information Management using ICT.

Our discussion revealed a unique gap: the absence of a journal that could simultaneously address both Information Management and Scientometrics. That meeting in Roorkee laid the foundation for the Journal of Information Management and Scientometrics — the first of its kind to integrate these two vital dimensions of the profession.

The groundwork for launching the new Journal had already been laid. Colleagues in the profession were informed through announcements, and several were personally invited to contribute to the inaugural issue. Yet, the greater challenge remained: how to publish the journal in the absence of financial resources.



To overcome this, I approached Mr. Naseem Ahmad, IAS, the then Vice-Chancellor, and (Late) Mr. Shafeeq Ahmad, the then Finance Officer, whose consistent support proved invaluable for the Department. I remain deeply obliged to both of them, for never once was I denied sanction of funds — whether it was drawing a fiber-optics line from the Zoology Department to the Department of Library Science in Kennedy Hall Complex, or purchasing the hardware, software, Air conditioners, and software packages for training and required furniture for the computer lab.

For the journal, a remarkable arrangement was approved: publication through the University Press at the University's expense, with income deposited in University funds, while quality control remained in my hands. This unique model ensured both institutional support and editorial independence; I was overjoyed with this arrangement. The journal was formally inaugurated by the Honorable Vice-Chancellor on 26 August 2004, in a grand function held at the Administrative Block. The ceremony was graced by Prof. P. B. Mangla, the distinguished scholar of international repute from Delhi University, who attended the release ceremony as Guest of Honour.

In fact, the release of the journal was combined with the launch of my two books:

1. Library Classification: Facets and Analyses (2nd Edition), first published in 1993 by McGraw Hill Publishing Company Ltd., New York.
2. Dewey Decimal Classification: A Complete Survey of 22 Editions, published by BRPC, Delhi in 2004. This work was later translated into Arabic and published in 2008 by Dr Rabah Fawzy, Department of Library and Information Science, Al-Azhar University, Egypt.

This combined event symbolised not only the birth of a new journal but also the continuity of scholarly contributions through my books, marking a milestone in the Department's academic journey.

Thanks to the tireless efforts of Prof. Hildrun Kretschmer, who served as Associate Editor while I was Chief Editor of the journal (ISSN: 0972-9925), it quickly attained international stature. Tragically, however, its **publication ceased after three years with the change of Headship in 2007** — a decision difficult to explain to our international contributors.

Determined to sustain the vision, I sought an alternate publisher and was fortunate to secure Taru Publications, New Delhi, which accepted the journal under a new ISSN (0973–7766) and title: **Collnet Journal of Scientometrics and Information Management**. The abbreviation COLLNET referred to the collaboration network Prof. Kretschmer had developed across the USA and Europe. Together, we continued publishing from 2007 to 2010.

By then, my responsibilities as Librarian-in-charge of the Maulana Azad Library (2008–2012) compelled me to **relinquish the Editorship of the journal in 2011**. Yet, before stepping down, the journal had already been indexed in several **international databases like EBSCO, LISA, Scopus, etc.**— paving the way for its **co-publication** by the prestigious international publisher **Taylor & Francis**.

This was the journal's greatest achievement, a recognition few departmental journals ever attain. And yet, what pained me most was that the **journal no longer bore the name of the Department of Library & Information Science, Aligarh Muslim University** — the very institution where its journey had begun, though the names of Shabahat Husain and Hildrun Kretschmer are still mentioned as **Founder Editors, prominently at the back of the title page**.



Launching of 'Journal of Information Management and Scientometrics' and  
WEBSITE of DLIS

# JOURNAL OF INFORMATION MANAGEMENT AND SCIENTOMETRICS

ISSN 0 972-9925

**Volume 1  
Number 1  
June 2004**

**Editors:**  
**Shabahat Husain**  
**Hildrun Kretschmer**

*FROM LIBRAMETRY TO WEBOMETRICS*  
Hildrun Kretschmer & Mike Thielwall

*ARCHIVING OF E-JOURNAL*  
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Aligarh Muslim University  
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**Editors:**

**Shabahat Husain  
Hildrun Kretschmer**

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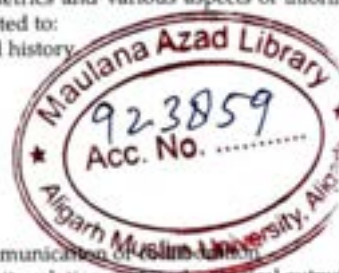
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5899  
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Department of Library  
& Info Science  
A.M.U., Aligarh

29 JAN 2025

## 5. UGC's Special Assistance Programme (DRS-I) (2013/14–2017/18)

Based on a proposal titled “**Knowledge Management in Libraries**”, jointly submitted to the UGC by myself in collaboration with Prof. Naushad Ali, the Department was awarded the prestigious SAP (DRS-I) Programme (2013/14–2017/18) — with **Prof. Shabahat Husain as Coordinator and Prof. Naushad Ali as Co-Coordinator**. This recognition was a remarkable feat for any Department of Studies in a University.

The programme yielded significant outcomes:

- Award of several PhD degrees on the subject.
- Organisation of national and international conferences.
- Publication of Conference proceedings
- Publication of numerous research papers in peer-reviewed journals.
- A dedicated **Knowledge Management Portal** was also developed, practically demonstrating the project's central theme — **how tacit knowledge can be captured**, preserved, and utilised for the benefit of future generations of scientists and technologists across organisations.

However, upon my superannuation in 2017, the incumbent Chairperson, albeit in all sincerity, replaced my name with hers in the credentials of SAP and further removed my name as the designer of the Knowledge Management Portal.

**[www.libraryknowledgemanagement.org](http://www.libraryknowledgemanagement.org)**

The last of its five modules — on Tacit Knowledge, scheduled for completion in 2018 before the project's closure — was regrettably left undeveloped.

Equally disheartening was the misallocation of a substantial grant of about 18 lacs originally secured for the installation of a security gate with Tattle Tapes in the Department's Library. Instead, the funds were diverted to establish a Knowledge Management Laboratory, which was neither required nor has been put to use to this day.

The project's digital presence also suffered: the domain **liskms.com** went permanently offline in 2018, immediately after the project ended. Had the initiative truly achieved its intended goals, the website would have remained a living resource; instead, it has been inactive for years, symbolising the unrealised potential of the endeavour.

Thus, the **greatest loss to the Department was the non-renewal of the UGC project**, which had carried a substantial grant for research and development activities. This lapse not only curtailed academic progress but also deprived future generations of scholars of a valuable institutional legacy.



## 6. Full-fledged Building for the Department of Library and Information Science

- **First Building** : Cultural Hall at the rear of the Maulana Azad Library from 1950–1994.

The foundation of the Department of Library Science was laid in 1950–51 with the introduction of a **Certificate Course in Library Science** by the then University Librarian, Prof. S. Bashiruddin, conducted in the **Cultural Hall at the rear of the Maulana Azad Library**. In 1958–59, Prof. Bashiruddin pioneered the introduction of the Bachelor of Library Science with full-time lecturers — the first of its kind in the country. The Certificate Course was eventually discontinued in 1968–69, paving the way for more advanced programmes. The Master of Library Science was introduced in 1970–71, followed by another landmark initiative in 1986–87, when Library Science was offered as a subsidiary subject at the B.A. level in the Faculties of Arts and Social Sciences. Recognizing the growing importance of research, the Department launched its M.Phil./Ph.D. programme in 1990–91.

- **Second Building:** Kennedy Hall Complex 1995 to 2013

When I assumed charge of the Department on 10 September 1995, I quickly realized that its location in the backyard of the Library offered little scope for expansion. The existing space was wholly inadequate to accommodate modern, IT-oriented courses. I therefore approached the then Vice Chancellor, Dr. Mehmoodur Rehman, and convinced him of the urgent need for relocation. Despite considerable opposition from other contenders for the same prime space, he approved the Department's shift to the **Kennedy Hall Complex** and sanctioned funds to remodel the premises. This enabled the creation of six faculty chambers and a dedicated computer laboratory.

Thus, in 1995, the Department moved from its modest quarters behind the Maulana Azad Library to its purpose-built facility in the Kennedy Hall Complex — a decisive step that placed us on a stronger footing to meet the demands of modern library and information science education. In 2008, I was entrusted with serving as Librarian In-charge of the Maulana Azad Library during the tenure of Prof. P. K. Abdul Azis as Vice Chancellor. At that time, a substantial UGC grant for infrastructural development was available. However, the funds earmarked for constructing a separate building for three departments of the faculty — Library and Information Science, Sociology, and Mass Media & Journalism — proved insufficient. The Vice Chancellor therefore approved the construction of a new building for only two departments, while the Department of Journalism, in accordance with its priorities, was provided resources to establish a studio and other mass media facilities at its existing location.

- **Final Present Building:** 2014-

The new building, designated as Block II of the Faculty of Social Sciences, was completed in 2013, about a year after Prof. Azis's tenure ended. It was formally

inaugurated on 27 February 2014 by Lt. Gen. Zameer Uddin Shah, then Vice Chancellor, during my tenure as Dean, Faculty of Social Sciences.

**Thus, I deem it as my honour and privilege to have guided the Department's journey — from its modest quarters behind the Maulana Azad Library, to the Kennedy Hall Complex in 1995, and finally to the newly constructed Block II in 2014.**







## Chapter 9

### Social Science Cyber Library: First in the World

#### 1.Introduction

When I assumed charge as Dean, Faculty of Social Sciences on 30 September 2012, the matter of utilising the 11th Five-Year Plan book grant was already under discussion. About a month earlier, the then Dean had invited me to deliberate on how the funds earmarked for the purchase of books for the Faculty library could be best utilised.

I pointed out that, unlike certain other faculties of the University, the Faculty of Social Sciences did not have a central library of its own. Hence, books could not be purchased exclusively for the Faculty. Moreover, dividing the grant equally among departments was impractical, since some departments were very large with extensive needs, while others were comparatively small. In addition, each department had already received separate book grants which remained unutilized by then.

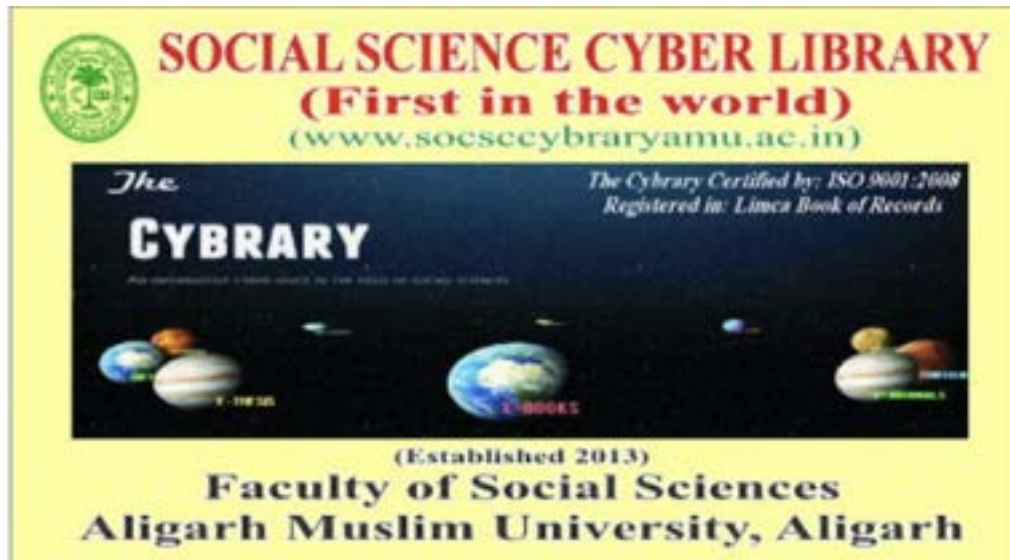
Faced with this situation, I proposed a more visionary alternative: the creation of a Social Science Digital Library, with its hub located in the Dean's office, accessible to both students and faculty from anywhere. The outgoing Dean welcomed the idea and asked me to submit a proposal. I complied, though I later learned that the proposal had already been discussed with the top administration without my name being mentioned.

Subsequently, I was asked to develop the digital library before formally taking charge. I explained that establishing such a library required several months, depending on its scope. Meanwhile, the Dean, in consultation with the Deputy Librarian of the Maulana Azad Library, purchased e-books in a few social science subjects without informing me. When the bills for these purchases came to me for approval as the new Dean, I circulated the lists among the department heads to confirm whether they had recommended the titles or found them useful. Their unanimous response was negative.

Accordingly, I forwarded the bills to the Finance Officer along with the comments received. The matter eventually required the intervention of the Vice Chancellor, Lt. Gen. Zameer Uddin Shah, who observed that the e-book orders had been placed with vendors on behalf of the University, notwithstanding their shortcomings. He therefore ruled that 50% of the payment be made from the Dean's funds, while the remaining 50% be met from the library's budget. Orders were complied with, though ***in my considered view, the expenditure incurred on subscribing to e-books — without***

*first ascertaining their relevance and utility for students and faculty — has regrettably amounted to a waste of valuable resources.*

With the balance of funds still available at my disposal, I began developing the proposed library. Over the course of a year, this vision materialised into what came to be known as the Social Science Cyber Library (SSCL) — a pioneering initiative that fulfilled my dream of creating a digital knowledge hub for social scientists globally.



## Social Science Cyber Library (SSCL)

The Social Science Cyber Library (SSCL), inaugurated on 27 December 2013 by His Excellency Shri Pranab Mukherjee, President of India, is the **first of its kind in the world**. Conceived as a global knowledge hub, it brings together a vast array of **open-access resources in the field of Social Sciences, including:**

- E-books and e-journals
- Video lectures and web courses
- Subject gateways and databases
- Specialized websites and software tools

**Its mission** is to enable students, research scholars, and faculty members worldwide to make the best use of freely available digital resources. Today, **the Cybrary is accessed in 176 countries**, reflecting its international reach and impact.

**The SSCL has also earned significant recognition:**

- **Awarded ISO 9001:2008** Certification in June 2015
- Entered into the **Limca Book of Records** (2017)
- Registered in OpenDOAR (Directory of Open Access Repositories), hosted by the University of Nottingham, UK

- Registered in ROAR (Registry of Open Access Repositories), hosted by the University of Southampton, UK
- **Featured with a description on Wikipedia**

## **Contents of the Social Science Cyber Library (SSCL)**

<https://www.socscycybraryamu.ac.in/index.php>

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### **Creating a central Hub of Cybrary: Problems**



Aligarh Muslim University is often regarded as a place of comfort for those who wish to take life at ease. Yet, for anyone determined to contribute meaningfully to its academic progress, challenges arise at every step. I have already explained the **circumstances under which the Social Science Cyber Library was established. Equally demanding was the task of finding a suitable location for the central hub of the Cyber Library**, which I gave a new nomenclature — the “Cybrary.”

The available space in the faculty building comprised the Dean’s Chamber, the Dean’s Office, and a Conference Hall. Curiously, between the two wings of the building were **four chambers allotted to certain teachers from different departments of the Faculty. These chambers, however, remained locked most of the time, as the same teachers already had offices in their respective departments.**

After discussing the matter with the Vice Chancellor, and with his approval, I had the four chambers vacated — a decision that, understandably, displeased the teachers concerned and their associates. With the consultation of the University Engineer and the Vice Chancellor’s sanction, **the dividing walls of these chambers were removed to create two spacious rooms.** One was designated as the **Hub of the Cybrary**, equipped with about thirty computer systems, while the other was developed into a **Smart Lecture Theatre** for Faculty extension lectures.

#### **Appointment of a Cybrarian**

A competent Cybrarian was essential to manage both the technical and administrative dimensions of the Cybrary. In my judgment, the most suitable individual for this role was serving in the Engineering College Library. However, his Professor-in-charge — who was also the then President of the AMU Teachers’ Association — was reluctant to relieve him.

#### **Support of Vice-Chancellors**

In a meeting convened in the Vice Chancellor’s chamber, I had to make the case that while the duties he was currently performing could be handled by many, the specialised responsibilities I wished to entrust him with could be carried out only by him. **Thanks to the unstinting support of Lt. Gen. Zameer Uddin Shah, Vice Chancellor, the appointment was approved.**



**As a matter of fact, I found Lt. Gen. Zameeruddin Shah, despite his military background, to possess a remarkable grasp of academic issues. Once convinced, he would act with firmness and decisiveness. Equally impressive was his sense of time management: he always made himself available whenever I sought his advice or approval — even on Sundays at his lodge — and would respond to my text messages within hours.**

**I count myself fortunate to have worked closely with at least six Vice Chancellors, all of whom I found to be very nice, well-meaning individuals devoted to the institution.**

One instance I vividly recall is when my MRI proforma for back pain diagnosis, as advised by an orthopaedic surgeon, came before **Mr. Naseem Ahmad, then Vice Chancellor**, for his final signature. He immediately called me to inquire about my welfare and even suggested some physical exercises — a gesture of personal concern I shall never forget. **I have given a detailed account of his tacit support that helped me build the Department of Library and Information Science during my tenure as chairperson. (Chap.8)** Probably realising my importance for the Cyberlibrary, Lt. Gen. Shah passed an order, at the time of my retirement, designating me as Honorary Coordinator of the Cybrary, though this arrangement was later deemed unfeasible.

**Recognising that the Dean of the Faculty could belong to any discipline, he wisely placed the Cybrary under the jurisdiction of the Chairman, Department of Library and Information Science, rather than the Dean — a professionally sound and institutionally prudent decision, though not without some measure of displeasure from incumbent Deans.**

Regrettably, since my departure in 2017, **the Cybrary has not received the sustained technical support it required.** Even library professionals have been unable to advance its development or diversify its sources and services in line with contemporary technological needs, leaving much of its potential underutilised.



# Certificate of Registration

Certificate No: 150515019151

*This is to Certify that the Management System of the*

**Social Science Cyber Library**

([www.socscylibraryamu.ac.in](http://www.socscylibraryamu.ac.in))

**Aligarh Muslim University, Aligarh-202002, U.P., India**

*has been assessed and found to be in accordance with the requirements of  
standard detailed below*

**ISO 9001:2008**

*This Certificate is valid for the following scope*

**“Providing Digital/E-Library Services  
in Social Sciences”**

|                           |                            |
|---------------------------|----------------------------|
| Initial Registration Date | 15 <sup>th</sup> May, 2015 |
| Issue Date                | 15 <sup>th</sup> May, 2015 |
| Valid Until               | 14 <sup>th</sup> May, 2018 |

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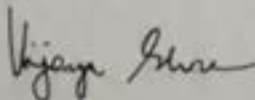
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**Social Science Cyber Library** at Aligarh Muslim University is the first ISO certified Cybrary that collects web-based e-resources (e-books, e-journals, subject gateways, video lectures etc.), making them accessible to Social Scientists in 142 countries so far through user friendly interface. The Cybrary developed under the leadership of Prof. Shababat Hasein, Chairperson, Department of Library and Information Science was inaugurated by Shri Pranab Mukherjee, President of India on Dec. 27, 2013.



*Vijaya Ghose*  
*Editor, Limca Book of Records*



Issued on: **October 24, 2015**

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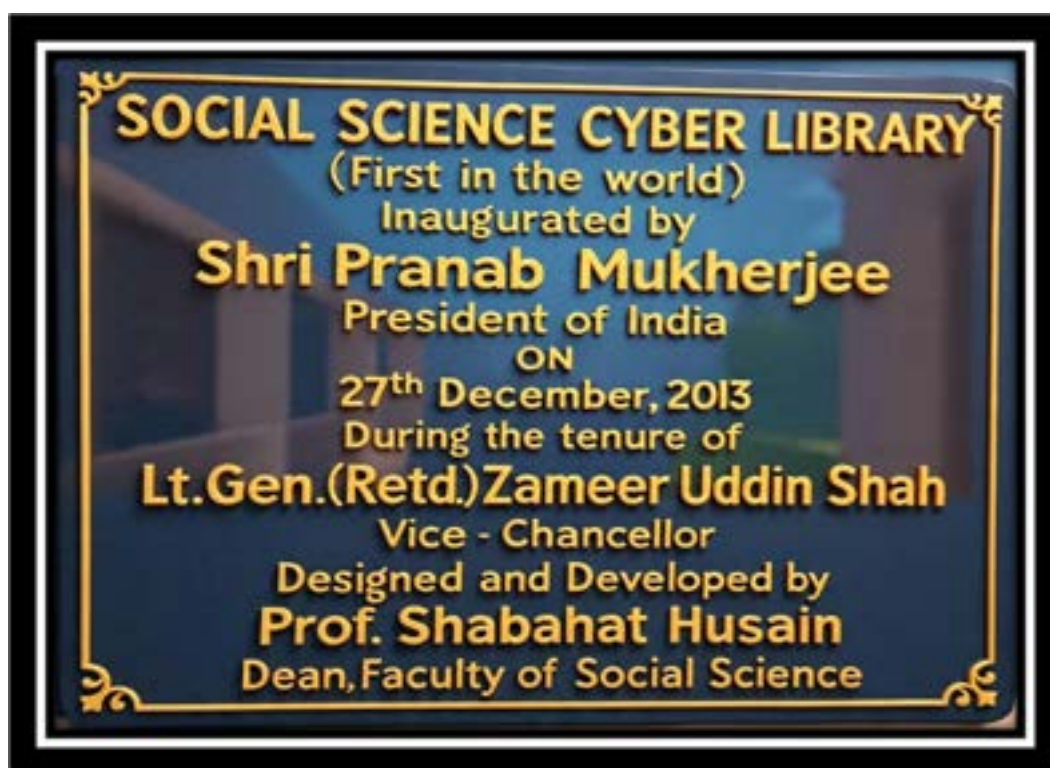


## Launching of Social Science Cyber Library



Designed and Developed under the direction of Prof. Shabakat Husain.  
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## Hub of Social Science Cyber Library





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# Aligarh Muslim University 'Cyberary' Gets ISO Certification

By WNS | Published: 28th June 2015 03:14 PM | Last Updated: 28th June 2015 03:14 PM

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**ALIGARH:** The Aligarh Muslim University's social sciences cyber library or "cyberary" was accredited with the International Standard Organisation (ISO) certification, institute officials said on Friday.

The "cyberary" was designed and developed by Shahabul Haqim, former dean of the faculty of social sciences, to provide students access to web-based resources.

The resources include e-books, e-journals, in-house publications, web courses, video lectures of eminent scholars and databases pertaining to social sciences.

The cyber library is available for social scientists not only in AMU but across the globe. The usage data shows that it has been accessed in 75 countries till date.

It was inaugurated by President Pranab Mukherjee on December 27, 2013.

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Aligarh Muslim University 'cyberary' gets ISO

— By Agence France Press, 2012-03-04 10:00

Aligarh, Uttar Pradesh Muslim University's new online open library is "cyberary" was awarded ISO 9001 certification, which is a mark of quality.

The "cyberary" was designed and developed by Shabir Hussain, former dean of the faculty of social sciences, to provide students access to wide range of resources.

The university has a number of journals, in-house publications, web resources, online database of electronic journals and databases pertaining to social sciences.

The cyber library is accessible to students not only in AMU but across the globe. The website also states that it has been awarded an ISO 9001:2008.

It was developed by President Prakash Mishra on September 20, 2011.

**News Portals: The following 23 portals reported the NEWS**

|                                                                                                                |                   |           |        |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|-----------|--------|
|  1 TwoCirclesNet              | 7/3/2015 10:17 AM | PNG image | 426 KB |
|  2 the news.co.in             | 7/3/2015 10:17 AM | PNG image | 143 KB |
|  3 in.news.yahoo.com          | 7/3/2015 10:17 AM | PNG image | 237 KB |
|  4 3novicesasia.wordpress.com | 7/3/2015 10:17 AM | PNG image | 179 KB |
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|  6 newindianexpress.com       | 7/3/2015 10:17 AM | PNG image | 642 KB |
|  7 business-standard.com      | 7/3/2015 10:17 AM | PNG image | 211 KB |
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|  10 jagran.com                | 7/3/2015 10:17 AM | PNG image | 458 KB |
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|  13 vplnews.com               | 7/3/2015 10:17 AM | PNG image | 556 KB |
|  14 nvnews.com                | 7/3/2015 10:17 AM | PNG image | 209 KB |
|  15 dlatimes.com              | 7/3/2015 10:17 AM | PNG image | 387 KB |
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|  19 prokerala.com            | 7/3/2015 10:17 AM | PNG image | 428 KB |
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|  22 muslimissues.com        | 7/3/2015 10:17 AM | PNG image | 433 KB |
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## **Chapter 10**

### **Modernisation of Maulana Azad Library (2008 – 2012) Part 1**

#### **1.Introduction**

As I often remarked to my colleagues during my charge of the Library (2008–2012): “One life of a librarian is not enough to resolve every pending issue of the Maulana Azad Library, while simultaneously revamping it with state-of-the-art facilities.”

The office of the University Librarian has always demanded more than routine administration. It requires a visionary leader and able administrator — one who can confront long-standing challenges, safeguard priceless collections, and at the same time lead the march toward modernization, while making the best use of the available talent. To hold this seat is to balance heritage with progress, stewardship with transformation, and continuity with innovation.

I entered the Library and Information profession as a Lecturer in the University's concerned department in 1976, when systems were still entirely manual. Over the years, I was fortunate to gain academic and professional exposure abroad — University of Maiduguri, Nigeria (1980–1983), the University of Toronto, Canada (1991), Loughborough University of Technology, England (1991–92) as a Commonwealth Scholar, as a delegate at the 46th F.I.D. Conference in Madrid, Spain (1992), as a Chair of a session at the IV International Conference on Webometrics, Informetrics and Scientometrics, Berlin, Germany (2008). These visits revealed to me how far library services had advanced internationally. At the same time, the Maulana Azad Library continued to resemble an image of the past.

By the first decade of the present century, significant developments had already transformed libraries in the developed world — and even begun to reshape Indian libraries.

In India, the decade marked the initial phase of automation in university and research libraries. OPACs (Online Public Access Catalogues) gradually replaced card catalogues in major institutions such as IITs, IIMs, and some central universities. Initiatives like INFLIBNET and DELNET expanded access to e-journals and databases, though unevenly. Many libraries still relied on CD-ROM databases and localised digital archives, with limited bandwidth and infrastructure slowing adoption. Staff training and funding constraints meant IT services were often partial and experimental rather than fully integrated.

By contrast, libraries in the US, UK, and Europe had already entered mature digital environments. Integrated Library Systems (ILS) were standard, supported by web-based OPACs, federated search tools, and early discovery layers. Widespread digitization projects (e.g., Google Books, Europeana) provided seamless access to global collections. Strong broadband penetration and institutional funding enabled remote access to e-resources, mobile interfaces, and personalised retrieval services. Libraries were shifting from mere storage to knowledge management and user-centric services.

It is therefore evident that in the first decade of the 21st century, Indian libraries were laying the foundation of IT-based services, while developed countries were consolidating and innovating. The gap was most visible in infrastructure, funding, and user experience: India focused on building access, whereas developed nations emphasised efficiency and personalisation.

When I assumed charge of the Maulana Azad Library in 2008, the institution resembled a relic of the past. The central hall was still dominated by card-catalogue cabinets, occupying precious space and symbolising the inertia of outdated systems. The situation was even more challenging in terms of resources: a modest allocation of ten lakh rupees was earmarked in the budget for computerisation of the library. A significant portion of this modest allocation was, for years, absorbed by outsourced retro-conversion — the laborious process of converting catalogue cards into a digital database. For a mammoth collection of nearly ten lakh books (then), the effort was both meagre in scale and painfully time-consuming, particularly when managed without vision or efficiency. During my tenure, however, the steps taken not only completed the arduous task of retro-conversion (as explained later in this chapter) but

also ensured that the annual allocation of ten lakh rupees was better used for developing I.T. based library facilities. This saving was redirected toward the overall development and modernisation of the library, enabling progress that went beyond mere digitisation of catalogue cards. In short, what had once been a slow crawl toward modernisation was transformed into a purposeful stride, laying the groundwork for a more dynamic and forward-looking institution. This was when the sweeping digital transformations were already reshaping libraries in the developed world. Even within India, prestigious institutions such as IITs, IIMs, TIFR, ISRO, BARC, etc. were embracing integrated systems, digitisation projects, and user-centric innovations. In contrast, Maulana Azad Library remained mired in outdated processes, its progress hampered by limited resources and poor execution. In truth, the contrast was stark: while global institutions were embracing integrated systems, digitisation projects, and user-centric innovations, Maulana Azad Library was only beginning its cautious journey into the digital age. The card cabinets symbolised the past, the limited budget reflected the constraints of the present, and the retro-conversion project marked the first tentative step toward a future that demanded far greater vision and investment.



**Central Hall with Catalogue Card cabinets and Display Tables (2007/2008)**

### **Personal Computers in library operations**

History of personal computers in Indian institutions, particularly libraries, reflects a slow but decisive transition from manual systems to digital environments. In the 1980s, imported IBM XT and AT machines were confined largely to universities, banks, and government offices, while libraries continued to rely on card catalogues and manual indexing. By the early 1990s, 386 and 486 PCs began appearing in select research libraries, though their use was limited by high costs and inadequate infrastructure. The real turning point came with the arrival of Pentium-based systems in the mid-1990s, which enabled wider adoption of software for cataloguing, databases, and early internet access. Projects such as INFLIBNET and DELNET provided Indian libraries with gateways to e-journals and shared resources, though implementation remained uneven. By the 2000s, as Pentium III and IV machines became common, libraries like the Maulana Azad Library cautiously entered the digital age, allocating modest budgets for retro-conversion of catalogue cards into databases. Compared to the sweeping digitisation in Western institutions, Indian libraries were still laying the

foundation. Still, these steps marked the beginning of a new era where PCs became indispensable tools for information management and access.

## **2. Modernisation of Maulana Azad Library.**

When I assumed charge of the Maulana Azad Library on 25 September 2008, I was immediately confronted with a host of pressing challenges. Foremost among them was the imperative to bring the library at par with national and international developments in the field of librarianship and information technology. To achieve this, a series of strategic measures were undertaken to modernise the Maulana Azad Library:

### **2.1 Establishing administrative discipline among staff and users.**

To monitor staff activity and student presence, my first decisive step was the installation of CCTV cameras across the vast, seven storied building — covering the central hall, the large reading halls, and other key sections.

It soon became evident that staff punctuality was a serious concern. Many employees were recording false arrival times in the attendance register to avoid disciplinary action. By cross checking the register against CCTV footage, I prepared a list of habitual defaulters with two columns, one showing the recorded time from the attendance register as against CCTV-recorded time, and got it circulated amongst all the staff members.

Old habits die hard: some section in-charges had developed the routine of beginning their day by leisurely reading the newspapers subscribed for students. CCTV footage not only helped me to take firm corrective measures against the library staff, but also pilferage by students was significantly curtailed. The staff found idle on duty were also held accountable. These early interventions not only restored discipline but also set the tone for the larger transformation of the Maulana Azad Library.

### **2.2 Library services and Interior facelift**

To facilitate the interior facelift of the Library, POP work was meticulously executed in the Outer Hall, the Central Hall, and later extended to the Manuscript Division and Auditorium. This transformation was carried out under the dedicated supervision of Mr. Asif Ali Khan 'Saffu', the library's conscientious Caretaker, who played a pivotal role in ensuring excellence. By successfully arranging for a skilled



POP team from Delhi, he secured a standard of workmanship that lent enduring quality and distinction to the project. The execution of quality POP work dramatically transformed the Outer and Central Halls of the Library, most strikingly the circular dome at the centre with a chandelier, enhancing the grandeur of the building.

Given the meagre financial resources, the work was managed with ingenuity. A painter and an assistant were appointed against leave vacancies — a common practice in large institutions — thereby saving on labour costs, while the expenditure on materials was met through the Library's contingency funds. Similarly, a carpenter and an electrician were engaged as daily wagers on leave vacancies. The carpenter's contribution was invaluable: he not only crafted new showcases but also repaired the large pile of broken furniture that had accumulated over several years. The electricians, on the other hand, undertook the crucial task of replacing the old, exposed wiring by embedding it underground throughout the library, cutting about 10 inch chases into the walls to accommodate distributed circuits.

### ➤ **Outer Hall**

Apart from the interior decoration and facelift of the Library's Outer Hall — where visitors are welcomed by Sadequain's masterpiece of Islamic calligraphy and the much-celebrated Library Tarana composed by Dr. Moozam Ali Khan — another effort that deserves mention is the affixing of verses related to the pursuit of knowledge, drawn from the Holy Qur'an and Hadith.

These inscriptions were placed with the intent of helping every visitor grasp the true spirit of Islam — a faith often misperceived by some as bound to traditionalism and devoid of intellectual vitality. In reality, Islam is deeply rooted in the quest for knowledge, learning, and wisdom, and the Library's Outer Hall stands as a radiant testament to this enduring truth.

During my tenure, when the rebuilding of the library stood as a foremost priority, special efforts were undertaken to link the academic theme of the university

— “عَلَّمَ الْإِنْسَانَ مَا لَمْ يَعْلَمْ” (He taught man what he knew not) —

with the library itself. At my request, Prof. Abdul Raheem Kidwai, an esteemed Islamic scholar and then Director of the UGC HRDC (Academic Staff College), carefully selected verses from the Holy Qur'an and Hadith, each underscoring the profound significance of acquiring knowledge for humankind. These timeless words were inscribed across all four walls of the Library's Outer Hall, transforming the space into a living tribute to the pursuit of knowledge. They remind every visitor that the quest for knowledge is not merely an academic endeavour, but a sacred duty and a noble journey. This stands as a powerful rebuttal to the narrow-minded perception that Islam is an orthodox faith whose followers — especially women — are destined to remain uneducated. Instead, the Library itself became a radiant testament to Islam's enduring commitment to enlightenment, learning, and the empowerment of all seekers of knowledge.

➤ **Central Hall**

The Central Hall stands as the true hub of the library's activities. It serves not only as the principal access point to every corner of the institution but also as a vibrant space that embodies its intellectual spirit. Within this hall are housed the Online Catalogue, three evocative photo galleries, and, most significantly, the treasured Sir Syed Personal Library — a showcase that connects the present generation with the visionary legacy of the founder.

As the Manual Catalogue Card cabinets and display tables were phased out, careful planning was undertaken to ensure the maximum utilisation of space in the Central Hall. The objective was not only to serve multiple purposes but also to impart a beautiful facelift befitting the library's stature.

In line with this vision, **four important showcases were thoughtfully installed** in the Central Hall, each designed to meet specific requirements of space management while simultaneously enriching the intellectual and cultural atmosphere of the Library.

- **New Arrivals Showcase** – Professionally designed to keep users informed of the latest acquisitions. Previously, new books were displayed on tables with glass tops in the centre of the hall, a practice reminiscent of the pre digital era and one that consumed valuable space. The vertical new showcase mounted

on the wall not only displayed books physically but was complemented by a 60 inch colour monitor installed in the Central Hall. This monitor was used innovatively to highlight new arrivals and illuminated manuscripts — a pioneering initiative, though later discontinued.

- **Publications of University Staff Showcase-** Directly opposite the New Arrivals section, a dedicated showcase was installed on the wall to highlight the publications of university faculty members. This initiative, widely admired by both the academic community and visitors, provided a visible platform to celebrate the scholarly output of the staff. It not only acknowledged the intellectual contributions of the faculty but also inspired students and researchers by presenting the University's vibrant academic culture.
- **Must Read Books Showcase-** Two additional showcases were placed strategically on either side of the entrance to the Research Division. The one on the left was designated as the 'Must Read Books' Showcase, featuring carefully selected works aimed at general knowledge enrichment and personality development. This collection served as a guide for students and readers seeking to broaden their horizons beyond their immediate disciplines, encouraging holistic growth and intellectual curiosity.

R No. 7930 VC  
Date 14/11/10  
VC's Secretariat, AMU



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## MAULANA AZAD LIBRARY

ALIGARH MUSLIM UNIVERSITY, ALIGARH-202002 (U.P.) INDIA

*Prof. Shabahat Husain*  
Librarian-in-charge

*V. Ch.*  
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*V. Ch.*  
*Librarian-in-charge*

Ref. No. 15891008  
Dated 14/11/10

Vice-Chancellor, AMU:

You may kindly agree that there is a gradual decline in the social & moral values in succeeding generations. The students of AMU are no exception to this phenomena. They particularly need to read some books that can help them to become better human beings.

I therefore, intend to put certain books dealing with personality development, character building, morality and ethics in a separate show case marked as:

### "MUST READ BOOKS"

The proposed show case, basically meant to attract attention of the students, will consist of books such as:-

1. Road to Success by Bill Gates
2. How to win friends and influence people by Dale Carnegie
3. Living seven habits: Stories of courage & inspiration by Stephon R Covey
4. How to be more Interesting by De Bono, Edward.

Certain Professors of the University will be approached to help me select at least 50 books of that nature. I shall be obliged if you could kindly recommend some such books on the basis of your vast experience.

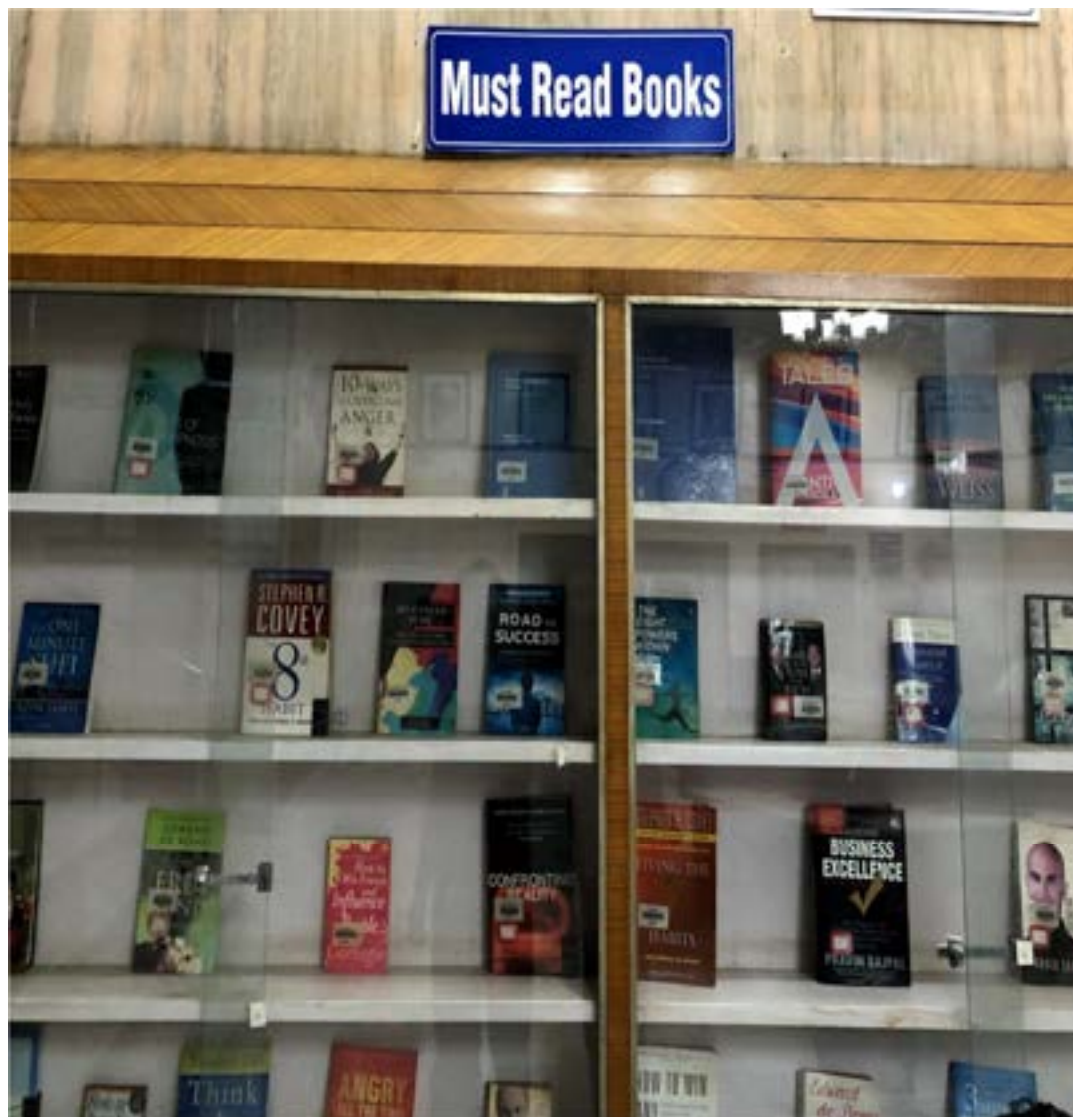
Thanking you in anticipation,

Yours faithfully,

*Shusain*  
(Prof. Shabahat Husain)  
Librarian-In-Charge

Unit-170  
Postal Address : 4/465, Sharafat Lodge (Behind Akbar Market), Civil Lines, Aligarh-202002 (U.P.) INDIA







## **Chapter 10**

### **Modernisation of Maulana Azad Library (2008 – 2012) Part 2**

#### **Sir Syed Personal Library – Rediscovery and Showcase**

##### **Introduction**

Since joining the Department of Library and Information Science in 1976, I was deeply aware of Sir Syed Ahmad Khan's generous donation of his personal library to the Lytton Library of the Muhammadan Anglo-Oriental (M.A.O.) College. This nucleus steadily expanded into what, by the time of my tenure, had grown into a vast repository of 1.35 million volumes.

Over the decades, however, Sir Syed's personal collection had become dispersed within the immense holdings of the Maulana Azad Library. Determined to recover this invaluable treasure, I deputed a dedicated team of library staff to trace the books using carefully defined identifiers:

- His preferred languages of Urdu and Persian.
- Autographs and handwritten notes on title pages.
- A distinctive brass seal engraved with his name.
- Marginal annotations in Sir Syed's own hand.

Through their Herculean efforts, the team successfully identified about three dozen books and manuscripts. Holding these volumes was a profoundly moving experience — a moment of goosebumps, knowing that these very pages had once been read and touched by Sir Syed Ahmad Khan himself.

My joy was boundless when I informed Prof. P.K. Abdul Azis, Vice Chancellor, of this remarkable discovery. On my recommendation, he graciously issued a letter of appreciation, acknowledging the collective efforts of the staff and myself in achieving this significant milestone.



These rare books of historical importance were subsequently showcased in the Central Hall, on the right side of the Research Division, under the title “Sir Syed Personal Library.” Each book /manuscript in the display showcase consisted of the details of its identification for the benefit of the visitors. The display was adorned with Sir Syed's portrait above, and between the portrait and the showcase was placed a plate inscribed with a poignant Urdu couplet, lending the exhibit a sense of reverence and continuity:

شام در شام جلیں گے تیری یادوں کے چراغ  
نسل در نسل ترا درد نمایاں ہوگا۔

The showcase soon became a special source of attraction for visitors, symbolising the living bond between Sir Syed's vision and the library's enduring legacy.

Regrettably, the inscribed plate with the couplet was later removed, diminishing the display's original aura.



**Sir Syed Personal Library Showcase**



# ALIGARH MUSLIM UNIVERSITY

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**Prof. (Dr.) P.K. Abdul Azis**  
Ph.D., D.Sc.  
Vice-Chancellor

D.No. 481 NC/Sectt  
January 4, 2010

Prof. Shabhat Husain,  
Librarian-in-Charge,  
Maulana Azad Library,  
AMU, Aligarh.

Subject: Rediscovering Sir Syed's Personal Library.  
Reference: Your letter no. 1453/MAL dated 30.12.2009.

**Dear Prof. Husain,**

I am delighted to see that you are trying to put together the personal collection of Sir Syed Ahmad Khan lying scattered in the Maulana Azad Library by initiating a retrieval effort to benefit every one interested in Sir Syed. It is gratifying to note that you have already retrieved 15 books and 15 manuscripts that would go into a showcase marked as "**Sir Syed's Personal Library**".

I place on record my appreciation for the work you have initiated. Please convey my appreciations to the following employees for their dedicated work, in this regard.

1. Dr. T.S. Asghar, Asstt. Librarian
2. Dr. Shaista Bedar, Asstt. Librarian
3. Mr. Mahmood Ali, Asstt. Librarian
4. Mr. Abdul Quddus Khan, Calligraphist

With best regards,

Yours sincerely,

**Prof. P.K. Abdul Azis**

### **3. Management of shelf space in the library**

Another pressing challenge was the rapidly dwindling shelf space. As the Library's collection continued to expand, the absence of a clearly defined policy for weeding out old books made the process cumbersome and ineffective. Consequently, the demand for proper shelf space grew acute. My predecessors had attempted to address this by narrowing the walking space between shelves. Still, this solution came at the cost of convenience for students and faculty, who needed adequate room to browse and consult books for selection comfortably.

#### **3.1 Clearing the Library's Junkyard, Obsolete Books and Discarded Newspapers**

Strangely, while shelf-space management remained a persistent problem, the library's seventh floor (West side) had long been reduced to a junkyard, cluttered with discarded items accumulated over decades, while the east side of the floor still consisted of a heap of discarded books and Newspapers. To make matters worse, the lift had been non-functional for nearly ten years, forcing users to rely solely on the staircase.

Fortunately, the Library has never been short of manpower. I therefore entrusted the Caretaker of the Library with the responsibility of clearing the seventh floor, utilising internal staff, thus saving on the labour cost. The work was executed systematically, with due care to avoid future audit objections.

A massive heap of discarded newspapers was also removed by following the prescribed procedure: quotations were invited from wastepaper collectors (Raddiwalas), and the weighing of the material was carried out on the big balance (Kanta) placed at the main gate of the library, under the supervision of four Assistant Librarians. The proceeds from the sale — approximately one lakh rupees — were duly deposited in the Finance Office, though the arduous waste-clearing procedure discouraged me from applying the same method to all the discarded books in the stacks.

My priority was clear: within a short tenure, I had to undertake multiple initiatives to bring about a visible transformation in the face and functioning of the library.

Streamlining waste disposal was one such step, but the larger goal remained the modernisation and revitalization of the institution.

However, records of junk materials were maintained meticulously, and unusable items were formally written off. This initiative not only freed up valuable space but also restored the seventh floor to meaningful use, marking a significant step toward resolving the long-standing issue of shelf-space management.

### **3.2 Recovery of Rare Books and Manuscripts**

Upon assuming charge of the library on 25-09-2008, I initiated a cleaning drive of the seventh-floor stacks to sort out the space problems, especially in Oriental Division. It led to a remarkable discovery of a total of 2,517 books in Arabic, Persian, and Urdu, of which nearly 1,000 belonged to the rare-book category. Among the same pile, four manuscripts were also unearthed, including one titled *Ittehaful Akaabir* by Shaukat Ali, dated 1296 AH.

This recovery was formally reported in the Library Committee meeting held on 2 December 2008, where members expressed deep concern over the prevailing state of affairs. The Librarian-in-Charge further informed the committee about an additional pile of nearly 25,000 obsolete books occupying valuable space on the seventh floor (East).

The committee agreed in principle that the weeding process should be undertaken without delay. What struck me most was that, as an outsider and Professor of Library Science, I could immediately perceive these long-standing problems, whereas the senior staff of the library — who collectively served nearly 15 years so far as Acting University Librarians — had failed to clear the accumulated junk and obsolete books. Their inaction perpetuated the crisis of shelf space, leaving the institution burdened with avoidable inefficiencies.

This episode underscored the need for fresh vision and decisive leadership in library administration: problems that had lingered for years could, in fact, be resolved through systematic planning and professional resolve.

### **3.3 Recovery of portraits of Founder's colleagues**

In addition to these reforms, another significant recovery was made by Mr Asif Ali Khan, caretaker, from the junkyard: portraits of Sir Syed Ahmad Khan's colleagues, who had stood by him during the Aligarh Movement and also that of 'Asrarul Haq 'Majaz'. These portraits were carefully restored, framed, and displayed in the Central Hall gallery, placed on either side of Sir Syed's portrait. Each was accompanied by a brief introduction highlighting the individual's contribution to the movement, thereby enriching the cultural and historical ambience of the library.

### **4. Revision of Library Rules and Recovery of Portraits**

Prof. Naushad Ali P.M., as a member of the library committee, underscored the urgent need to revise the library rules, which had remained unchanged since 1975. Acting upon this, the Librarian-in-Charge undertook a systematic revision of all rules relating to:

- Weeding of obsolete books
- Procedures for stock verification
- Issuance of books to different categories of users for home use
- Collection of fines for late returns and/or loss of books
- Other operational regulations essential to library management

These reforms were implemented without delay, ensuring that the library's functioning aligned with contemporary academic and administrative needs.

It was also proposed that the official website of the Maulana Azad Library be launched at the earliest. This important task, too, was undertaken by the Librarian in Charge, marking a significant step toward modernisation and transparency.

<https://www.amu.ac.in/libraries/maulana-azad-library>

### **5. Reorganisation of Library collection**

The Maulana Azad Library is renowned not merely for its English-language holdings, but more significantly for its vast and invaluable collections in Urdu, Persian, and Arabic. Over time, these sections became so congested that books

had to be stacked even on top of almirahs. Recognising the urgency of the situation, I took the decisive step of relocating the Hindi and Sanskrit sections to the seventh floor, which had previously been occupied by the junk material.

The entire floor was thoughtfully redeveloped: walls were freshly painted in light blue colour, while carpeting was laid in dark blue colour, giving a tasteful light-and-dark blue combination. The whole space was divided into two functional zones — shelving on one side and a well-furnished reading area on the other. Modern amenities were introduced, including proper air-conditioning and OPAC terminals. By the time library's lift became operational after about a decade. Most importantly, the sequence of books from the 1st to the 6th floor was not disturbed by such a move, while creating much-needed shelf space for the collections in the Oriental Division.

However, one of my successors chose to shift the Hindi–Sanskrit section to the fourth floor, for reasons best known to him. This decision not only squandered the resources already invested in its careful refurbishing but also disrupted the original sequence of books so thoughtfully established by the visionary administrator, Padamshree Bashiruddin Ahmad.

In the process, the bound journals arranged subject-wise from 000 to 999 were first displaced from the fourth floor to the seventh floor, only to make way for the Hindi and Sanskrit collections. Ironically, the same setting and colour scheme that I had introduced on the seventh floor in 2009–10 was replicated on the fourth floor, further underscoring the redundancy of the move.

In my considered view, such a step constitutes a professional blunder — undermining both the intellectual order and the continuity of the library's classification system, while wasting valuable institutional resources.

Nevertheless, my decision to shift the Hindi-Sanskrit section to the west of the seventh floor created much-needed breathing space. The Urdu, Persian, and Arabic collections, along with several donated collections, were systematically rearranged in the vacated area, ensuring both accessibility and preservation. The initiative not only alleviated overcrowding but also enhanced the library's stature as a multilingual repository of knowledge, blending tradition with modern infrastructure.

## **6. Manuscripts Division: Reorganisation and facelift**

The Maulana Azad Library is renowned for its extraordinary collection of nearly 16,000 manuscripts, many of which belong to the “rarest of the rare” category. Yet, paradoxically, this priceless division long remained the most neglected, earning ironic descriptions such as a “Bhoot Bangla,” a century-old haunted house. From 1960, when the Maulana Azad Library was inaugurated, until I assumed charge in 2008, the focus was confined to mere custodianship rather than preservation, conservation, or scholarly dissemination. The neglect ran so deep that the keys to two steel almirahs remained missing for nearly three decades, with successive librarians reluctant to take responsibility for the unaccessioned manuscripts, uncertain of their number or condition.

Ultimately, the almirahs were opened under videographic recording, in the presence of all Deputy Librarians and Shri S.M.A. Khusro, a highly respected retired Additional Sessions Judge who had served in Aligarh during the late 1970s and 1980s. Following his retirement, he was a regular user of the Maulana Azad Library during my tenure as Librarian. In recognition of his stature and dedication, a seat and selected reading materials were reserved for him in the Librarian’s chamber, where he continued his scholarly engagement with the library’s resources. On several occasions, I sought his counsel on important administrative and financial matters, benefiting from his wisdom and judicial experience.

### **6.1 Restoration of dilapidated Manuscripts: Grant from Saudi Arabia**

The discovery revealed that a substantial portion of the manuscripts had fallen into a dilapidated state. In the meeting of the Library Committee held on 2 December 2008, I apprised the members of the generous financial assistance of ₹12,84,246.58 received from the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, following the visit of H.E. Saleh Mohd. Al-Ghamdi, Ambassador to India, on Sir Syed Day in 2006. Regrettably, the grant had remained unutilized since its sanction.

The matter was discussed at length, and it was resolved that the restoration of the dilapidated manuscripts would be undertaken through a committee appointed by the Vice-Chancellor under the chairmanship of Prof. M. Salimuddin, former Pro-Vice-Chancellor and a distinguished Biotechnologist of



the country. As a result, restoration and curative conservation treatment were successfully administered to 300 manuscripts.

The Vice-Chancellor himself reviewed the progress of the project in the subsequent meeting of the Library Committee held on 11 March 2011. The same high-powered committee constituted by the Vice-Chancellor continued to oversee all major tasks and acquisitions of the library. This decisive intervention not only rescued the manuscripts from further decay but also shielded the librarian from mounting criticism, underscoring the indispensable role of visionary leadership in safeguarding the intellectual heritage of the institution.

## **6.2 Cataloguing and digitisation of the manuscripts**

Equally pressing was the need to complete cataloguing and digitisation of the manuscripts collection, so that the steeped knowledge contained in these manuscripts could enlighten scholars worldwide. To modernise operations, the Lybsys 7.0 software with Unicode facility was procured, enabling the cataloguing of manuscripts and the multilingual holdings of the Oriental Division.

## **6.3 The Juma Al Majid Centre for Culture and Heritage, Dubai**

The Juma Al Majid Center for Culture and Heritage in Dubai, renowned for acquiring and digitizing microfilms of manuscript collections worldwide, has forged over 120 bilateral agreements with international libraries, universities, and cultural institutions. Its initiatives include major projects such as the digitization of over 3,800 rare manuscripts at Jamia Hamdard, New Delhi, and the ambitious “100,000 Manuscripts Project” in partnership with global bodies like the Bibliotheca Alexandrina. Beyond digitization, the Center dispatches expert restorers and specialized equipment to countries in need, physically saving and restoring deteriorating texts.

Prior to my tenure as Librarian, Aligarh Muslim University signed an MOU with the Centre containing significant clauses:

(1) digitization of the entire manuscript collection of the Maulana Azad Library, complete with metadata, in exchange for an equal number of digitized manuscripts from their holdings;

(2) gifting of digitization equipment along with a specialized restoration machine developed in the USA worth ₹10 lakhs (in 2008); and

(3) training of two library staff members at the Centre in Dubai. After assuming charge, I expedited its implementation, and digitization work commenced under the supervision of the Manuscript Division. However, the well-wishers of the University raised their concerns to the Vice Chancellor, those digital images of manuscripts had once been misused for monetary gain nearly two decades earlier. Considering this, the Library Committee — the highest administrative body of the library (like the Academic Council), chaired by the Vice Chancellor decided to wind up the project. In my personal view, such a decision was a loss for the library.

#### **6.4 Chance Discovery of Rare Items from Manuscript Division**

During the course of corrective measures in the Manuscript Division, I, with the assistance of Dr. Ata Khursheed, Assistant Librarian, in charge of the Division, was able to uncover several rare and remarkable items:

- Sale deeds – 348 documents, the oldest dated 1011 AH (1602 CE) from Akbar's reign, and the latest dated 1215 AH (1800 CE).
- Sword of Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb – one.
- Unaccessioned manuscripts – approximately 350.
- Photo frame – containing three miniature portraits of Emperor Shahjahan, Queen Mumtaz Mahal, and the Taj Mahal.
- Sapphire pen stand – presented to the Vice Chancellor, AMU, by Nadir Shah, King of Afghanistan, in 1933.
- Trowels (Kanni) – two Trowels used to lay the foundation stones of:
  - Maulana Azad Library by Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru on 12 November 1955.
  - University Swimming Pool by Sir James Scorgie Maston, Lieutenant Governor of the United Provinces, in 1916.

All these items were formally displayed during the meeting of the Library Committee held on 11 March 2011. On that occasion, the Vice Chancellor, while commending the improvements achieved in the library over the preceding two

and a half years, specially remarked that “all the aforesaid developments have taken place without any additional grant to the library.”

Among the discoveries, the sword of Emperor Aurangzeb drew particular attention. Several committee members posed with the sword, capturing photographs that underscored its historical allure. The news of this discovery quickly spread, receiving extensive coverage in both print and digital media. Leading national dailies such as The Times of India, Hindustan Times, and The Indian Express reported the find, while television channels — most notably Doordarshan — broadcast the story, including an interview with me.

#### **An Encounter with a Foreign Journalist**

During this period, I received a call from a foreign journalist based in Delhi, known for his coverage of Latin America. As per our fixed appointment, he visited me, though I sensed a certain hostility in his attitude toward the University and its legacy. While narrating the history of the University, the Library, and especially its manuscript collection, I not only showed him the items he had come to see but also introduced him to some of the rarest of the rare manuscripts preserved in our holdings.

Later, I took him around the University in my personal car, highlighting its landmarks, particularly the grand old building of the M.A.O. College. Along the way, I explained how the institution had earned the title “Oxford of the East.” He was visibly impressed by the discipline on campus, repeatedly remarking on the absence of students in the streets. I explained that they were all engaged in their classes.

In discussing the legacy of the founder, Sir Syed Ahmad Khan, I emphasised his secular vision, quoting his famous words: “India is like a beautiful bride, and Hindus and Muslims are like its two beautiful eyes; both are essential for the beauty and survival of the bride.”

By the end of the day, after sharing lunch with him, I introduced him to the Vice Chancellor, who must have handled him well before his departure to Delhi. Some days later, he sent me a copy of his published report in Spanish. Upon translation, I discovered that he had rendered Sir Syed’s metaphor of “bride” as

**“girlfriend.” No doubt, the concept of bride as a cultural symbol was unfamiliar in his society, leading to this curious mistranslation.**



**Times of India**

**<https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/india/aurangzebs-sword-found-in-amu-cupboard/articleshow/7789877.cms>**

**<https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com › india › Aurangzebs-sword-found-in...>**

**Aurangzeb's sword found in AMU cupboard - Times of India**

**Mar 25, 2011 · Khurshid, head of the manuscript division at AMU's Maulana Azad Library, found the treasure last month during a ...**

**Author: Manjari Mishra**

**Times of India**

**<https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/lucknow/aurangzeb-sword-tumbles-out-of-amu-cupboard/articleshow/7789594.cms>**

**Aurangzeb sword tumbles out of AMU cupboard - Times of India**

**Mar 26, 2011 · Last month, when he opened the almirah that had been left untouched for the past five decades, Khurshid, the head of ...**

**Aurangzeb's sword, pen stand gifted by Afghan King re-discovered at AMU**

**Monday March 14, 2011 08:00:54 PM, Special Correspondent**

### Aurangzeb's sword, pen stand gifted by Afghan King re-discovered at AMU

Monday March 14, 2011 08:00:54 PM, Special Correspondent



The sword of Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb (below) which is re-discovered at Maulana Azad Library, AMU today during its re-organisation.

**Aligarh:** The ongoing process of reorganization of manuscripts at Maulana Azad Library, Aligarh Muslim University (AMU) has revealed some hidden treasure in the form of museum pieces including a sword of Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb, according to the university officials.

A close look revealed that a couplet in old Persian is engraved on the sword in gold indicating that the same was presented to Aurangzeb.

Another piece is a Pen Stand made of Sapphire gifted by the King Nadirshah of Afghanistan to the then Vice-Chancellor of AMU in 1933.

Such pieces along with 350 recently discovered manuscripts and an equal number of sale deeds (1602 AD - 1800 AD) were put on display.

The Maulana Azad Library is particularly known for its oriental collection including 16 thousands manuscripts, a large number of which belongs to rarest of the rare category, the officials said.

It also has a fragment of Holy Quran written in 'Khat-e-Kufi' on parchment, which is claimed to be inscribed by Hazrat Ali (the 4th Caliph of Islam), 1400 years ago.

Besides, several royal decrees of Mughal Emperors namely Babar, Akbar, Shahjahan, Shah Alam, Aurangzeb etc and translation of Sanskrit works as Mahapurana, Bhagwad Geeta, Mahabharata and Leelawati in Persian by Abul Faiz Faizi, a scholar of eminence in the court of Mughal Emperor Akbar also form the core of this all important National Asset.

Meanwhile, a meeting of the Library Committee of Maulana Azad Library was held in the Cultural Hall of Maulana Azad Library to discuss various issues pertaining to the smooth functioning of Maulana Azad Library.

Prof. Husain informed during the meeting that the library is now working to connect the entire 100 departmental libraries as well as the libraries of Murshidabad and Mallapuram Centre with Maulana Azad Library under a network, named as 'AMULIBNET'.

Community News

## Aurangzeb's sword and pen stand re-discovered at AMU



The Milli Gazette,  
12 Apr 2011



Aligarh: A sword of Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb was accidentally re-discovered at Maulana Azad Library, AMU during a re-organisation recently. Another piece re-discovered was a pen-stand made of sapphire gifted by the King Nadirshah of Afganistan to the AMU in 1933. These are part of

# Samyuktha Harshitha

Hari Sarvothama Vayu Jeevothama -The Madhwa  
Way of the World

Saturday, 10 November 2012

## The sword that fell out of a cupboard

There were several locked cupboards in a university. These cupboards had remained unopened for decades. In February 2011, when one of the cupboards were opened, a sword with Persian engravings fell out.

The sword belonged to the last great Mughal emperor Aurangzeb who practically ruled over the whole of India in the late 17<sup>th</sup> century. Aurangzeb was the Emperor from 1658 to 1707 and he had succeeded Shahjahan to the throne.

The Mughal kings and royalty, including Aurangzeb, possessed several arms and many of these articles were noted for their magnificent make and beautiful carvings. Swords, daggers, knives, pistols and other arms belonging to the



## 6.5 Facelift of the Manuscript Division

**My vision was to transform the Manuscript Division — the most precious part of the Maulana Azad Library — into its most beautiful centre of attraction.** Hence, a comprehensive facelift was undertaken at the beginning of 2012, including a thoughtfully designed entrance and a manuscript gallery adorned with elegantly crafted POP pillars. The gallery walls were painted in a soothing light blue, complemented by a dark blue carpet, creating an atmosphere of dignity and calm befitting the treasures it housed

In essence, the reorganisation elevated the division from a neglected repository into a living archive of wisdom, combining preservation, accessibility, and modernisation for scholars worldwide. Paradoxically, the facelift coincided with the abrupt end of my tenure due to administrative changes. Ironically, as Prof. Azis's tenure came to an end, the renovated Manuscripts Division, from its original worst shape to its present best shape was inaugurated by Lt. Gen. Zamiruddin Shah shortly after assuming office **as Vice Chancellor on May 17, 2012.**







**Renovated Entrance to Manuscripts Division**



**Renovated Manuscripts Gallery**



## 6.6 Conservation Lab and Manuscripts Museum:

### Visit of Prof. Mushirul Hasan

Prof. Mushirul Hasan — eminent historian, former Vice Chancellor of Jamia Millia Islamia, and Director-General of the National Archives of India — was not only a distinguished intellectual and scholar of his time, but also an able administrator and, above all, a devoted alumnus and well-wisher of Aligarh Muslim University. His presence as chief guest during the Golden Jubilee celebrations on 7 December 2010 was a testament to his enduring bond with the institution.

It was in 2010, while I was serving as Librarian-in-Charge of the Maulana Azad Library, that Mr. Asif Ali Khan, the caretaker, informed me that Prof. Hasan was consulting books in the Oriental Division. True to his humility, he often visited the library like any ordinary user. I went to meet him in the reading room and invited him for tea after his study.

At that time, I was acutely aware of his powerful position as Director-General of the National Archives. During my tenure, nearly 300 dilapidated manuscripts had been preserved with the help of a grant from the Saudi Government, yet many more awaited conservations due to lack of funds. When Prof. Hasan graciously visited my chamber, I deliberately placed the restored manuscripts alongside those still in a fragile state, to emphasise the urgency of preservation.

I impressed upon him the need for a dedicated **Preservation and Conservation Laboratory** in the library — a “hospital” where manuscripts, as invaluable national assets, could receive proper treatment. I also stressed the importance of establishing a **Manuscripts Museum**, where select treasures could be displayed for scholarly and public appreciation under **temperature and humidity control, so essential for the longer life of manuscripts.**

Providentially, that day was the last date for submission of applications for funding from the National Archives. Prof. Hasan, ever supportive, immediately called his staff in Delhi and ensured that all formalities were completed without delay. His timely intervention gave momentum to the vision of safeguarding and showcasing the priceless manuscript heritage of the Maulana Azad Library.

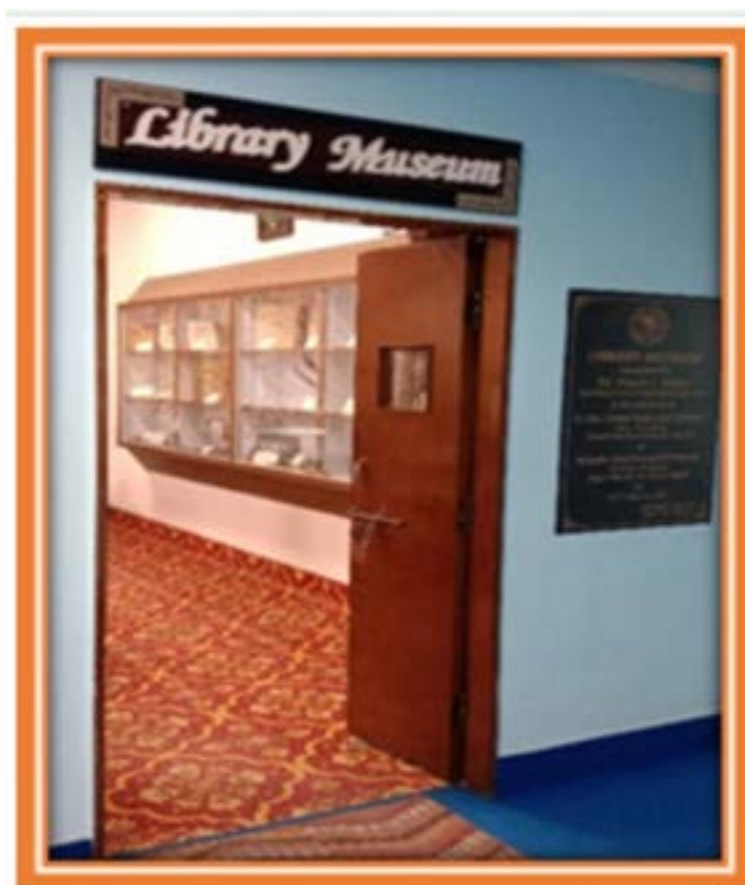
Consequently, a grant of **₹20 lakhs was sanctioned to the Maulana Azad Library — ₹10 lakhs each earmarked for the establishment of a Preservation and Conservation Laboratory and a Manuscripts Museum.** In recognition of my efforts, Prof. Mushirul Hasan later included my name in the panel of experts of the National Archives of India, entrusting me with on-the-spot evaluations of institutional demands across the country.

### Conservation Lab and Manuscripts Museum: A Missed Opportunity

Although the sanction letter was duly received during my tenure, the actual release of funds occurred only after I had relinquished charge. To the best of my knowledge, the development of the Conservation Lab stretched over more than two years, while the so-called Manuscripts Museum — curiously renamed the '**Library Museum**' for reasons best known to its architects — was inaugurated on 12 February 2017 in the Manuscript Division, regrettably without seeking my opinion.

It is said that **the grant of ₹20 lakhs ultimately lapsed without meaningful utilisation, and neither of the two facilities could rise to the standards originally envisaged.** Most critically, the **absence of proper temperature and humidity control continues to endanger the life of invaluable manuscripts both in the Museum and in shelving spaces.** The mere installation of air conditioners, without the requisite regulating equipment, is not only inadequate but potentially harmful to the manuscripts.

Nevertheless, I have always felt that at least one of these centres should have been named in honour of Prof. Mushirul Hasan — a distinguished alumnus, eminent scholar, and able administrator — as a fitting tribute to his vision and his timely intervention in safeguarding the manuscript heritage of the Maulana Azad Library. The following pics were taken from the MAL site.



## Chapter 10

### Modernisation of Maulana Azad Library (2008 – 2012) Part 3

#### 7. Retro conversion of Library Catalogue

Retro conversion is the process of converting traditional card catalogues or manual bibliographic records into a digital database. It involves systematically entering catalogue card information into computerised formats, often using library management software.

- **Purpose:** To modernise access, integrate collections into OPAC (Online Public Access Catalogue), and enable resource sharing.
- **Method:** Data entry, scanning, or outsourcing to specialised agencies.
- **Challenges:** Large volume of records, high cost, time-consuming effort, and need for accuracy.
- **Impact:** Transforms static card catalogues into searchable, networked systems, improving efficiency and user experience.

As stated earlier, the library had an annual budgetary allocation of ₹10 lakh for developing computer facilities. Before my tenure, much of this amount was routinely spent on outsourced retro conversion, with limited impact. Recognising the inefficiency, I introduced a major administrative change.

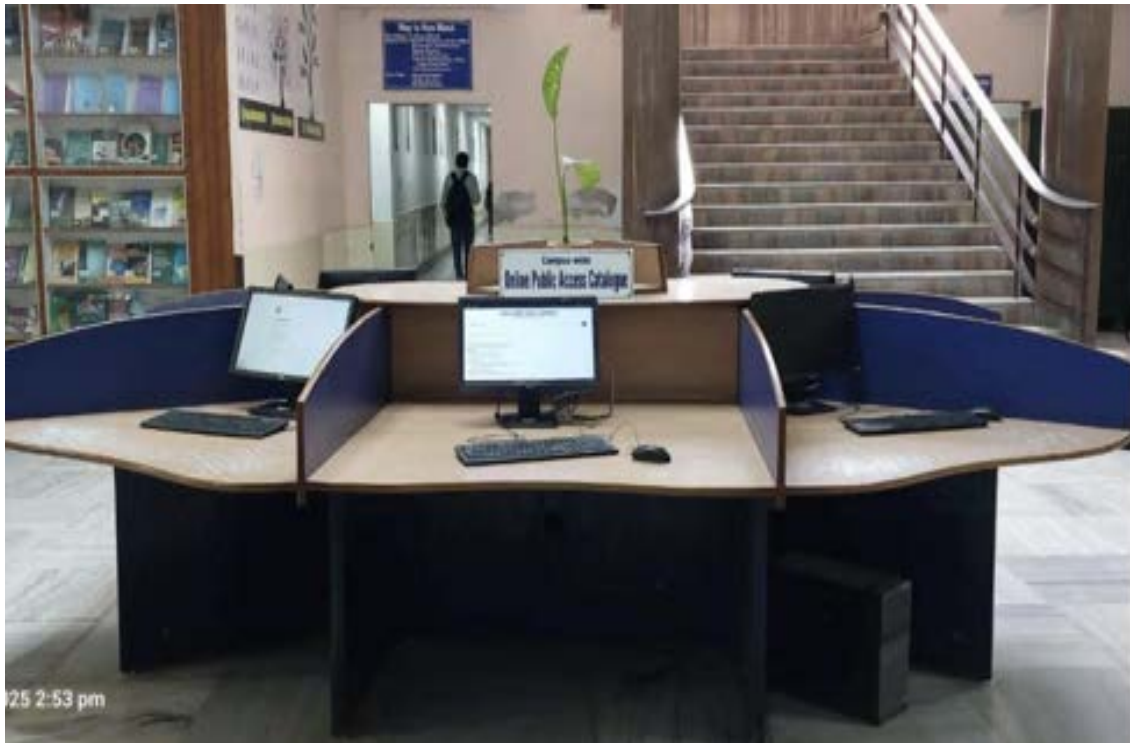
The library already had a sanctioned post of computer operator, which I filled with an MCA-qualified professional. In addition, several staff members possessed strong computer skills — and, fortunately, nearly 99% of the library staff had once been my students, which made training and coordination smoother.

In the computer lab, equipped with Libsys library software, we organised a series of short courses (each of one week's duration) providing training in data entry. Proper certificates were issued to the trainees. This ensured that the entire staff received hands-on training in retro conversion. To streamline the process, one person from each section was deputed for retro conversion, under the supervision of a senior staff member.

I was mindful of the varying workloads across sections: some remained busy year-round, while others peaked during admissions, examinations, or end-of-financial-year book purchases. To reduce bottlenecks, computers were also installed on the fourth floor of the seven-storied stack, enabling retro conversion close to the collections without moving books or catalogue cards to the lab. Priority was given to issuable books, ensuring faster progress. While others peaked during admissions, examinations, or end-of-financial-year



This strategy allowed us to complete retro conversion more efficiently, while also saving a substantial portion of the annual allocation. The competent authority reallocated the funds thus conserved for broader development and modernisation of the library.



**Online Public Access Catalogues in the middle of the central Hall**



## **8. Introduction of Online catalogue or OPACs in Libraries**

OPACs (Online Public Access Catalogues) are computerised catalogues that replaced the traditional card system, enabling users to search holdings by author, title, subject, keyword, or call number. They provide real-time access to bibliographic records and book availability, with advanced features such as search filters, cross-references, and user-friendly interfaces. Integrated with Library Management Systems (ILS), OPACs support resource sharing and remote access, making collections more accessible, searchable, and interactive.

In our library, OPACs were introduced by me through a Local Area Network (LAN) within the library building and extended to the entire campus via a Campus Area Network (CAN). Once the card catalogue was digitised, OPAC terminals were installed in every section and the seven-storied stacks. The central hall, which had long been dominated by card catalogue cabinets, was transformed into the OPAC hub.

Drawing inspiration from a library furniture magazine purchased in England, I designed a distinctive OPAC desk in the shape of an eight-petal flower, each petal accommodating one computer. A skilled furniture vendor executed the design with a striking bright blue and light teak wood combination. The table's concealed wiring and a beautifully crafted POP ceiling canopy added elegance, from which a chandelier — generously donated by an alumnus showroom owner — hung. Matching computer chairs completed the ensemble. This unique installation became the focal point of the library, attracting readers and visitors alike. The modern OPAC facility not only enhanced access but also symbolised the library's transition from tradition to technology, leading to a remarkable increase in usage and visibility across the University.

## **9. Automatic Security Gate for Books: 3M System**

Automatic security gates have become indispensable in modern library infrastructure, ensuring the safety and preservation of collections. The 3M Library Systems, a division of the US-based multinational 3M (NYSE: MMM), has pioneered library innovations for over four decades (3M Library Systems). By integrating technologies such as RFID and Tattle Tape, these gates prevent the unauthorised removal of books and resources, thereby safeguarding valuable assets. Beyond theft detection, they foster a disciplined environment, enabling staff to devote greater attention to user services rather than manual monitoring. Their installation reflects a library's commitment to modernisation, efficiency, and accountability, reassuring administrators and readers alike that resources remain secure while access is seamless and user-friendly.

When comparing RFID-based security systems with traditional Tattle Tape technology, the initial investment in RFID is substantially higher due to the cost of tags, readers, and integrated software. Yet RFID offers multifunctional advantages—supporting circulation, inventory management, and self-service kiosks—thus reducing long-term operational costs. In contrast, Tattle Tape is less expensive upfront, relying on



magnetic strips and detection gates, but its utility is confined to theft prevention alone. Consequently, while RFID requires capital expenditure nearly 50 times greater than Tattle Tape, it delivers a higher return on investment through efficiency, automation, and scalability. Tattle Tape, meanwhile, remains a budget-friendly but functionally limited option.

To uphold the library's commitment to modernisation, efficiency, and accountability, it was essential to reassure both the University's top administrators and the readers that resources were protected while access remained smooth and user-friendly. Yet, at the time, even securing funds for a basic Tattle Tape system proved difficult. Installing the best available American 3M System required a substantial investment, far beyond the library's means.

A turning point came during the 11th Five-Year Plan (2007–2012), when the University received a significant development grant, including a separate allocation for the Library. However, the grant was restricted to the subscription of back volumes of journals. Guided by the principle that where there is a will, there is a way—and by the grace of the Almighty—I devised a creative solution. I proposed to the Vice Chancellor that the annual grant of one crore rupees earmarked for journal subscriptions across nearly 100 departments be reappropriated for the installation of the 3M System (covering the automatic security gate, Tattle Tape strips for 2.64 lakh issuable books, and a workstation). Meanwhile, the journals' subscriptions for that financial year could be financed through the 11th Plan allocation. Both measures were fully compliant with University and UGC regulations.

The Vice Chancellor approved this pragmatic plan and, at my request, constituted a high-powered Library Sub-Committee to oversee the modernisation initiative. Chaired by Prof. M. Salimmuddin, an internationally reputed scientist and former Pro Vice Chancellor, the committee provided strategic oversight and institutional support, shielding the librarian from administrative hurdles.

A dedicated team of library staff meticulously affixed Tattle Tape strips to 2.5 lakh issuable books, while I personally supervised the integration and testing of the electronic systems with the circulation process. The Vice Chancellor himself conducted the final system test. The fully automated **3M Library Security System** became operational in 2010/11, functioning flawlessly for over a decade until 2022/23, when the technology became obsolete.

It was then replaced by a far more expensive RFID-friendly security system, though ironically, the University could never afford RFID tagging for its vast collection. As a result, the new system continues to support only Tattle Tape, symbolising both the progress achieved and the financial constraints that persist.



### **3M Automatic Security Gate**

#### **10. AMULIBNET – A Unified Library Network**

The Maulana Azad Library is a vast system comprising Faculty and Departmental Libraries. Although book purchases were centralized, the collections remained scattered across the University without a unified record. To address this gap, I presented the concept of AMULIBNET to the Vice Chancellor — a vision to connect the resources of departmental and faculty libraries, as well as AMU Centres at Murshidabad, Malappuram, etc with the online catalogue of the central library.

With his approval, the project was launched. As many as 52 library staff members working in different departments were trained in MS-Excel to enable them to feed their departmental data into the network. The progress of AMULIBNET was formally reported at the Library Committee meeting held on 11 March 2011.

A model procedure was developed to bring all AMU libraries together, ensuring continuity for future expansion and follow-up. By the end of 2011, the system had become fully operational, though the library website has somehow recorded its commencement date as 2012.

## 11. Digital Resource Centre (DRC): A Landmark in Library Modernisation

**A Digital Resource Centre (DRC)** plays a pivotal role in democratizing access to knowledge, ensuring that rare, scholarly, and contemporary digitized resources are preserved and made available to a global audience. It strengthens the library's mission by integrating traditional collections with digital archives, thereby **enriching research, teaching, and lifelong learning**.

During the **first decade of the 21st century**, a noticeable trend emerged across universities and special libraries to establish dedicated DRCs. Some institutions even went so far as to **rename their libraries as Digital Resource Centres**, reflecting the growing recognition that digital collections were no longer supplementary but central to academic and professional advancement. This marked a profound shift in library philosophy—from custodianship of physical holdings to leadership in **digital knowledge dissemination**.

In the course of **the reformation and modernisation of the Maulana Azad Library**, one of the earliest initiatives was the establishment of a DRC. Since no suitable space was available, I reorganised the Issue Section, raising a glass partition to carve out a chamber equipped with 10 systems and a server dedicated to preserving digitized resources. Among its treasures were approximately **1.75 lakh e-books**, downloaded free of cost from the **World e-Book Fair (Project Gutenberg and World Public Library)**—a landmark achievement in expanding scholarly access.

Another attraction of the DRC was the **Imation Disc Stakka**, an innovative CD storage and display machine. This motorized carousel could hold up to **100 CDs or DVDs**, connected via a single USB cable for both power and data transfer. Bundled with **OpdiTracker software**, it indexed and managed disc content seamlessly. A unique feature allowed up to five units to be stacked, forming a tower capable of holding **500 discs**.

The library subscribed to sets of CDs across disciplines, with the most valuable being those related to **Medical Sciences, especially Anatomy and Surgery**. These resources unusually attracted medical students to the Maulana Azad Library, as they greatly benefited in understanding classroom lectures and surgical procedures—despite the fact that their primary demands were otherwise met by the **Medical College Library**.

The **Digital Resource Centre (DRC)**, **CCTV system**, and **Campus-wide Online Catalogue** were inaugurated by **Prof. P. K. Abdul Azis**, Vice Chancellor, on **16 March 2009**. A grand inaugural function was held in the **Cultural Hall of the Maulana Azad Library**, presided over by the Vice Chancellor. The distinguished guests of honour included **Prof. M. Salimuddin**, former Pro-Vice Chancellor, AMU, and **Prof. N. Laxman Rao** from **Osmania University, Hyderabad**. Eminent dignitaries such as **Nawab Ibne Sayeed Khan 'Chatari'**, former Treasurer of the University, and **Prof. Khwaja Naseem Ahmad**, former Vice Chancellor, AMU, also graced the occasion.

In his address, Prof. Azis warmly appreciated the efforts of the **Librarian-in-Charge**, acknowledging the concrete steps taken to usher in much-needed changes in the library system. He described the inauguration of the DRC, CCTV network, and campus-wide online catalogue as a **milestone in the modernisation of the Maulana Azad Library**.

Prof. P. K. Abdul Azis had expressed the hope that the Digital Resource Centre (DRC), inaugurated in a modest makeshift space with only ten systems, would mark the beginning of a larger vision. With the completion of the new library building, funded by a grant of ₹5 crores, he envisioned the DRC expanding to accommodate at least 100 systems, thereby offering enhanced facilities to the students and staff of the University.

His prophetic words seem to have come true. On 15 September 2016, a new Digital Resources Centre was inaugurated in the library's new building, equipped with 96 systems. From a service perspective, both the current Digital Resources Centre and the earlier Digital Resource Centre (2009) provide the same campus-wide access to online resources, serving the University community.

### ***Digital Resource Centre: Vision and Controversy***

Yet, following the reinauguration, two issues have sparked discussion on the campus:

1. **Academic justification** — A critical question arises regarding the reinauguration of a six-year-old Digital Resource Centre (DRC), whose original plaque continues to adorn the library's main gate. The duplication of commemorative plaques for the same facility inevitably raises concerns of institutional propriety and historical continuity. Such practices risk creating ambiguity in the library's archival record, blurring the distinction between genuine innovation and ceremonial repetition.

The issue is further compounded by the **re-inauguration of the Oriental Division on the same date in the new building**. This division has been an **integral part of the Maulana Azad Library since its inception in 1960**, and its re-dedication, without substantive structural or functional transformation, invites scrutiny. From an academic standpoint, these actions raise questions about the appropriateness of symbolic reinaugurations in established institutions, where continuity and authenticity are central to scholarly credibility.

2. **Grammatical correctness** — The installation of a new plaque using the word Resources instead of Resource has been contested. Grammarians argue that Resource is the correct and internationally preferred usage, functioning as a **modifier of "Centre"** — meaning "a centre for digital resources." In contrast, Resources Centre is less common in global English and may be considered grammatically imprecise.

**It is for the honourable readers of this e-book to decide on the aforementioned two issues**

Amidst this progress, however, one symbol of early innovation — the once-celebrated **Imation Disc Stakka** — has quietly disappeared alongside a collection of CDs and DVDs, surviving only in memory as part of the library's journey of modernisation.



**Imation Disc Stakka**



**Inauguration of 'Digital Resource Centre' (DRC), CCTV system, and 'Campus-wide Online Catalogue'**

## AMU NEWS and Views

(<http://amunewsandviews.blogspot.com/2009/03/digital-resource-centre-closed-circuit.html> )

### **Digital Resource Centre, Closed Circuit TV and Campus wide Online Catalogue at MA Library, AMU inaugurated by Dr Rahat Abrar, Public Relations Officer**

**Aligarh March 16:** The Vice Chancellor of Aligarh Muslim University Prof. P. K. Abdul Azis today inaugurated a Digital Resource Centre, Closed Circuit TV and Campus wide Online Catalogue at Maulana Azad Library of the Aligarh Muslim University.

Addressing the function Prof. P.K. Abdul Azis said that the new building of the Central Library equipped with internet facility will be constructed at a cost of Rs. Five Crore to provide better space to students, researchers and faculty members. He said that the University is planning digital classrooms in the next two years and urged the faculty members to make this University a centre of excellence and help regain the glory of this historic institution. Professor N. Laxman Rao of Osmania University, Hyderabad, said on this occasion that this is the first university library in India which opens from 8 O'clock morning to 2 O'clock night. He said that this library has created history by installing CCTV to maintain the functioning of the library.

Earlier, Professor Shabhat Husain, Librarian-in-charge, Maulana Azad Library said that the digital resources have now become an essential part of library collection. He said that we have installed ten systems to begin with in order to access the digital resources loaded onto a high-power server.

Using the server of the Computer Centre, a link has been created on the internet to enable faculty members and students to access the online catalogue from anywhere in the campus.

He said that the modern CCTV installed in the library not only gives pictures of the different areas of the library but also has facilities for recording and infrared photography. The present system of CCTV is also a boon for the security of the invaluable collection of manuscripts, as in case of any intrusion in odd hours, the system will send messages to three authorised persons.

He said that another important task ahead is the digitisation of about 16000 manuscripts and about 5000 rare books in different languages.

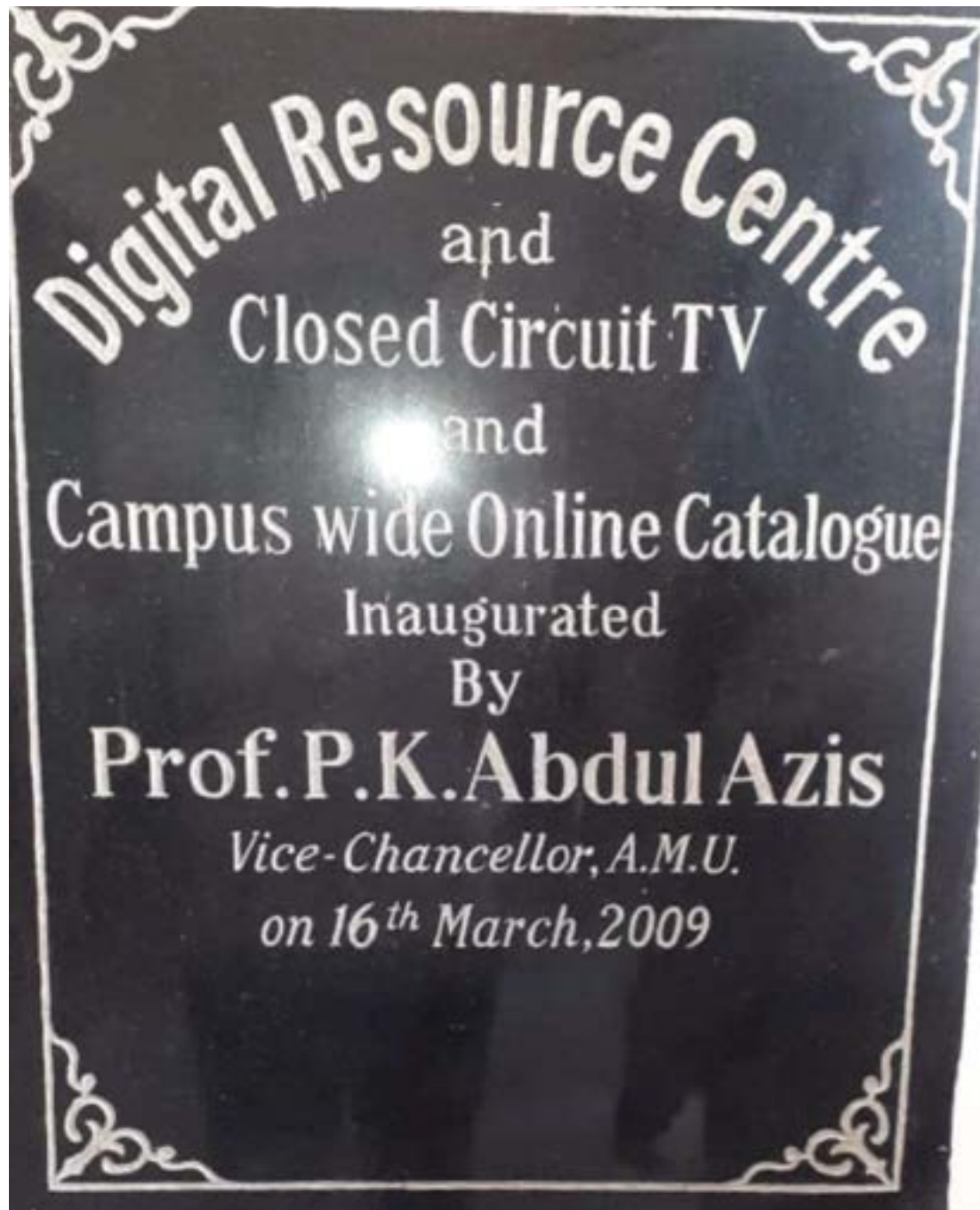
Prof. Husain informed that the Vice Chancellor has approved the installation of an automatic security gate through which nobody would be able to take out any unissued book outside the library by using unfair means. This move is, however, not an easy task because every book of the gigantic collection in the library will have to be provided with an electronic device, which is a time-consuming and painstaking job.

Prof. M. Saleemuddin of the Biotechnology Unit and Professor M. Saud Alam Qasmi, Dean Faculty of Theology also addressed the function. Nawab Ibne Saeed Khan of



Chhatari and Prof. Shamim Ahmad, former acting Vice Chancellor and Professor A. A. Nizami, Dean Faculty of Engineering, also graced the occasion.

(Dr. Rahat Abrar), Public Relations Officer







## Digital Resources Centre

*Inaugurated by*

*Lt. Gen. Zameer Uddin Shah (Veteran)*

*Hon'ble Vice Chancellor  
Aligarh Muslim University, Aligarh*

*in the presence of*

*Brigadier Syed Ahmad Ali (Veteran)*

*Hon'ble Pro Vice-Chancellor  
Aligarh Muslim University, Aligarh*

*&*

*Dr. Nabi Hasan  
University Librarian*

*on*

*15<sup>th</sup> September, 2016*



## Oriental Division

*Inaugurated by*

*Lt. Gen. Zameer Uddin Shah (Veteran)*

*Hon'ble Vice Chancellor  
Aligarh Muslim University, Aligarh*

*in the presence of*

*Brigadier Syed Ahmad Ali (Veteran)*

*Hon'ble Pro Vice-Chancellor  
Aligarh Muslim University, Aligarh*

*&*

*Dr. Nabi Hasan  
University Librarian*

*on*

*15<sup>th</sup> September, 2016*

## 12. UGC Grant and New building of Maulana Azad Library

The University Grants Commission (UGC) sanctioned a major grant in the early 2009s under its Eleventh Plan (2007–2012) scheme to strengthen infrastructure in central universities. This support formed part of UGC's broader Development Assistance program, which prioritised the modernization of libraries, laboratories, and digital resource centres.

The grant was intended to accommodate AMU's growing collections and expanding digital resources, and it supported the construction of additional reading halls, computer laboratories, and storage facilities, in line with UGC's emphasis on accessibility and inclusivity. Special provisions were also made for differently-abled students, including ramps, rails, and dedicated toilets.

Consequently, a new library building adjacent to the old one was constructed at a cost of ₹5 crores. On 15 September 2016, the Digital Resources Centre (DRC) and the Oriental Division were formally inaugurated in this new building, marking a significant step in AMU's continuing journey toward modernisation and digital integration.

## 13. INFLIBNET's Role in M. A. Library: Digital Resources and services worth crores of rupees were made available free.

The year 2010–11 was a landmark period in expanding free access to digital resources and databases worth crores of rupees through the initiatives of the Information and Library Network (INFLIBNET) Centre, Gandhinagar, started by UGC in 1991 as a project and later made it an independent centre in 1996. INFLIBNET is a premier national agency committed to strengthening India's academic infrastructure by promoting digital access, resource sharing, and library networking. Its mission has been particularly focused on Central Universities, ensuring that faculty, researchers, and students benefit from affordable, seamless, and equitable access to scholarly content. In this way, INFLIBNET has played a pivotal role in modernising higher education, fostering research excellence, and bridging the digital divide across India's academic landscape.

The Director of INFLIBNET holds a position equivalent in stature to that of a Vice Chancellor of a Central University. Among its distinguished leaders, **Dr. Jagdish Arora** stands out for his longest and most impactful tenure (2007–2018), a period widely regarded as the zenith of the organization's growth. Under his visionary leadership, INFLIBNET consolidated its role as a national hub for digital resources, library networking, and scholarly communication. **Landmark initiatives such as the UGC-INFONET Digital Library Consortium, Shodhganga (Indian theses repository), and e-ShodhSindhu (journal access consortium)** were expanded and strengthened, ensuring equitable access to knowledge across Central Universities and other UGC-approved institutions. His tenure was marked by strategic planning, technological innovation, and a deep commitment to democratizing information,

elevating INFLIBNET to international recognition as a model of academic resource integration in the digital age.

In a National Seminar organized by the Maulana Azad Library in collaboration with the Department of Library and Information Science, Dr Jagdish Arora was invited as the Chief Guest of the Inaugural Function, where Prof. P. K. Abdul Azis, Vice Chancellor, honoured him for his **unmatched contributions to higher education in India** through the INFLIBNET Centre.

In his keynote address, Dr. Arora elaborated on the **importance of digital resources and the role of INFLIBNET** in ensuring equitable distribution of scholarly content. He also chaired one of the sessions, benefiting students, faculty, delegates, and library staff. Entrusted by the UGC, Dr. Arora oversaw the **selection of 60 universities** in India for access to premier e-resources. **AMU was among the chosen institutions**, receiving access to nearly **1,000 journals from ScienceDirect** collections and **908 Wiley online journals**, as communicated in his letter to the Vice Chancellor dated 31 December 2010. In acknowledgment, Prof. Abdul Azis conveyed his appreciation in a formal letter of thanks (D.No.657/VC Sect, dated 20 January 2011).

Beyond this, the Maulana Azad Library secured IP-based free access to **'Web of Science' (with 10 years' backup) worth ₹9 crores**, encompassing prestigious research tools such as the Science Citation Index (1961–), Social Science Citation Index (1966–), and Arts & Humanities Citation Index (1977–), published by the Institute for Scientific Information, Philadelphia, USA. Additional access was extended to ERMED Consortia, J-Gate, and BIOSIS. Notably, **ERMED provided AMU with 2,400 online journals in Health Sciences worth ₹7.5 crores**.

By the end of 2010, these services were operational, and in February 2011, the library was scheduled to receive **SciFinder Scholar** (American Chemical Society, Columbus, Ohio, USA), **valued at ₹20 lakhs (single-user license)**. This resource offered access to the world's largest and most comprehensive databases in Chemistry and related sciences.

A note from INFLIBNET clarified that these databases were provided only for one year, with renewal contingent upon usage statistics. Consequently, the Vice Chancellor issued a general directive to all Deans, Chairpersons, and research scholars, appreciating the Librarian-in-Charge's efforts and urging that it be made **"mandatory for each researcher to effect at least five downloads every day."**

However, with the tenure of Prof. Abdul Azis ending on 17 January 2012, and my own subsequent relief from the additional responsibility of Librarian-in-Charge to resume my substantive post as Professor and Chairman, Department of Library and Information Science, the **renewal of these free online databases and services worth crores of Rupees, to the best of my knowledge, could not be secured**.



# ALIGARH MUSLIM UNIVERSITY

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Res. 0571-2700087  
Email vcamu@amu.ac.in

**Prof. (Dr.) P.K. Abdul Azis**

Ph.D., D.Sc.  
Vice-Chancellor

By DAK

D.No. 657 /VC/Secc  
January 20, 2011

Dr. Jagdish Arora,  
Director,  
Information and Library Network Centre,  
P.O.B No. 4116, Navrangpura,  
Ahmedabad-380009.

Dear Dr. Jagdish Arora,

*Hearties greetings for a happy and prosperous new year 2011*

It has reference to your kind letter dated 31.12.2010 informing me about the inclusion of AMU amongst 60 eligible universities to have access to about 1000 online journals from Science Direct collections as well as 908 Wiley Online Journals. While appreciating your efforts in the overall development of information services provided by INFLIBNET to the universities in India, I particularly feel thankful to you for the provision of aforementioned all important full text databases for our university.

I wish and pray that through the efforts of INFLIBNET, the published output of scientific community in India in general and AMU in particular will greatly improve both in quantity and quality, thus bringing them at par with the best scientific institutions in the world.

With warm regards

**Prof. P.K. Abdul Azis**

✓ Copy to: The Librarian, Maulana Azad Library, AMU, Aligarh.

#### **14. Installation of OTIS lift/ Escalator**

The library lift serving the seven-storied stacks had remained non-functional for nearly ten years, causing considerable hardship for students and staff alike. This long-standing inconvenience was finally resolved through the timely intervention of Vice-Chancellor **Prof. P. K. Abdul Azis, who allocated ₹10 lakhs out of the savings of the financial year 2010–11.**

Equally vital was the **support of the Library Sub-Committee, chaired by Prof. M. Salimuddin**, whose members extended full cooperation. Together, we engaged with the OTIS offices in Bangalore and Lucknow, completing all formalities to ensure that the grant was effectively utilised before the close of the financial year.

This initiative not only restored a crucial facility but also symbolised the collective resolve of the administration under the leadership of Prof Azis, and library leadership to modernise infrastructure and improve accessibility for the academic community.

#### **15. Launching of the Library Website**

Until this point, the library's online presence had been subsumed within the University's official website. In the Library Committee meeting held on 22 December 2008 (Item 9[4]), members — led by Dr. Naushad Ali — strongly emphasised the need for an independent website dedicated to the Maulana Azad Library.

Responding to this call, the library's standalone website was successfully launched by the end of the financial year 2009–10, marking a significant step toward digital autonomy, enhanced visibility, and modernisation of library services.

This initiative not only strengthened the library's identity but also symbolised its growing role in embracing technology to serve the academic community more effectively.

#### **16. Dr. Masarrat Ali and Sir Syed's Digital Library Project**

Dr. Masarrat Ali was an accomplished Indian-American biochemist, entrepreneur, and community leader whose life journey reflected resilience and vision. Born in Jhansi, Uttar Pradesh, into a lower-middle-class family, he was the son of a local tailor. Through education he transformed his life, enrolling at Aligarh Muslim University in 1971, where he earned his B.Sc. in Chemistry in 1975 and an M.Sc. in Biochemistry in 1977, securing the University Gold Medal for ranking first in his class. He went on to complete his Ph.D. at the Central Drug Research Institute in Lucknow, followed by post-doctoral research in France, before moving to the United States in the mid-1980s to join Louisiana State University Medical Center. In 1994 he settled in San Antonio, Texas, and founded Alpha Diagnostic International Inc., a biotechnology company that achieved significant success. His corporate leadership was recognized with the Ronald Reagan Award for Best Businessman of the Year in 2005. Embodying the American dream, he also entered politics as a Democratic Party candidate in Texas during the 2010 election cycle, gaining attention as a first-generation immigrant

running for public office. Alongside his professional achievements, Dr. Ali remained deeply connected to his alma mater, co-founding and serving as President of the AMU Alumni Association of San Antonio and working actively with the Federation of Aligarh Alumni Associations. His philanthropy included funding smart classrooms for AMU's Department of Biochemistry and supporting the digital preservation of Sir Syed Ahmad Khan's historic works through [sirsyedtoday.com](http://sirsyedtoday.com). This initiative, known as Sir Syed's Digital Library, ensured that rare manuscripts, writings, and speeches of AMU's founder were preserved and made accessible to scholars and students worldwide. Dr. Masarrat Ali passed away in April 2017, leaving behind a legacy of scientific achievement, entrepreneurial success, community leadership, and cultural preservation, bridging continents and generations through his vision and service.

### **About the Sir Syed Today Project**

In early 2010, Dr. Masarrat Ali, an ardent admirer of Sir Syed Ahmad Khan and then President of the Federation of AMU Alumni Associations, USA, proposed to Vice Chancellor Prof. P.K. Abdul Azis the idea of developing a dedicated website, Sir Syed Today (<http://www.sirsyedtoday.org>), in collaboration with Aligarh Muslim University. Under his personal supervision, and with the assistance of a team of library staff led by the Librarian, the digitization of Sir Syed's collection was undertaken with remarkable speed. Despite his demanding schedule in the United States, Dr. Ali set an ambitious target of completing the work within a week. He brought high-quality scanners from the U.S., and the digitization was carried out round the clock in the allotted suite of the University Old Guest House. The project was successfully accomplished and preserved on a set of 36 CDs to ensure a permanent record. By the time the website was developed, Dr. Ali returned to Aligarh to launch it on 29 April 2010 in a grand function held at the Cultural Hall of the Maulana Azad Library. The event was presided over by the Vice Chancellor, with Dr. Ali as the Chief Guest and Registrar Prof. P.K. Abdul Jalil as Guest of Honour, marking a historic step in preserving and sharing Sir Syed's intellectual legacy in digital form.

### **[www.sirsyedtoday.org](http://www.sirsyedtoday.org)**

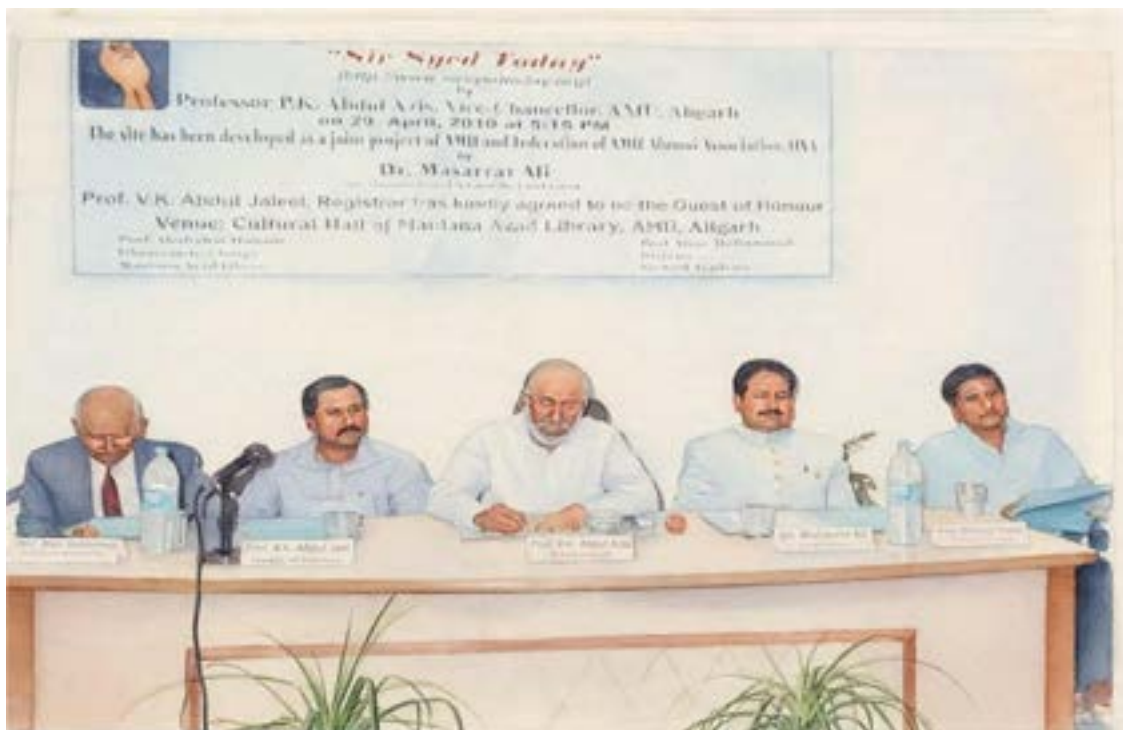
The portal ([www.sirsyedtoday.org](http://www.sirsyedtoday.org)) was a monumental digitization initiative launched at Aligarh Muslim University (AMU).

The project was formally unveiled in the Central Hall of the Maulana Azad Library by the Federation of Aligarh Alumni Associations (FAAA) in collaboration with AMU, under the leadership of Vice Chancellor Prof. P.K. Abdul Azis. Conceived and designed by AMU alumnus Dr. Masarrat Ali, it was widely recognized as the largest digital archiving project in India dedicated to a single individual or institution at the time of its release. The portal hosted an extraordinary archive of more than 110,000 pages of historical documents, including over 45,000 pages of the Aligarh Institute Gazette and 5,000 pages of Tehzibul Akhlaq. Its primary vision was to freely digitize and democratize access to the complete literary works, books, pamphlets, and educational conference

records authored by or focused on Sir Syed Ahmad Khan, thereby opening them to scholars and researchers worldwide.

### Operational Status & Legacy

The original standalone domain '[www.sirsyedtoday.org](http://www.sirsyedtoday.org)' is no longer active as an independent repository. Over time, due to infrastructure and hosting transitions, most of the digitised records and manuscripts were absorbed into AMU's decentralised systems. The site functioned effectively until 2017, the year of Dr Masarrat Ali's passing and my own superannuation. Regrettably, the library administration did not assume responsibility for sustaining the portal or relaunching it, despite the fact that the complete digitised collection remains preserved on 36 CDs. Had the administration taken the initiative, the invaluable resource could have continued to serve as a living digital monument to Sir Syed's intellectual legacy.







Releasing CDs of [www.sirsyedtoday.org](http://www.sirsyedtoday.org)



Jhony Foster and his team after presenting Library Tarana



## **17. Appointments and Promotions for Library Staff**

**For nearly two decades, the nagging problem of library staff appointments persisted under a regime of ad hocism. No selection committees were convened for either appointments or promotions,** and some staff retired without receiving their due promotion for more than a decade. At least twenty library professionals were engaged on fixed salaries, while scores of others continued as temporary or ad hoc employees. The situation was even more precarious for fourth-grade staff, many of whom worked as daily wagers — skilled and unskilled — on fixed pay. An anomaly arose when, after salary revisions, those in lower positions began drawing more pay than highly qualified professionals serving on contractual terms.

I apprised the Vice Chancellor of this distortion, and not only was the error rectified, but I also impressed upon him the extent to which appointments and promotions had been unjustly delayed. As a result, the long-neglected process of convening selection committees for library staff was finally initiated. Unfortunately, this long-awaited reform reached completion only after the departure of Prof. P. K. Abdul Azis as Vice Chancellor. With the approval of the Acting Vice Chancellor, the following selection committees were convened in the first week of March 2012:

- Deputy Librarian: 1 + 1 (Non-PhD; only grade awarded)
- Assistant Librarians: 5
- Professional Assistants: 20
- Semi-Professional Assistants: 36

Working candidates who couldn't be appointed in the above lists were duly accommodated against future vacancies.

OFFICE OF THE REGISTRAR  
(ADMINISTRATION SECTION)  
ALIGARH MUSLIM UNIVERSITY  
ALIGARH

Dated: 03.03.2012

OFFICE MEMO

On the recommendation of the General Selection Committee, the Vice-Chancellor has approved the appointment of the following as **Professional Assistant** in the Pay Band of Rs. 9,300-34,800 with Grade Pay Rs. 4200 plus allowances as admissible under the rules:-

- |     |                             |
|-----|-----------------------------|
| 1.  | Ms. Zia Fatima              |
| 2.  | Mr. Burayd Ali Khan         |
| 3.  | Mr. Mujahid Ali Khan        |
| 4.  | Ms. Babu Musawir            |
| 5.  | Mr. Mohd. Salman Majid      |
| 6.  | Mr. Parvez Alam             |
| 7.  | Mr. Mohammad Khalid Siddiqi |
| 8.  | Mr. Shariq Ahmad            |
| 9.  | Mr. Najmi Shahzad           |
| 10. | Mr. Syed Anis Ahmad         |
| 11. | Mrs. Asma Khan              |
| 12. | Mr. Has Muddin Khan         |
| 13. | Mr. Mohammad Akram          |
| 14. | Mrs. Tasneem Firdaus Zaidi  |
| 15. | Mr. Javed Akhtar Khan       |
| 16. | Mr. Syed Ali Raza-Naqvi     |
| 17. | Ms. Saba Nasreen Bano       |
| 18. | Mr. Asad Husain Siddiqui    |
| 19. | Ms. Niha Musarrat Husain    |
| 20. | Mr. Rakesh Babu Sharma      |

On probation for a period of one year  
with effect from the date they join  
their duties

Temporary and be placed on  
probation as and when lien free  
vacancy will be available.

The candidates at Sr. No. 4, 13, 16, 17, 18, 19 and 20 will be governed by the newly Defined Contribution Pension Scheme as adopted and implemented by the University vide Office Memo No.(C)/148 dated 08.02.2005.

They are however, required to furnish details of their past services on the prescribed proforma obtained from Registrar's Office for the purpose of retirement benefits, if any.

Under the University rules, they are also required to produce a Physical Fitness Certificate from a Registered Medical Graduate not below the rank of a Civil Surgeon or from the Chief Medical Officer, University Health Service, AMU, at the time of their confirmation.

Under the General directives of Executive Council, the candidates at S.No. 16 to 20 are also required to join their duties within four months from the date of issue of this office letter, failing which, offer of appointment will be cancelled.

Posting orders will be issued separately.

(Dr. Salik A. Siddiqui)  
Assistant Registrar  
(Administration -NT)

Contd... 2

Dated: 1.03.2012

OFFICE MEMO

On the recommendation of the General Selection Committee, the Vice-Chancellor has approved the appointment of the following as Semi Professional in the Pay Band of Rs. 6200-20200/- with a basic pay of Rs. 2000/- plus allowances as admissible under the rules.

| S.No. | Name                   |
|-------|------------------------|
| 1     | Mr. Bahari Dhar Sharma |
| 2     | Mrs. Rubina Anis       |
| 3     | Mr. Rameez Khan Bhatti |
| 4     | Mr. Mohd. Moazzam Khan |
| 5     | Mr. Abid Hussain       |
| 6     | Mrs. Zeba Nageen       |
| 7     | Mr. Sadatuddin         |
| 8     | Mrs. Raichshanda Rizvi |
| 9     | Mr. Ishaq Ahmad        |
| 10    | Mr. Mohd. Iqbal Ahmad  |
| 11    | Mr. Mujahidul Muhi     |
| 12    | Mr. Rais Ahmad Qasim   |
| 13    | Mr. Afsar Mushtaque    |
| 14    | Mr. Farrukh Latif      |
| 15    | Mr. Wahid ur Rehman    |
| 16    | Mr. Nadeemul Haque     |
| 17    | Mr. Shafiqul Hasan     |
| 18    | Mr. S. Javed Ahmed     |
| 19    | Mr. Iqbal Ahmad        |
| 20    | Mr. Nadeem Ahmad       |
| 21    | Mr. Mohammad Asaf      |
| 22    | Mr. Mohd. Nafees       |
| 23    | Mrs. Zabi Noor         |
| 24    | Mr. Syed Gul Hasan     |
| 25    | Mr. Javed Nadeem       |

On probation for a period of one year with effect from the date they join their duties.

|    |                           |
|----|---------------------------|
| 26 | Mr. Farhan Nihal          |
| 27 | Mr. Mohammad Azim         |
| 28 | Mrs. Surayya Ghaffar      |
| 29 | Ms. Mohsina Farooq        |
| 30 | Mrs. Sana Sherwana        |
| 31 | Mr. Rao Ashraf Kamal Wani |
| 32 | Mr. Abdul Wadood          |
| 33 | Ms. Imrana Zahra Jafri    |
| 34 | Mr. Shamim Ahmad          |
| 35 | Mr. Mazhar Ali Khan       |
| 36 | Ms. Shabana Qadeer        |

Temporary and be placed on probation for one year. When free vacancy will be available.

The candidates at Sr. No. 4 to 36 will be governed by the newly Defined Civil Service Scheme as adopted and implemented by the University vide Office Memo No. 10/11-2 (19/12/2011).

They are, however, required to furnish details of their past services on the form prescribed and obtained from Registrar's Office for the purpose of retirement benefits, if any.

Under the University rules, they are also required to produce a Physical Fitness Certificate from a Registered Medical Graduate not below the rank of a Civil Surgeon or from the Civil Surgeon, University Health Service, AMU, at the time of their confirmation.

Under the General directives of Executive Council they are also required to join their duties within four months from the date of issue of this office letter, failing which, offer of appointment will be withdrawn.

Posting orders will be issued separately.

Approved: \_\_\_\_\_  
Admin. Officer

*[Signature]*

## 18. Overall impact of modernisation of the library

### ➤ Reading Halls

One of the most striking transformations was the removal of the **industrial look** created by large air-conditioning ducts in all five Reading Rooms. Although the AC system had been installed nearly a decade earlier, no one had considered adding false ceilings with LED lighting to enhance the aesthetic appeal. Undertaken in phases despite the expense, this initiative gave the halls a modern, elegant, congenial atmosphere, drawing more students to the library, as confirmed by the **recorded footfall as shown by the Automatic Security Gate's counter**.

With the rise of mobile usage inside the library, manual checks proved ineffective. To maintain discipline, **mobile jammers were installed in the Reading Rooms and Central Hall**, ensuring a focused study environment.

### ➤ Library Auditorium

Equally remarkable was the **complete turnaround of the Library Auditorium**. POP work on arches and pillars, combined with a white-pink colour scheme and a red carpet, transformed the hall during the very first year — a change that even surprised **Prof. P. K. Abdul Azis**. In preparation for the Golden Jubilee celebrations, **Mr. Asif Ali Khan, the devoted Caretaker with his unbounded love for the alma mater**, mobilised labour to work late into the night, personally arranging their dinners and tea from his own pocket so long as work of POP continued. **His dedication gave the hall a grandeur that soon made it one of the most sought-after venues**, with organisers willingly paying a maintenance charge for its use.

### An interesting anecdote

At the very first function of the Library's Golden Jubilee, held in the newly renovated Cultural Hall with its light pink walls and red-carpet combination, the Vice Chancellor — who was to preside — entered and asked me in surprise:

**“Where have I come? Is this the same Cultural Hall of the Library?”**

I modestly replied, **“Yes, Sir.”**

He then asked, **“Who gave you money for this? I didn't.”**

To which I retorted with humility, **“Allah gave me money.”**

**Delighted with the transformation, the Vice-Chancellor, in his address, heaped praise upon me. In my speech, however, I attributed the success to the moral support of my wife, who was present in the gathering with my daughter. After the function, Prof. P. K. Abdul Azis personally thanked my wife for her support and graciously invited us to the Vice Chancellor's Lodge for a sumptuous treat — a gesture of warmth and respect that my family will always cherish.**





### ➤ “Thought of the Day” Board

To foster intellectual engagement of the students, a **“Thought of the Day”** board was introduced, supported by a suggestion box. Submissions by the students put in the box, were graciously reviewed daily by my elderly friend, Retd. **Sessions Judge Mr. Khusro**, who selected one idea to display along with the student’s name and class on a daily basis. This simple gesture nurtured a culture of participation and community spirit. The impact was so profound that MBA final-year students interviewed me about the administrative style behind such spectacular changes, while Hall leaders invited me as Chief Guest or Guest of Honour at their Hall functions.

Another persistent challenge was the unsightly **heap of students’ shoulder bags in the Outer Hall**, since bags were not permitted inside the library. To resolve this, I commissioned **a wooden reception-cum-property counter in a nicely crafted curved shape with 100 compartments and a token system**, positioned at the right side of the main entrance. Adorned with a wooden backdrop featuring the University Monogram and the inscription **Maulana Azad Library, Aligarh Muslim University, Aligarh** in white deco paint, the arrangement bestowed the entrance hall with a five-star dignity, elevating the library’s stature in the eyes of students and faculty alike.

### ➤ Dismantling Drive

Regrettably, after I relinquished charge, not only were those colleagues — including my steadfast supporter, Mr. Asif Ali Khan, Caretaker — who had immensely contributed to the library's development transferred elsewhere, but even the elegantly curved reception desk was dismantled and shifted to the Cycle Stand, where it has since functioned merely as a property counter. Today, only the back panel affixed to the wall remains. As a consequence, students in haste often bypass the cycle stand and continue piling their bags in the outer hall, thereby eroding both the aesthetic appeal and the functional order that had once been carefully established.

Although I formally assumed charge of the library on 25-09-2008, changes continued to unfold consistently throughout my four-year tenure as Librarian-in-Charge. Among the most notable was the inauguration of the **Digital Resource Centre, CCTV system, and Campus-wide Online Catalogue**, carried out by **Prof. P. K. Abdul Azis, Vice Chancellor, on 16 March 2009**, with a commemorative plaque installed in the Outer Hall of the Library. Owing to paucity of time, the engraver could not inscribe my name on the plaque; instead, it was written in paint — a fragile substitute that was easily erased, as indeed happened after I left the chair of Librarian.

دنیا کے ستم یاد نہ اپنی ہی وفا یاد

اب مجھ کو نہیں کچھ بھی محبت کے سوا یاد



**Remaining part of the Reception cum Property counter**



## 19. Conclusion

Administrators — whether Vice Chancellors, University Librarians, or Heads of Departments — will inevitably change with time. Yet, the good work for the institution must continue, especially where professional decisions are involved in a gigantic institution like the Maulana Azad Library.

It is in this spirit that I wish to reiterate the following, urging reflection and corrective measures:

### 1. Tenure and Halted Projects

My tenure, though brief—spanning just four years (25-09-2008 to 20-06-2012)—was marked by significant strides toward **modernising the library**. Yet, its abrupt conclusion brought about a **shift in leadership**, which unfortunately led to the halting of several ongoing projects.

The following initiatives, to the best of my knowledge, **have not been revived to date**, leaving behind unfinished milestones that could have further transformed the academic and cultural landscape of the institution.

### Key Projects Awaiting Revival

- **Publication of Rare Manuscript :Nahjul Blagha**

1000 copies published under an MOU between AMU and the Government of Iran (via Iran Cultural Councillor, New Delhi) remain sealed in cartons in the Manuscripts Division for the last 14 years.

Action is needed to release them and create a corpus fund for publishing other rare manuscripts, ensuring global access to the knowledge contained in them.

- **Relaunching of the website: [www.sirsyedtoday.org](http://www.sirsyedtoday.org)**

As the contents of the website are already preserved in 36 CDs available in the library, this site may be relaunched, marking a historic step in preserving and sharing Sir Syed's intellectual legacy in digital form.

- **National Archives Grant Renewal**

A **grant of ₹20 lakhs** for manuscripts' preservation and conservation with temperature and humidity control equipment should be revived and utilised.

- **Preservation of Artefacts**

Treasures of Manuscripts Division, such as **hundreds of medieval coins** in a well-decorated rosewood case, remain insecure until accessioned, catalogued, and preserved.

- **Restoration of remaining dilapidated manuscripts**

Urgent conservation work is required for the remaining manuscripts that continue to deteriorate.

- **Systematic Weeding of Obsolete Books**

Thousands of outdated volumes dumped on the 7th floor (East) and other floors of stacks need systematic removal.

- **INFLIBNET E-Resources Renewal**

Attempts should be made to renew the databases worth crores, made accessible to AMU by INFLIBNET during my tenure, to restore scholarly access.

## **2. Correction in Library Stacks:**

**I present here only the latest picture of the stacks**, inviting reflection by both library administrators and professionals, as well as by those general readers who sincerely wish this invaluable institution to endure and flourish. The image is not merely a record of the present state but a call to action — a reminder that the survival of the library depends upon thoughtful stewardship, professional integrity, and collective responsibility.

|                                                               |      |               |      |                                                                                                                         |
|---------------------------------------------------------------|------|---------------|------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Discarded books/Newspapers</i>                             | East | ← VII Floor → | West | Bound Journals                                                                                                          |
| <i>Old Volumes of Periodicals (No research Value)</i>         | "    | ← VI Floor →  | "    | Old Reference Books                                                                                                     |
| <i>Census /Donated Books</i>                                  | "    | ← V Floor →   | "    | Reserved Books collection                                                                                               |
| <i>Bound Newspapers Database of newspapers available free</i> | "    | ← IV Floor →  | "    | <i>Hindi and Sanskrit Reading Room and Stacks</i><br>(May be restored to its original location, in old or new building) |
| <i>English books arranged subject-wise 823-999</i>            | "    | ← III Floor → | "    | <i>English books arranged subject-wise 370-822.9</i>                                                                    |
| <i>Locked Junk Yard of old machines etc, unused books</i>     | "    | ← II Floor →  | "    | <i>English books arranged subject-wise 000-369</i>                                                                      |
| <i>Wall</i>                                                   | "    | ← I Floor →   | "    | <i>Hindi Textbooks/ Urdu General Books (Subject-wise Arrangement 000-999)</i>                                           |

Equally pressing is the need to embrace the technological transformation of the library, ensuring the effective implementation of RFID, Artificial Intelligence, and Robotics. These innovations are no longer optional but essential for libraries seeking to remain relevant in the digital age.

### 3. Social Science Cyber Library — Achievements & Challenges

It may be noted that **significant strides in the modernisation of the M.A. Library** were achieved within a short span of **four years (25-09-2008 to 20-06-2012)**. These efforts had a **profoundly positive impact on the student community**, transforming both the academic environment and the cultural spirit of the library.

Yet, despite these successes, **a few discontented colleagues** worked persistently to bring about a change in the top library management. Their efforts succeeded as soon as the new regime assumed charge. While they were celebrating what they perceived as victory, they could not foresee what Almighty had destined for me.

The true turning point came when **His Excellency Shri Pranab Mukherjee, President of India**, in the presence of **Lt. Gen. Zamiruddin Shah, Vice-Chancellor**, inaugurated the **world's first Social Science Cyber Library** in a grand ceremony at Kennedy Hall Auditorium on 27 December 2013.

Designed and developed under my leadership as Dean, Faculty of Social Sciences, the Cybrary quickly earned global recognition:

- ISO 9001:2008 Certification (2015)
- Limca Book of Records (2017)
- Accessed today by social scientists, researchers, and students in 176 countries worldwide

***Yet, regrettably, no technological innovation has been added since my retirement in 2017. Without modernisation, this pioneering initiative — once the pride of our institution — risks becoming outdated and losing relevance in the fast-moving digital era.***

Nevertheless, this achievement stands as a testament to the enduring vision of academic innovation, proving that true success is shaped not by opposition, but by perseverance and divine will.

**It reminds me of a famous couplet by Basheer Badr:**

پتھر کے جگر والو غم میں وہ روانی ہے

خود راہ بنا لے گا بہتا ہوا پانی ہے

**Above all, what the Quran prescribes:**

**Surah Aal-Imran, Verse 26 (3:26)**

وَنُعِزُّ مَنْ نَّشَاءُ وَنُذِلُّ مَنْ نَّشَاءُ

**Meaning:** "And You honor whom You will, and You disgrace whom You will."

